

In no particular place, at no particular time, an old man toiled in front of a desk. Tanned, leathery skin had wood in one hand, a knife in the other, methodically whittling something into shape. The methodical sound of steel carving through wood paused ever so often, the man blowing excess wood chips away and studying his work. Then he would continue.

The whittling continued throughout the night. Illuminated by the stars and the moons, the man needed nothing else to guide him.

He stopped. He listened.

The softest breeze walked beside his cottage. Further still, winds whipped over a cliff face, down towards a shore where soft waves broke upon white sand.

The old man stood up with a start, knocking his chair back. He left his tools and his project on his desk and stumbled out of his workshop into his living room, then to the front door. He rested his hand on the knob and waited.

He took a deep breath. Through the closed door, he knew some certainties. Ahead of him, a forest. To his right, the mountain. To his left, his lighthouse. And behind him and his cottage, the ocean shore.

"Daddy, daddy!" A young girl's voice broke his stupor. "I'm home!"

The old man stood a little straighter, opened his eyes a little wider, and forced the contours of his face into a reassuring smile. He opened the door.

"Welcome back, little one," her father greeted her. She was half his size, with

wine-dark hair the seemed black in the moonlight. Her clothes were dirty and threadbare, with dirt clumps and branches stuck to her in odd places. He knelt down to match her height, picking out the branches and brushing away the dirt as he did. "Did you have fun out there?"

"Yeah!" She beamed. "I went to the mountain again! There were some bugs on the way, but I lost my bag and couldn't bring them back. There was a big bird too! It looked at me funny but I scared it off!"

"Ok, ok," her father returned her smile and finished dusting her off. "Let's get you cleaned up. You can tell me how you scared the bird and the rest of your adventures on the bath."

"Do I have to?" She faked a yawn. "I'm really tired."

"Well you're certainly not going to bed as filthy as you are," He stood, holding her hand as he led his daughter to the side of the cottage. He had set up a tub there, with a well a little ways away.

The girl hummed to herself as her father drew some water from the well. Once he had a bucket full, he brought it back and set it down next to the girl.

She stuck her finger in and shook her head. "Daddy, it's too cold."

"Oh sorry miss, here," he thought for a moment and then snapped his fingers. The water steamed and then boiled.

"Daddy, now it's too hot," she giggled.

"Oh is it? My mistake," he tapped his head, earning another giggle. With another snap of his fingers, the water turned a

comfortable warm.

She raised her arms in the air.

"Come on miss, you can undress yourself."

"I want daddy to do it!"

He rolled his eyes yet acquiesced to the young girl regardless. He bathed her as she talked about her adventure through the forest. Going to the mountains and back again, finding a river and following it for awhile. She wanted to try her hand at fishing but couldn't find a fishing rod before she got bored and kept going.

"And you know," she continued as her father dried her. "I also found this weird rock!"

"Oh yeah?"

"Yeah! It had my name on it!"

The old man paused. Just as quickly, he finished drying her. "Really?"

"Really!"

He dressed her in night clothes, keeping his breathing even. Any moment now, she was going to ask a very difficult question.

"Do we have other bags?" she asked. Not the question he was expecting.

"Sure we do," he said, picking her up. "What kinds are you looking for."

"I want one where I could put cool bugs in without them fighting."

"I'll make you one, don't worry about it," he said.

"Ok," she happily rested her head on his shoulder while he carried her into the cottage.

He lit some candles on the way to her

room, illuminating the dark with soft candlelight. He would have to make replacements soon - these were down to almost a quarter of their wick.

Setting her down in a bed that was entirely too big for her, the old man tucked the girl in.

"Daddy, will you tell me a bedtime story?"

"A bedtime story?" He ran his hand through his hair in thought. "Would you like me to tell you about Ashen again?"

"You always talk about Ashen," she whined.

"I guess you're right. What kind of story would you want then?"

"I want one with magic and witches!"

"Magic and witches? Sorry to say miss, but Ashen's got both of those."

"What?" Her eyes widened.

"It's ok, this one's more about the witch than it is about Ashen," he chuckled.

"I guess that's fine..." She tried to hide her disappointment.

"It'll be good, I promise," he tapped her on the head and sat down. "Let's see, let's see. Where should I start?"

"You should start at the beginning! That's where all stories start Daddy!"

"A good idea as any," he cleared his throat and began. "This story doesn't start in Ashen."

"Really?"

"Yes, really. It starts in an unnamed village. A girl, much like yourself, was traveling alone and found herself in that

village."

"Is she pretty like me?"

"She was very pretty, but not as pretty as you, little miss. She had blonde hair, with brown skin and simple traveler's clothes. Her eyes were a deep verdant green. And she knew special magic. Special witch magic."

"Daddy, what's the difference between normal magic and witch magic?"

"The same difference between all magic - it depends on who is casting it. In this case, our heroine knew witch magic because her mother was a witch."

"Woah!"

"Yes, and she had sisters as well. They were also witches."

"A big witch family!"

"Exactly."

"But then... why is she alone?"

"Why indeed. Before I answer that for you, do you want to give her a name?"

"I can name her?"

"Of course you can."

"Hmmm," The girl lay in silence, lost in thought. After some time, she answered, "How about 'Nettle?'"

"A fine name," her father nodded.

"Nettle starts her story in an unnamed village. She was looking for something or maybe, someone. After asking around the village, she took a break outside of town. She had been traveling for quite some time and wanted to sit under the shade of a tree and feel the wind in her hair. A simple reprieve for what was about to happen. It would be the last she would

have for awhile."

It was afternoon when Nettle woke from her nap. The tree she rested under had it's branches swaying in the wind, the sun starting to catch her from underneath it's shade. It has been a couple hard days from traveling from the Southern reaches of Von and her exhaustion had taken her for a spell.

She was disappointed at not finding her mark, but a part of her was also relieved. She didn't know what she would do if she found what she was looking for.

As Nettle stretched, someone in the branches caught her eye. A young boy, younger than her, was resting on the branches. He watched her, she watched him. Then he jumped out of the tree and ran back towards the village.

Nettle sighed to herself and got up, dusting herself off.

"Where to next?" She asked herself. Just as she was about to pick a direction and go, a sudden unease struck her.

In seconds, the sky turned red and a streak carved itself from the heavens and crashed into the village in front of her. The air burned as the village did and Nettle's heart dropped to her stomach.

"No, no, no," she pleaded, breaking out into a run. She had found what she was looking for - only, it found something else first.

Nettle ran into the village, most of it already burning. There wasn't time to check for survivors, nor was there time to stop the flame. She had to find the source before it was too late.

When she traversed the whole of the

village without finding her quarry, Nettle took a deep breath and closed her eyes. It couldn't have gotten far. She sensed, not with her physical senses, but with her magical ones. She looked for magic and found the source already leaving.

Nettle looked at the village, towards the source, then at the village one more time. Buried under some burning rubble was the boy that was watching her from the tree. She ran for the boy.

With no regard for subtlety, she called for magic and magic answered her. She blasted away fire and rubble. The boy was still alive, but barely. Calling for more magic, she stabilized him, gifting the boy vitality before drawing a protective circle around him.

"Stay safe," she prayed for him. Then, Nettle felt for the source of the flame. She found it speed towards the setting sun, towards the west. It was growing fainter.

Nettle breathed deep as she ran westward. She needed more speed. She called for more magic. Her steps lifted her off the ground until she wasn't running anymore. She flew through the air, following a flaming trail. Yet no matter how much magic she called for, the flame only dimmed in her senses.

Her focus broke before her magic did, Nettle tumbling back to the ground as she lost her tracking.

Rolling to a stop, Nettle laid in place as the crackling of flames died to a smolder.

"Too slow again," She cursed to

herself. "I will find you, sister. And I will stop you."

She pulled herself together and limped out of the smoldering path. She had some cuts and bruises from the landing and some burns where she flew through open flame.

When the sound of crackling flames was distant, she found herself surrounded by trees and foliage. A hand on one of them, Nettle collapsed and breathed deep. Each wound stung and pulsed.

"I'm sorry," She whispered. The magic within her was tapped. So instead of pulling the magic from within, she pulled it from without. Feeling the life course through her hands from the tree to herself, her wounds healed and her hurts stopped.

Above her, the leaves that were once green and full had turned orange and red. They fell as the branches decayed.

Nettle cursed herself. She was never good at this particular trick, taking more than she should have and unable to take full advantage of the energy she took.

With unearned vigor, Nettle retraced her steps back to the village. She flew pretty far, far enough that she wouldn't see the charred remains until the morning of the next day.

To a village like this one, they wouldn't be able to stave off a bandit attack. Monster and beasts would have also been dangerous. To any sort of magic, they wouldn't have had any chance. Not a single building stood; wood was charred to cinders and even stone foundations were turned to molten rock.

Nettle went to the protective circle. The boy she kept safe within was no longer to be found. Perhaps he managed to find some safety. Perhaps not. Nettle couldn't dwell on that, instead searching through the village for other survivors.

There were none, of course. She had made that decision early when she chose to chase down the flame as opposed to making sure everyone was ok. Even the boy was just low hanging fruit. Once more, Nettle cursed herself.

In the ruins of the village, she couldn't help but collapse yet again.

It wasn't the first time she came across a scene like this. She had hoped that she'd be fast enough to stop it. But in her heart, Nettle knew that it would not be the last either. She needed to be stronger. She needed to be faster. She needed to be more resilient. She needs to be more than what she is.

Nettle gathered the remains of her already shaky resolve.

Once she confirmed there was nothing left, she doubled back to the trail of fire. Even if the flames have gotten cold, this was the only path left to her.

This was Nettle's life for the next five years. Find a hint of flame, be late to cinders, maybe find one survivor, then move on.

In more ways than one, Nettle has grown. With age comes experience, her skills improving. No longer does she take too much magic from the plants around her. Her flight comes easier, something she can hold almost indefinitely.

In her travels across the land, she mapped out the incidents and the frequency. It starts from the south, but then it would travel north. Repeated incidents would happen in a line, carving a path northwest, northeast, or so on. This was something she knew, something she tried to follow.

Despite her own skills growing, her sister has not been idle either. The incidents were more frequent, happening at opposite sides of land. Sometimes at the same time.

Nettle could only draw one conclusion; her sister is fragmenting portions of her power and sending the flames off. She didn't know the purpose of the wanton destruction.

Once Nettle figured out these were fragments and not actually her sister, Nettle tried to fight the problem from the source. On the southern most reaches, through perilous mountains, was a castle that her sister called home. One attempt of storming that fortress was met with flames buffeting her for every step. A second attempt was met with a barrier she could not breach.

There was a third attempt, of that Nettle was sure. But she could not remember it aside from waking up burnt and broken. Recovery was hard after that, but recovery did happen. And now, Nettle was sitting atop a ridge, with the castle behind her and the world in front of her. Every so often, another gout of flame would burst from the castle. It coalesced into a ball, then shot into the sky with

breaking speed.

Even at Nettle's fastest, it takes all of her strength to keep pace with the flame. Not a chance she could catch up. And not a chance she would even be ready for a fight if it came down to it. Not to mention she couldn't be two places at once either.

But if she could be in two places at once...

Nettle can't fragment herself like her sister does. Learning how would take too long.

She needed help. She needs help. Nettle pulled out her map again. At the very center of it, was a city untouched by flame.

Well, untouched would be the wrong word. She had certainly seen flame approach the city, but they were always quenched before even entering the city properly. They could handle it.

The city of Ashen. A city where the best and brightest arrive and push each other to the greatest heights.

At her mother's warning, Nettle steered clear of the city.

"They don't take kindly to our types," her mother had told her once. When Nettle was curious and asked why, she followed up with, "To be more specific, they don't take kindly to me. They'll hate you by association, so do be careful if you plan to visit."

Nettle jumped off the ridge and flew towards the city. She didn't know how she was going to get help from there. But that was what she needed.

At first, Nettle was worried that she'd be outed as a Witch right away. She stopped flying more than two days away on foot. She modified her clothes to simple traveler's garb, with an additional cloak for the hard weather.

What else did a traveler need? A weapon. With magic, she crafted herself a dagger and kept it at her side. With her preparations complete, Nettle started a ritual and sealed most of her magic away. If Ashen was as dangerous as her mother said it was, then they absolutely cannot find that connection.

Nettle traveled on foot towards the city. It was easy to spot, built beside the largest mountain - Mount Alchaic. It wasn't always a mountain - it used to be a volcano, her mother had told her such, yet no more than that. From hearsay and legends, they say Ashen was built not long after the volcano erupted, burying a previous city underneath. That was the extent of what Nettle knew, but hopefully she didn't need to know any more than that.

Upon approaching major roads, Nettle saw that there were scores of people who were also walking to Ashen. Travelers, much like her. However, unlike her, they were far more worn. Threadbare clothes. Grimy and tired. Some had exposed burns that they pushed through.

It occurred to Nettle, then, that maybe more people survived the incidents than she thought. That would be a better alternative. She hoped it were the case.

Snaking her way through the crowds of

people, Nettle wanted no attention drawn to herself. It became easier as Nettle approached the city - the procession grew more and more as everyone converged to a single point.

Surrounding Ashen were long stretches of farmland. Some plots had multiple people doing manual labor. Other plots had a singular person working magic across it. Nettle saw various types of cattle roaming around, a rancher flying in the sky to keep track of them all.

"Do you think we can get work in the fields?" One of the travelers asked.

"If we're lucky. I can't do magic like that."

"There's some of them not doing magic though."

"I hope they can teach me magic,"
Another chimed.

"They can't teach what you don't have."

"I do have magic though!"

"Oh yeah? Show me!"

A sparkle of fireworks came through the crowd. With the city proper on the horizon, Nettle felt spirits lift just a little.

Then, there was an unmistakable feeling. Nettle whipped her head back south just in time to see flame streak across the sky.

The crowd held their breaths as fire crossed ahead of them into Ashen. Children began to cry, their parents trying to reassure them everything will be alright.

The flames crashed into an invisible barrier, magic vibrating through the air.

Nettle held her breath. At this point, fire would rapidly spread and coalesce into a new flame, feeding off of itself. But even as fire ripped through the air and the barrier, several dots appeared in the air, fighting the flame and extinguishing the threat.

Within moments, the situation was handled and a hush fell upon the crowd.

"We'll be safe there," that affirmation rippled through everyone as someone spoke something that was on everyone's mind.

Nettle herself found herself smiling with them. It was the first smile after a long time of failure. If Nettle could find herself allies here, maybe that would be enough.

The procession slowed and then split into lines as they approached the gate. A checkpoint to vet everyone coming into the city.

"All refugees, please be ready to answer questions and provide a drop of your blood for our records. If you are magical, please find yourself at the rightmost line for our scan," someone flew over the rest and began speaking to the crowd and providing instructions.

A murmur went through the crowd.

"Rest assured, this is for the safety of yourself and for Ashen," they continued, then repeated their instructions up and down the crowd as needed.

Nettle pulled her hood up and moved to the right side of the gate, waiting her turn.

A fight broke out.

"What do you mean my son can't come in?"

"I'm sorry, sir, but your son is too aether-sick to come within city limits."

"That's the whole point! We need your healers to get him better!"

"I understand sir, but we have so many refugees as is. We can't risk an outbreak at this point."

"That's a load of crap, I'm taking my boy in there whether--"

Nettle took her spot in line before things turned ugly. The officer in front of her was armored head to toe in shining, silver metal.

"Ok, ma'am, if you can answer some questions for us we'll have you on your way, understood?"

"Understood," Nettle nodded.

"Excellent, first your name please."

"Nettle."

"First and last?"

"Just Nettle."

"Ok Just Nettle," the officer chuckled a little at their own joke. "What brings you to Ashen?"

"My village burned down, I was hoping I can start a new life here," Nettle said.

"Refugee like the rest eh?" the officer didn't say that accusingly. Just routine. "Good enough reason as any. Ok, now you're on the magic line. Can you show us your proficiency."

Nettle nodded and raised her hands out. She focused for a moment but then realized; the ritual made it significantly harder to cast magic. She furrowed his

brow.

"Excuse me, ma'am, are you sure you belong on the magic line?"

"It's been a hard couple of days," Nettle spoke without thinking, trying to buy time and rout some semblance of magic. With a large mark of effort she managed to conjure a brief spark.

"Hm," the officer studied Nettle. "Well, you've got magic in you, that's for sure. Why not, we've accepted less."

Nettle sighed in relief and nodded.

"Just one more thing," the officer produced a stone that came to a point, much like a cone. "As you might have heard is that we need a drop of your blood for our records. If you refuse, which is well within your rights, you will not be allowed within the city. We solemnly swear that your blood will not be used for nefarious ritual purposes, blah blah blah. If you are a known criminal, I will arrest you on the spot. Understood?"

Nettle nodded, but there was a sudden thought. Her mother was not in Ashen's good graces. If this is how they find out Nettle was related to her, it might blow things up before she had a chance to start.

"Please place your finger on this point whenever you're ready."

Nettle took a deep breath. Oh well. She placed her finger onto the point of the stone, pressing just light enough to draw a little blood.

The stone lit up and made a thrumming sound. It turned green.

"Welcome to Ashen, Just Nettle," the

officer nodded and gestured her to go past the gate. "Next!"

Nettled nodded at them and walked past the gate, relieved to go through without any issues. She flexed the hand that lost the blood. While glad that it didn't flag her as a risk, there was a part of her that looked up to the sky where the flame impacted the barrier.

She pushed those thoughts away and focused on the next step. Looking for allies within Ashen.

The real question was where to start. Ashen was one of the biggest cities she had ever seen. All sorts of people and all walks of life. In the end, she settled on the same strategy she has always used. Wandering around and hope for the best.

In this way, she learned the pulse of the city. By her immediate vicinity, the gates and most of the outskirts were refugees and places that supported them. Shelters which were filled to the brim, shops that looked like moneylenders, and other shops with odds and ends.

One set of establishments caught her eye. At regular intervals there was a small clinic or office with a giant sign which read "KINDLING"

"Join the Kindling today!" Criers in front of those signs rang bells and said their spiel. "Be a part of something bigger! No magic or experience required! Pay is good!"

Kindling. Fuel for the flame. Whatever the purpose of 'Kindling' was, Nettle didn't like the name of it.

Nettle didn't doubt whoever lined up

had the same thought she did. All the same, the lines for these places were long. The promise of pay was something that people couldn't pass up. Especially now, when they had next to nothing. Nettle didn't fault them for that.

Deeper into the city, she switched into a different district. It looked like this one had more than refugees. Their clothes, though simple, were more complete. It didn't look like they were about to unravel at any second.

These citizens walked with their head held high, with destinations in their eyes and focus in their steps.

Another district change.

This had to be market district of a sort. Open air markets and food stalls were in the middle of streets, actual restaurants and groceries stores on the edge.

"Two strals for a pastry, three strals for two!"

"Only five strals to take home three chunks of fish! All must go!"

"Excuse me, miss, would you like to try our fruits? Only one stral!"

At the center of this district, there were performers as well. From what Nettle could see, most of them were aided by magic in some way or another. Acrobats flew through the air and warped in between the crowd. Musicians who enhanced their song with multiple instruments or bright lights.

Nettle watched the performers for a spell, but what really caught her attention were the crowds they were

performing for. They weren't particular large or special in any way. What stood out to her was they were able to be in the crowd at all.

They weren't downcast, beaten upon, or in a hurry. It was a brief moment of levity that could be enjoyed without any worries.

Nettle looked at her hands. When was the last time she could enjoy a brief moment to herself? She couldn't answer. Even in this moment, she had to move and find a lead. So she moved districts again.

The next district was closest to the mountain. Buildings and offices were built into the side of it, with various paths set up so that access up the mountain was easy.

This seemed to be the business and science district. Finely dressed individuals hurried along, carrying papers under their arms or bags filled with bits and bobs on their back. Nettle caught a lot of attention here, her traveler's cloak sticking out like a sore thumb. But despite catching glances, no one approached her. They had their own places to be and things to do.

Nettle returned to the previous districts to blend in better. Now that she's scoped out general locations, she focused on eavesdropping for any scraps of rumors.

A group of armored soldiers were watching one of the performances.

"Did you hear about the attack today?"

"On the southern border, ye?"

"Ye, there was fire again. The barrier

took the brunt of it, but some of our Strikers had to take to the field this time."

"That's a scary thought."

"Hey, as long as it's them out there and not us."

Their conversation petered out as the performance did. Nettle took that chance to leave them.

While browsing some wares, she found another conversation across a family.

"It looks like Emain in the east is mustering some forces. Their patron might finally try to take us over."

"Oh the Archmagus will never let that happen."

"But their patron is also a great mage, aren't they?"

"Come now, the Archmagus is the greatest mage in Ashen. There's no chance."

"I hope you're right."

Not what Nettle was looking for.

Throughout the market district, Nettle couldn't find any decent rumors. Always talking about the attack that just happened or about things irrelevant to Nettle.

She returned to the outskirts. Nettle expected to hear more of the troubles out here. She assumed most of them were displaced because of the flames. But the longer she listened, the more perplexed she became.

"We're safe from the monsters now."

"Bandits won't catch us out here."

"I'd like to see those damned witches

burn my life down this time."

She thought there would be more. To her, fighting her sister and watching her ravage the land in fire and ash was quite a big deal. To Ashen, it was another part of life.

In the same way they had the luxury to watch a performance unbidden, once inside these walls, they had to luxury to treat her war as something that just happens.

Disheartened, Nettle slipped into a tavern.

She did not sleep that night. Reality set in for her. Nettle was fighting her war all by herself. With no money, no magic, or connections, and no help. She had hoped to find something in Ashen, but after five years running from place to place, she didn't know how to.

"It's only been a day," Nettle said to herself. "We can try again on the morrow."

The next day, Nettle set out bright and early. Another day meant another chance for information.

The first thing she saw was the line to join the Kindling. Whatever organization the Kindling was, Nettle was wary about her autonomy being taken away from her. Even if it was a perfectly fine organization, she'd be marching to the beat of their drum. But, it could be better than nothing. She'll place it as her last resort.

While out and about, Nettle decided to change her tactics from eavesdropping to something more direct. She looked for a guard.

"Excuse me, sir," she called out to one looking over the inside gate.

"Do you need something, ma'am?"

"Do you know where people go when they need help?"

"Us guards is a good a place as any. Where has the crime been committed?"

"More of a mercenary type of help," Nettle explained.

"Ah, that would be different. Outside of the city?"

Nettle nodded.

"And that makes things a little more complicated." The guard rubbed his chin. "Your best bet would be the Guild. They'd have the manpower to help you out."

"The guild? Where can I find that?"

"Well that's going to be a problem. Two problems actually," the guard pulled out a map and pointed to the eastern side of the city. "You have three options to get

there. Straight north from here and that'll take you through the Chandlery, our school district. Unfortunately you need to be student or faculty to set foot in there without an alarm."

"Not the school then."

"You could, if you became a student. Anyway, the next path straight through the mountain. You'll reach Uptown that way, but it's locked down for the best and brightest of us. If you had incredible magic potential, you can swing your way inside, but outside of that you'll need to become very important. Safe to say it's overkill if you just need to get the guild."

"Maybe I am important," Nettle half-joked, but she also felt for the barrier within herself created by the ritual.

"You might be, but not in the way that matters to the higher-ups."

"Of course. The last route?"

"The last route, aside from leaving the city going the long way around, is to through the Fissures. Now the gates can get pretty rough, understandably so with the ins and outs. Us guards, we keep things under control. A year or two back, we got a bad quake from the mountain. Split the southeastern side of the city right in two, leaving a gorge that flows with lava."

Nettle nodded and listened.

"Now, because us fine Ashen folk are so stubborn, there's still a thriving community that lives around Fissures. Only problem is that they're quite hardy and lawless around there. There's not a strong

guard presence in that area. The powers that be has declared it so. My guess is that they're trying to keep all the troublemakers in one place but-" the guard shrugged.

"Then that's my best bet," Nettle said. She turned to go.

"Now hold on there, miss," the guard stopped her. "Getting there is just the first problem. The second and more tangible problem is going to be your funding."

"My funding?"

"Yes, your funding. How much stral do you have on you?" The guard asked.

Nettle was hesitant to answer.

"If my guess is right, not much," The guard continued. "You'll need to put up a reward if you make a request. Harder requests require higher compensation, after all. The only exception is if you're putting up a request for a treasure hunt - in those cases, the reward is the treasure, split upon the commissioner and the commissioned as decided by both parties."

"How much to slay something?"

"Depends on the beast. Magic?"

"Magic," Nettle confirmed.

"Magical beasts typically go for five figures. Ten thousand to eighty thousand stral, depending on the known danger. Unknown tends to add a zero to it."

"That's a mighty sum," Nettle said.

"Not something I can afford," The guard agreed.

"While I thank you for your

information, how do you know so much about the guild?" Nettle asked.

"Oh, that's easy. I used to be a member. Good pay, if dangerous work. I'd take it over becoming Kindling over there," he jutted his chin towards one of the longer lines. "Anyway, I assume you're taking the path through Fissures?"

"Seems to me like the only path available," Nettle said.

"Stay careful out there. I can see the iron in your eye, but I've also seen some good folk enter the fissures and don't come out. One more thing, on the way to the Fissures, you might come across the Red Light district. There's an establishment there called the Leaky Tap. If you're tapped for cash they do take strays fairly often. The ladies there aren't hard to look at either, I'm talking curves that--"

"And thank you very much for your help, sir," Nettle nodded and turned to leave.

"You're welcome, miss! Don't be a stranger."

Nettle was glad that she lucked out with how friendly the guard was.

"Oh, I never asked his name," Nettle looked back, but she had already crossed districts.

She moved through the market district with purpose, making sure to keep east. It was still early in the morning and despite that, or because of it, the markets were packed with everyone trying to get their shopping done. Nettle did notice that the further east she went and closer to the the fissures, the more the crowds thinned

out.

There was a level of unkempt that was different in this area. A lot of these shops were closing up for the day, shirtless men and women putting signs back inside.

Others were just leaning against walls, watching and waiting. Nettle kept a hand on the dagger at her hip. She thought about releasing the ritual for access to her magic.

If there was ever a time to travel through this area, it would be early morning in broad daylight. Any unruly patrons would be all tuckered out from a long night.

Regardless, Nettle kept her eyes and ears open. This would be a good opportunity actually - while her physical senses are keeping track, she summoned what little magic she could to sense around her as well. Make more with less, that was something she learned in the past five years.

She saw an establishment with a sign that read "The Leaky Tap." It looked a little bigger than the others, slightly more vibrant the rest. Nettle noted the place and it's location.

Her path through the red light district was without incident.

True to form, the fissures were the most rundown district of Ashen. Buildings were made of scrap and sheets, houses being built upon uneven ground. Most visible was either dead or dying, curled up against the buildings like with naught but skin and bones.

Those who were able to walk around weren't doing much better. Limping, dirty bandages, and giving Nettle a wide berth.

As much as the Red Light district made Nettle feel unclean, Fissures made Nettle feel danger. They were all eyeing her. What did she have on her? How much could she go for?

Nettle kept her cool and made it to the actual fissure. True to name, the land was split into two halves. From her position, the gap was anywhere between half a mile to a couple miles. She stood on the jagged edge, looking below to find other houses and buildings built into either side of the cliff. Deep below, she saw hints of red - no doubt the molten rock.

She heard footsteps behind her. Nettle turned, a big, heavy man approaching.

"Looking to cross to the other side darling," His voice was gravely and deep. "'Fraid this isn't the spot for that. Though if you still want to, I can get you there. I'd just need a little *incentive*."

"Enough," Nettle whispered to herself. "When in the city of Mages, magic is needed."

"Speak up, darling, I can't hear you," The man took a step forward.

With some effort, Nettle released a little bit of the ritual seal within her. Then, she stepped back into open air.

Using just enough magic unleashed to let her fly, Nettle propelled herself to the other side of the fissure. She landed on her feet, already walking towards her destination.

Onlookers made some note of her, but otherwise went about their business. Proficient magic changes things for a lot of people here. This was something they didn't want to mess with. The rest of the people in the Fissures left her alone, either out of fear, lack of energy, or just couldn't be bothered.

In either case, Nettle left the Fissures and entered different district. In some ways, it was similar to the market district. There were open air markets and food stalls, but the establishments were less commercial and more utility.

Blacksmiths abound, magic shops, with an emphasis on combat. The citizens openly carried weapons of all kinds. Swords, axes, bows. Many of them had light armor of leathers and cloths. Others wore metal heavier than the guards. All of them looked ready to throw down.

Nettle wandered for a little bit, taking in the sights. Unlike the rest of the city, this area felt quite warm. She took the chance to rest at one of the crossroads. As large as Ashen was, it took her most of the day to walk from one edge to the other. The sun was already setting to the west, the mountain casting a long shadow on the district.

Mage lights turned on all throughout, a fair distinct sight from the torches burning earlier. Not only that, but a crowd was forming a circle at the center of the crossroads.

"There's going to be a duel today!"

"Are you sure? Which two sods have ran into each other?"

"Apparently it's one of the Essaim twins."

"The guy?"

"Yeah, the guy. Family honor and all that."

"This should be a good show."

Nettle listened to the murmurs throughout the crowd and approached the circle to look.

Within the circle, a small woman was shadowboxing the air. On the opposite side of her, two similar looking adults were conversing with each other. The twins Nettle overheard about. They both had platinum hair, lithely built. They each had a sword on their hip, but something about them felt off to Nettle.

No, not off. Just different.

Ah, they had something the rest of these people lacked. Enough magical strength that it leaked off of them like steam. It wasn't overt or uncontrolled. It was some level of magical potential that couldn't be ignored.

The platinum-haired woman locked eyes with Nettle for a moment. Was she thinking the same thing Nettle was.

But just as fast, she returned to conversation with her twin.

"Hey meathead!" the small woman pointed at the man. "Enough talk! Put your money where your mouth is!"

The man turned to face her. "You don't want this, Penny. The names of my ancestors are not yours to disgrace."

"Your 'ancestors' are what put us here," Penny balled her hands into fists

and took up a combat stance. "And I'll see it that it stops!"

"Really? Over this?" the crowd murmured. "Is she really picking a fight over this?"

"If you're not gonna come to me," magic condensed around her limbs and she pounced. She crossed the span in a single step, poised to strike. "I'll come to you!"

Nettle furrowed her brow. The man made the action of drawing a sword, but he didn't grab the sword at his side. Instead, a sword appeared in his hand in a flash of light, blocking Penny's blow.

Penny was not to be denied, kicking off of air and throwing herself behind him.

The man turned and continued blocking her, stepping backwards into to the center of the circle.

"Show her why you're the adventurer around this parts!"

"Put her down Elmond!"

"Glory to the guild!"

Elmond. Nettle stuck to the name. There was something about that felt familiar.

The magic surrounding Penny condensed further. She kicked it up to a higher gear.

Elmond didn't flinch, only summoning a second sword. He hadn't moved from the center and kept his cool.

"Alright, Elmond. Enough playing around. Finish this up so we can go back to the guild," the twin called out.

"Working on it," Elmond said back. "Hard to be nonlethal with a sword."

"And that'll be your mistake!" Penny moved faster than Nettle could track.

Elmond dropped the swords and a bat appeared in his hands. Swinging for the fences, he clocked Penny in the gut, sending her flying.

The crowd erupted into cheers at the display, a couple chasing after her to make sure Penny was alright.

"Honestly," the twin waved her hand as the bat disappeared. "Too soft for your own good."

"If I wasn't, that would be proving her right," Elmond said. "You're the one who's too soft, Elisabeth. Penny was right. We're never going to redeem our family at this rate." He started walking away.

Elisabeth shrugged. As the crowd began to disperse, Nettle was about to move off herself before Elisabeth approached her.

"Hello there, stranger. I assume you're new here?"

"Oh," Nettle was taken aback. "Yeah, how did you guess?"

"You've got that wide-eyed look of a tourist to you," Elisabeth said. "Let me guess, you're looking for the guild?"

Nettle nodded.

Elisabeth smiled and gestured to follow her. "Come on, people usually do."

Nettle followed her with a spring in her step. A small piece of good news.

Elisabeth lead Nettle further north of the district. She pointed at a building that looked like a church, much bigger than the other buildings.

"See that one there? That's the guild. Since this is the adventurer's district that is our primary export. That's how I guessed that's what you were looking for."

"Because people don't come here unless they are an adventurer or looking for an adventurer," Nettle said.

"Exactly, so which one are you?"

"Which one?"

"Adventurer or looking?" Elisabeth asked.

"Looking," Nettle said. "I've got a problem I need help with."

"Well, let's hope your reward is good," Elisabeth winked. "The guild's got more than a couple able members."

Once they reached the guild building, Nettle could hear the sounds of revelry and drinking from the inside.

Someone was thrown outside but quickly jumped back to their feet and flew back in.

"Don't mind the mess, they're just celebrating a won duel," Elisabeth gestured for Nettle to go first. Nettle obliged her.

Upon crossing the door, the stench hit her before anything else. It smelled like sweat, food, and alcohol. At the very center, tables and stools were thrown over like a makeshift arena. There was fist fight as people cheered and jeered for whoever was fighting. Whenever someone was knocked out, they were pulled out of the

ring and someone else took their place.

"Never a dull moment here at the guild!" Elisabeth yelled over the noise. "This way, the quest counter is on the second floor."

Up the wooden stairs, there were three counters each manned by a receptionist. There were some adventurers that were missing the revelry and looking over the quests available to them.

Elmond was one of those adventurers. He was chatting to a receptionist when he noticed his twin approach.

"Welcome back. I've already handed our quest in and got our reward," Elmond nodded to Nettle. "And who do you have here?"

"Good. This is..." Elisabeth started to introduce Nettle before both of the realized - Nettle never gave her name.

"Nettle," Nettle introduced herself. "I'm from outside Ashen."

"As are we," Elmond gestured to the rest of the guild. "Most of us are."

"Miss Nettle here is looking to put up a quest," Elisabeth explained.

"I can handle your quest registration for you," The receptionist at the far left raised their hand. "Let's hear the details."

"Come on Elmond, I did my good deed for the day," Elisabeth turned to go.

"You go on ahead," Elmond said. "Maybe this quest will be more interesting we've currently got."

"A little rude, Elmond. My quests are perfectly suitable," The receptionist

said. "And as we've gone over before, Elmond, we allow our clients some modicum of confidentiality. You can wait with your sister."

"No, it's alright," Nettle said. "I think I do want you to take this quest anyhow."

"There you have it," Elmond smiled and leaned against the counter.

"We'd much prefer to keep the process as clean as possible, but if you're insisting," the receptionist sighed. "Ok, what do you have for us."

"I have a particular quest that needs to be completed," Nettle started. "But before that, how well do you know about the Witch of Summer?"

"Witch of Summer?" The receptionist frowned. "We've seen our fair share of witches, warlocks, and other rogue mages, but that title is unknown to us."

"Hm," Nettle thought for a moment. "How about the sudden influx of flames burning the land?"

"We have," Elmond said.

"Elmond, please. Let us receptionist do our jobs," the receptionist said. "Anyway, yes. We often have quests to either act as guards in case of that or restore villages."

"I know the source of it and I need help stopping her," Nettle said.

The receptionist was quiet for some time. "That is quite the request. I assume the reward is substantial."

It was Nettle's turn to be quiet.

"Of course not," The receptionist

sighed. "I'm afraid the guild can't sponsor this quest. There's too many unknowns for us and without a reward to offset the possible danger, not many will bite for this."

"Oh," Nettle frowned. "How much do you think it needs to be?"

"Because of the uncertainty, it would need to be a very large sum," the receptionist said. "Forgive me for being forward, but I don't think you'll be muster a sum anytime soon."

Nettle stood there in silence. So many thoughts ran through her head. The most important one was how she was going to get the help she sorely needed.

"But," the receptionist broke Nettle's train of thought. "Deals that are done without guild sponsorship are not beholden to that rule." The receptionist turned to Elmond. "Well, Elmond? Could never resist a chance to play hero, even if it meant for no reward."

"Of course," Elmond cheered. "I've taken some of those village restoration quests before. If we can stop that, that sounds like a fine reward as is."

"Really?" Nettle asked. "Are you sure?"

"Elisabeth is not going to like that," the receptionist said.

"She usually doesn't. That doesn't stop her from coming along anyway. Come on Nettle, we can talk specifics with Elisabeth and some dinner," Elmond hurried down the stairs, not waiting to see if she would follow.

"Too kind by half," the receptionist shook her head. They turned to Nettle, "I

truly don't know how dangerous your quest will be, but be careful with them both, ok? Elmond and Elisabeth are some of our best. I'd hate to lose them."

"It won't come to that," Nettle said, with a level of confidence that surprised herself.

"See to it that it doesn't," the receptionist nodded at her and began to do paperwork.

Nettle made her way down the stairs and back to the revelry. Elmond and Elisabeth already pulled up a table, eating their fill and comparing notes.

"There's quester," Elmond waved Nettle over, a turkey leg in one hand and a flagon in the other. "Enjoy yourself tonight, we'll leave southbound first thing in the morning."

"Hello again Nettle," Elisabeth greeted, but Nettle could see that she was in a far sourer mood than before. "I hear that your quest doesn't have an overt reward."

"None that I could provide, no," Nettle shook her head. "I apologize."

"No need to apologize," Elisabeth said. "I don't blame you for taking the help where it is given. Now for my kind-hearted brother, I will be having him apologize."

"What? I don't see how being a good person is grounds for--"

"It's not about being a good person, it's about not having funds after this is said and done," Elisabeth growled. "I'm all for good deeds, but I'm not for being poor again."

"We can make it work, Elisabeth,"

Elmond said. "Provide us some details, Nettle. Maybe there's something good to come of this."

"Of course," Nettle nodded. "Let's start from the target." She pulled out her map and pointed south within the mountain ranges.

"Is that where the target is? The Spineshattered?"

"Something like that," Nettle said. "That's where her Castle is."

"Her?" Elisabeth raised a brow.

"The Witch of Summer, is that right?" Elmond asked.

"The Witch of Summer," Nettle confirmed.

"And how do you know all of this?" Elisabeth waved a spoon around. "I hope what you have isn't hearsay."

"No, it's not hearsay. I know this location because I've been there," Nettle explained. "It's surrounded by a barrier of flame, not to mention it's the source of the incidents burning down the countryside. I'm not strong enough to do it on my own."

"And this is your business because...?" Elisabeth beckoned for her to continue.

"Because...?" Nettle wasn't sure how to respond.

"Listen, I buy that you've seen the source, I even buy that you need help. But I can't figure out the why."

"Elisabeth!" Elmond chided. "If she needs help, she needs help. What more do we need?"

"No, no, it's a fair question," Nettle

paused and tried to think of a good reason. She didn't want them to know the full truth, at least not yet. A half truth then. "Seven years ago my home was one of the first attacked by the Witch. My mother was a mage who tried to stop her."

Nettle stopped and took a breath.

"I'm sorry to hear that," Elisabeth held Nettle's hand. "That must've been hard for you."

"Yeah," Nettle choked up. She wasn't even sure why. "Yeah."

"You've got my buy-in," Elisabeth continued. "But the Spineshattered Range is dangerous. It would do us well to be well-prepared." She looked at Elmond. "Go get some other quests. Even if we're doing this, we're not coming back to Ashen empty-handed."

"But Elisabeth, I heard there was a castle involved. There might be treasure in there," Elmond complained, but he got up anyway.

"Make sure the rewards are big! Even if the quest is boring!" Elisabeth called after him. Elmond waved her off as he climbed the stairs. "We might take a pretty wide detour, but I hope that's alright with you."

"No, that's fine," Nettle said. "I'm just glad you agreed. I've been at this for a long while."

"I could imagine."

"Elisabeth! I've got some escort quests and a couple from Emain! We'll need to head North, then to the eastern shore," Elmond came running down. "Big payout!"

"There you have it," Elisabeth got up

and grabbed some of the papers out of Elmond's hand. "Go get some rest, the guild has a couple of guest rooms on the second floor. Say you're with Elmond and me, they'll give you one."

"Elisabeth, Elmond," Nettle got up and bowed to both of them. "Thank you both."

"Well," Elisabeth started, then looked at Elmond. Elmond nodded at her, smiling wide. "The Essaim family used to be heroes. We'll leave at dawn. Rest up."

Nettle thanked them again and followed their instructions to an empty room. As she closed the door behind her, something inside her stopped. She wobbled to the bed and fell, all of her strength leaving her.

"Oh," Nettle thought to herself, her eyes already dropping. "*I must've been more... tired than I thought...*" And for the first time in a long time, she slept in a soft bed, warm and safe.

"The next day started bright and," the old man tapered off as he heard the soft snoring of a little girl. It was quiet, barely audible, but now that he let his story sit for a moment, he saw that his daughter had fallen asleep. "Hope I won't have to repeat much tomorrow night."

He smiled and brushed the hair out of her face, just watching her snore for a couple minutes.

"Good night, little miss," he said, tucking her in and extinguishing the candles. He crept through the house slowly, avoiding all the spots on the floor that creaked. Back into his workshop, the old man took stock of what he was working on.

He had a handful of wooden figurines already made and placed to the side. They were of various creatures he's seen. A bear that can call rot and ruin with it's breath. Lightning wolves. A dragon, of course. Back to his current block, the old man had forgotten what he was carving. Did he make a decision or was he hoping to find the shape of what the wood had wanted to be?

Regardless of what he thought, he went back to it. It wouldn't be the first time he carved a block into nothing.

So with nothing but his thoughts, the old man whittled away and away.

Sunlight peaked into his room, sunbeams shifting through clouds of dust and wood shavings.

"I should go fishing today," he said. He set his knife down, the wood almost gone. At the same time he left his

workshop, the little miss walked out of her room, dragging her blanket and rubbing her eyes. "Good morning little miss, did you sleep well?"

She nodded and sat on the couch, curling up with her blanket. She yawned. Her stomach growled.

"Want some breakfast?"

With eyes still closed, she nodded.

"Ok, let's get you some grub," he went to the kitchen beside her and took his time fashioning a meal. Some eggs, toast, the last of the fish. He set the breakfast in front of her and waited until she started eating.

"Daddy," she asked in between bites. "Did you finish the story yesterday?"

"You fell asleep miss," he said. "How could I have?"

"Mm," she nodded and continued to eat, half asleep.

"I'm going fishing today. Do you want to come with?"

"Mm," she nodded again.

"I'll wait outside for you, ok? Make sure to get dressed and grab your fishing rod."

"Mm," she nodded a third time and ate her toast. The old man left her to it and went outside. He stretched and sat on a bench next to the door, breathing out smoke in the crisp and cold air.

After some time, the young miss went outside. She wore yellow rubber boots and had a small fishing rod in her hands.

"Daddy, I can't find my fishing hat," she pouted.

"Don't worry little miss, it's right here," he reached behind her and snapped his fingers. A fishing hat appeared in his hands. "See, it's right here."

She beamed as her father place the hat on her head.

"Ready to go?" he offered his hand.

The young girl took his hand and the two walked down the cliffs to the shore.

"Can you tell the story while we fish?" she asked him.

"Hmm," the old man thought for a moment. "Do you think it'll scare the fish?"

"No! The fish are brave!"

"Then I can tell the story," he thought for a moment. "What's the last thing you remember before you went to sleep?"

"Elmond and Elisabeth accepted Nettle's quest!"

"Good, good," the old man nodded.

"Nettle and the rest went to bed to tackle the new day."

Nettle woke with a restfulness she hadn't felt in a long time. It was the kind that put a spring in her step, a song on her lips, and head up.

As she left her room, Elisabeth was already on the way to her.

"Good, you're awake," she greeted. "Elmond is already off getting supplies. We'll meet him at the northern entrance through the Chandlery."

"We can pass through the Chandlery without being student or faculty?"

"Being a proper citizen and adventurer of Ashen gives us a pass," Elisabeth winked.

"Did you decide our route?" Nettle asked while the two left the guild. There were a number of members passed out on the floor, but the two paid them no mind as they walked over them.

"We'll be heading north first, we have an escort quest to send a couple researchers to a northern mining operation," Elisabeth said. "After that, we'll head east to Emain, and then south to your castle. We'll earn some extra stral and get probably get stronger on the way, does that seem fair?"

"More than fair," Nettle nodded.

"Good," Elisabeth said.

When the two got to the Chandlery, Nettle couldn't believe her eyes. The district itself was a large candelabra, multiple tiers and nodes spinning around.

Mages of all sorts flew around the building, somehow not crashing into the moving parts.

"This is the Chandlery?" Nettle asked.

"It's incredible."

"Yeah, it's one of the reasons Ashen is as strong as it is. Students come in, Mages come out. That's not to mention Uptown within the mountain. They get all the good toys."

The two of them made it to the edge of the city at another gate. Unlike the rest of the gates Nettle has seen, this one was tightly regulated with no refugees.

Researchers in white coats and travelers packs were gathered around talking to each other. Two of them caught Nettle's eye - a woman fiddling with a strange contraption and another woman in metal armor inscribing something onto a maul.

"They're the folks we'll be escorting," Elisabeth pointed them out.

"Should we introduce ourselves to them?"

"No, Elmond can take care of that," Elisabeth found a wall to lean against. "He's usually the one who talks with our clients."

Right on cue, Elmond came by and waved at Elisabeth and Nettle.

"I thought you said he was picking up supplies," Nettle asked him.

"Oh he's already got them," Elisabeth held her hand out. Similar to the swords, a large traveler's pack appeared in his hand. "Handy trick, isn't it?"

"How do you two keep doing that?" Nettle asked as Elisabeth unsummoned the pack.

"Family secret," Elisabeth said. After a moment, she sighed. "Well, not really a

secret. Let's call it a family tradition."

"Oh, family," Nettle nodded. "Family things are good."

"Yeah, well," Elisabeth shrugged. "Family is family."

"Family is family," Nettle agreed.

Elmond waved them over, the researchers ready to leave.

"And that's us," Elisabeth got up and stretched. "Time to head out."

Their journey northward began. Right outside of the gate there was a large procession of refugees that wanted to come in, that begged the guards to come in. They were all turned away, being directed to go to one of the other gates.

The desperate kept trying. Multiple guards were mobilized, using magical shields defend against the horde of people trying to force their way in.

Elmond reached a section of the guards and spoke something to them. He gestured for everyone to come over.

"They're going to have to do a small teleport to get us out of here," Elmond explained. "It's particularly bad today."

"Isn't there anything that can be done for them?" Nettle looked around at the poor scene. "Surely there's something."

"Of course there can be," Elisabeth said. "Are you going to be the one to do so?"

"I..." Nettle started to say something, but as the teleport circle was created and she stepped on, she understood what Elisabeth was saying. Something could be done for them. Nettle could see what she

can do for them. But not her. Not now. There were bigger fish to fry.

The spell took them, the teleport different than the kind Nettle was used to. For the briefest of moments, she felt nothing. She couldn't breath. Then she returned as the air breathed in and out of her lungs. Her eyes adjusted to the light; they were in a small encampment at the top of a hill. In the distance to south, the walls of Ashen were far enough away to be unable to make out any distinction in the crowds.

Several of the researchers were knocked on their butts, dizzy and disoriented from the experience.

"Woo," Elmond pounded his chest. "Still takes some getting used to. Alright everyone, let's get going." He rounded the researchers and kept them going, leading the party forward.

Elisabeth stumbled, Nettle helping her through the teleportation sickness.

"Nasty teleport, that," Elisabeth tried not to hurl. "No idea how he's able to stomach that."

"Not the easiest teleport," Nettle agreed. "My mother had smoother ways."

"Your mother knew how to teleport?" Elisabeth asked. "She must've been a good mage."

"The best I've known," Nettle said. She smiled. "Even against what I've seen in Ashen, she's still the best."

"Did she teach you that? It might be helpful in the future."

"No, we didn't get that far," Nettle sighed. "Taught me the fundamentals and

most of the basics."

"Mm," Elisabeth straightened out and walked on her own, Nettle letting her go. "The basics, huh."

"Something wrong?"

"No, no," Elisabeth sighed. She pointed ahead. Elmond was chatting up the researchers, laughing with them. "Elmond and I... our family wasn't big on the fundamentals and basics."

"Does it have something to do with why that girl was upset at him?"

"Penny?" Elisabeth did a half-laugh. "No, she's just jealous of our talents. Our talents that came from our family, so I guess she's not far off the mark actually."

"You don't have to talk about it if you don't want to," Nettle said. "Family is hard."

"It's fine. If we're traveling together, you should know. It'll give us an edge in case we find something tough," Elisabeth thought to herself. "Let's talk more about it when we reach camp. You can tell me about your mom too."

Nettle smiled. "Sure, I'd like that."

"Great," Elisabeth picked up her pace. "Let's catch up before they leave us behind."

Nettle obliged. They joined the group and kept a steady pace towards the north.

From the conversations, Nettle gleaned a couple more bits of information. This group of researchers will be heading to the Northern Scar. It was a deep gouge in the land where many different mining operations are. Once in a good distance,

half of the group will go northeast towards Mallach. The other half will continue North to a different mining operation known as Digen. Nettle's group was part of the latter.

"Anything else to look out for?" Nettle asked. She looked at the sky, dark clouds forming ahead of them.

"Bandits, beasts, the usual," Elisabeth said. "Are you good in a fight?"

Nettle nodded.

"Then if something does appear, you're with me. We go forward and take out the threat, Elmond stays back to defend everyone else."

"Understood," Nettle said. While they walked, Nettle practiced the fundamentals she talked about. Deep breaths, feeling magic in the air. She formed a ball of pure magic, spinning it around and just controlling it. When she felt comfortable, she had two balls. When trying to get to three, she fumbled and the balls detonated into a harmless firework.

She frowned. Before the ritual, she could control up to six with no issues. Oh well.

"Keep at it," Elmond called out. "You'll get there!"

Nettle smiled at the encouragement. She kept going.

Despite the clouds darkening overhead, the day passed without incident. Pushing away from the path, the trio set up camp, along with two campfires. One set for the researchers and another for themselves.

While eating their rations, Elisabeth sat next to Nettle.

"If I recall, I promised you a story about Elmond and me," Elisabeth said.

"And I about my mother," Nettle nodded.

"Right," Elisabeth gazed into the crackling flames. "I'll start with our last name. Essaim. Our family goes back incredibly far. You can trace us a thousand years ago, maybe more."

"A thousand years is a long time," Nettle said.

"Indeed it is," Elisabeth agreed.

"Because of our talents, the Essaims were incredibly combatants. We were predisposed to being good adventurers and heroes. Here, this'll be useful."

Elisabeth pointed next to the flame. She summoned a sword.

"You two do that often," Nettle said.

"Is that what you've been taught?"

"If only," Elisabeth wore a wry smile.

"You can call it our inheritance. It's like our hair color. If you see someone with platinum hair, it's probably an Essaim."

"Are there a lot of you?"

Elisabeth didn't answer right away. "At home, yeah. There's not much of us who adventure these days. Elmond and I had to fight a lot to get out here."

"They don't approve?"

"Like I said, not much who adventure these days," Elisabeth summoned another sword to place by the fire. "They say our ancestor was the legend among legends. He can control a thousand swords and was a god on the battlefield. He could warp to each and every one, ripping through armies like a wildfire." She summoned a third

sword, sticking it into the fire. "My father, his father's father, and his father before that has been chasing that legend ever since."

"So what's the deal then?" Nettle asked. "If that's your problem with them, what's Penny's?"

"Well, we were adventurer's once. Once," Elisabeth sighed. "For the people who know of our legends, they feel like my family has let the world down. That we could've fixed the world. When I was younger, I thought we could've. That was a long time ago. Now I'm just glad we're out of there. Elmond believes still. He still believes in that legend."

The two of them sat in silence, having long finished their rations.

"Enough about me," Elisabeth smiled, though it didn't quite reach her eyes. She unsummoned her swords. "I hope your family was kinder than mine."

"Ha," it was Nettle's turn to stare at the fire. "Before the witches, it was. I call her my mother, but she wasn't really. In her words, she had a habit of picking up strays."

"You were adopted?"

"We all were. I was the youngest of three sisters, all of us who were unwanted once. She gave us a roof over our heads, full stomachs, and magic of all sorts. Though my mother was strict in her lessons, her eyes were full of love and kindness for all of us. Except..."

"Except?"

"I talked to my sisters once about this once," Nettle explained. "Sometimes, I'd

catch her staring into the distance. I don't know towards what, I don't what my mother was thinking. But I remember thinking that she looked so sad. My sisters didn't know what I was talking about, of course."

"Sounds like she held the weight of the world on her shoulders," Elisabeth said.

"Now that I think about it, yeah," Nettle agreed, something like that. "Then the flames came. I lost my eldest sister first. Then my mother. My other sister fought for a while, but then I lost her too. I'm the only one left."

The two women stared into the fire for a long time, sharing in a moment of silence and grief.

After a while, Nettle spotted Elmond on the outskirts of the camp. He summoned a sword and stuck it into the ground. Walking a little more around the perimeter, he stuck another. And another.

Nettle pointed him out to Elisabeth.

"What's he doing?" Nettle asked.

"He's setting up a perimeter," Elisabeth said. "He can summon more swords than I can. But I'm the better caster of the two of us, so once he's done I'll cast a spell connecting them all. Wards off most threats and for the ones it can't, we'll spot far in advance."

The two watched him complete his perimeter. Elmond waved Elisabeth over to cast her spell.

"That's my queue. You can go ahead and tuck in for the night."

"Understood," Nettle nodded as Elisabeth got up. "Oh, Elisabeth?"

"Yeah?" Elisabeth paused.

"Thank you for sharing your story with me," Nettle bowed her head slightly.

Nettle couldn't see Elisabeth's face in the darkness, but Nettle thought she smiled.

"Good night, Nettle. May your dreams be kind."

Though Nettle slept, she did not dream. She woke to lightning and thunder.

Despite the coming rain, everyone agreed to push forward and keep traveling. The researchers all had their own ways of staying dry and Nettle casted a spell to keep the rain off in a small area around her.

Despite their ways of staying dry in this weather, the path was muddy and difficult to trudge through.

Elisabeth and her kept the front of the pack, Elmond taking up the rear.

"Any chance of wolves?" Nettle asked. Thunder boomed ahead of them.

"Very high," Elisabeth kept a hand on her sword. "It's too dangerous to set up another camp in this area with the lightning so close."

What Nettle and Elisabeth were worried about, were wolves known as Raiju. Unlike normal wolves, these pulled power from storms. There weren't as many as a full pack. Depending on the storm there could be any amount from one to three. However, even just one raiju can catch someone unprepared.

If Nettle was at full strength, she could handle one alone with some difficulty. She didn't want to find out if she could do it while protecting a crowd.

Another peel of lightning ripped through the sky, followed by a boom that shook Nettle's bones.

Nettle saw movement up ahead. Elisabeth held her hand up, causing the group to stop.

Thunder boomed without lightning in the sky.

A streak shot towards them. Elisabeth

moved first, but Nettle was faster.

Shield. Magic obeyed her, throwing up a wall of force that deflected lightning. The source stomped into view.

"Elmond!" Elisabeth called back. "Get everyone to safety!"

There was only one raiju in this storm. But as it approached, the footsteps shook the ground it walked on. It was almost as tall as the trees in this forest, with white fur that sparked with electricity. It's wolfish snout was long and pronounced, scarred with slashes where other travelers tried to make their mark.

It snarled with hackles raised, ready to pounce. They were territorial; the beast was giving them a chance to back down. Unfortunately for all parties involved, there wasn't any time to go around in this storm.

"You ever fought raiju of this size before?" Elisabeth asked in this moment of calm.

"No," Nettle drew her dagger slowly.

"We haven't either."

Nettle dropped the shield and the raiju pounced. Nettle dove one way, Elisabeth the other. Pulling all of her magic that she could muster within herself, Nettle enhanced herself and turned just in time to see a claw slash at her.

She jumped over it and flew down with the dagger. No purchase on it's hide.

Nettle pulled back, electricity crackling. All around the raiju, an explosion of static pulsed, shocking the area Nettle was just in.

Raijus store static electricity and can discharge them in a couple of ways. As an augment to an attack, around them to clear a crowd, and as a blast of force like a cannon.

The trick to fighting them was to be brief and keep behind then - easier said than done because of their speed, also augmented by lightning. Nettle and Elisabeth danced around the raiju, pulling back and pushing forward in tandem. Nettle kept the attention most of the time, the dagger unable to do anything. From what she could see, that worked well. She'd pass by a sword stuck into the body of the raiju from where Elisabeth found purchase.

Even then, this raiju showed no sign of slowing down. They needed something with more punching power.

The air crackled, smelling of ozone. Nettle's hair stood on edge and she jumped back. In a split second, she spotted Elisabeth do the same.

Shield! Nettle commanded magic at the speed of thought. Thunder rumbled above and in that very instant, lightning crashed from the heavens and into the raiju.

The subsequent thunder knocked Nettle off her feet, though she spun into the air to avoid hitting the ground.

The raiju howled, it's entire body glowing with the lightning it absorbed. Nettle grimaced, but it wasn't the worst thing that has happened. Paradoxically, the more lightning a raiju absorbs, the slower they become. Channeling that much energy is difficult, even if they were

born to do so.

It swiped a claw, a wave of destructive force taking out the ground and uprooting trees entirely. A concussive roar almost blasted Nettle out of the sky - even though it missed, the ringing in her ears almost grounded her.

"Elmond!" Elisabeth shouted out, clear as day.

Below Nettle, Elmond appeared. He had a large greataxe and clashed with the raiju. He dropped the axe and moved closer to the raiju even as it swung again.

Another weapon appeared in his hands, the two clashing again.

Nettle looked over to Elisabeth on the other side. The raiju hadn't even noticed her trying to pierce it's hide with the swords she has.

Even with Elmond here, they weren't going to make any progress until they have some more punching power.

Nettle landed. She felt for the magic in her, for the magic around her. She pulled magic in from the world, using her body as a conduit in way that was similar to the raiju.

It noticed. It opened it's maw to howl at Nettle, but Elisabeth came from above to stabbed swords into eye, while Elmond swung from below to shut the wolf up.

She turned the magic into a ball, condensing it and spinning it faster and faster.

The raiju sent out a wave of electricity, Elmond and Elisabeth dodging out of the way just in time.

Whether Nettle could collect more magic

or not, she was at the limit she could control. The ball was condensed to the size of her fist. She spun, the ball following her actions as the raiju charged at her.

Keep things simple. Nettle dodged the first two swipes and got right in front of the raiju. With all her strength, she swung the magic into the raiju's chest, detonating the condensed magic. *BANG*

The cacophonous *boom* was different than thunder. Nettle was thrown back and the sound of rain stopped for a moment. Then the rain continued, Nettle picking herself up.

Shaking the ringing from her ears and the lights from her eyes, Nettle caught her breath, the sense of danger gone.

"Is it dead?" Nettle asked, to anyone who would be listening.

Elmond and Elisabeth were in front of the collapsed raiju, Elisabeth pulling her swords out of it. Nettle thought it was dead, but then she saw the rise and fall of it's chest as it kept breathing.

"This thing is tough," Elmond looked it up and down. "Too bad it's not our primary quest."

"Are we killing it?" Nettle put a hand on it's fur. It almost seems like a shame to.

"No. Even with the advantage you've given us, I don't think we can or should," Elisabeth said.

"I'd wager this guy is old. At the very least, older than Elisabeth and me combined," Elmond said. "Besides, even if we do, we'd want to head back to Ashen to

make use of the body somehow. We're heading in the opposite direction."

"I don't think the guild has made a stink about this. Raiju's are territorial, so there's a good chance it would've let us leave if our path wasn't through the storm," Elisabeth said.

"I'll round our troops up," Elmond jogged off to where he evacuated the researchers to.

"Good job out there," Elisabeth stretched. "Was that part of your fundamentals?"

"Yeah," Nettle nodded. "There's magic in me and there's magic in the world. If there's not enough within, just use the magic without."

"That's handy," Elisabeth wiped the water from her face to no effect. The rain came by and the two realized how drenched they were. "Any chance you can use the magic without to control the weather?"

"Not yet, but I can still do something," Nettle called for some magic. Like before, she wanted to create a localized area around her to divert the rain. There was an added bonus to dry the two of them off, but when Nettle called for the magic, her knees buckled. "Wha-"

Elisabeth caught her. "Easy. That must've taken more out of you than you thought."

"Maybe," Nettle leaned against Elisabeth as the rain poured down. Maybe it was her imagination, but the rain let up a little bit. "Let's get going."

"Let's," Elisabeth helped Nettle to the northern path.

To Nettle's relief, the storm did let up. There were still a couple of hours of sun left, hardening the mud by the time it got to nightfall. Nettle's strength did come back, yet she still suffered from dizzy spells throughout the day - a side-effect of intaking too much magic at once.

Elmond jogged over to walk with the two of them for a bit.

"Hey Nettle," he greeted. "That's some cool magic you did over there. Was that raw magic?"

Nettle nodded. "Raw magic from the area around us."

"Woah," Elmond whistled. "Is that something you inherited? You didn't even chant a spell."

"It's just the fundamentals of magic," Nettle explained. "It was something I was taught. My mother told me this was something anyone can do."

"Oh yeah, Elisabeth told me some things about your family. Same mom?"

"The very one."

Elmond was quiet, visibly thinking some thoughts. "Hey, you said anyone could do what you did, right?"

"That's what I was taught," Nettle nodded.

"Could you teach me?" Elmond asked.

"Could I?" It was Nettle's turn to think to herself. "On some level, I think I could."

"Really?" Elmond beamed. "I know Elisabeth told you a bit of our family, we never really learned about all these fundamentals you've been talking about."

"I'll try my best," Nettle smiled.

"Whatever you can!" Elmond hopped with a spring in his step and headed back to the researchers.

"You didn't have to humor him," Elisabeth said, once her twin was out of earshot. "I thank you all the same."

"It's ok," Nettle tried to pull magic into a ball and continued practicing. "Mother used to have me teach lessons to the village kids. 'You've only mastered something once you teach it to someone.'"

"Then I hope your lessons are good," Elisabeth paused, then added, "Teacher."

The next camp was made at the top of a hill. In the far distance, Nettle saw a vague line on the horizon. Elmond pointed to it.

"That's the Scar. Another two days of travel and we'll make it there," he pointed to a tiny building that was halfway over there. "That's the next checkpoint and where we'll split off with the Digen team. Mallach team will have an escort waiting for them. Get some good rest tonight, we're halfway there."

Once the camp and perimeter were setup, Elisabeth and Elmond sat on the opposite side of a campfire from Nettle.

"Ok," Nettle took a deep breath. "First step is being aware of the magic in you. Can you two feel what magic feels like? The feeling of actual magic?"

Elmond summoned a sword. "When we use our talent, it feels like a pulling sensation in our hand. We think about it and it appears. Is it like that?"

"No, not really," Nettle shook her

head. "It's an application of magic, a shortcut, but do you think you can control that feeling across your entire body?"

Elmond focused for a moment. "I don't see what you mean."

"It means, brother of mine, that the magic we use is derived from raw magic, but it lacks the flexibility. We can only do one thing with it," Elisabeth explained, far better than Nettle could.

"Exactly," Nettle focused some ambient magic into a ball. "The first step is being aware of all the magic within you. If you don't know what magic feels like, I can kick start that for you."

"Let's do it," Elmond braced.

Nettle waved the ball around and pushed it towards Elmond. Instead of detonating it like with the Raiju, she just let the ball pass through him.

Nettle created another ball and sent it towards Elisabeth to the same effect.

"Woah," Elmond looked at his own arms. "Kind of tingles."

"Remember that feeling," Nettle said. "You'll have to be aware of it within you."

Elmond took a deep breath and closed his eyes. Nettle could see his focus.

On the other hand, Elisabeth was more relaxed. When she breathed out, she held her hands together. When she released her hands, a small ball of magic was formed. Then she just held it there.

When Elmond opened his eyes, he frowned. Then he saw Elisabeth sitting there with her own ball of magic and widened his eyes.

"What?" he looked at Nettle. "Did you give her that?"

Nettle shook her head.

"I did always say I was a better spellcaster than you," Elisabeth winked at her brother.

"I guess," he pouted, but then redoubled his efforts to tap into magic.

It took him some most of the night, but Elmond was able to create a ball as well. It was unstable for now, but Nettle assured Elmond that he'll get better with practice.

The day to the checkpoint was simple, if hard. The difficulties on the road started to make themselves apparent. Nettle was used to traveling, so she didn't see much of the issues, but some of researchers became increasingly irate.

"These don't travel often," Elmond explained. "I'll deal with them."

"And that's why he's the face," Elisabeth said.

Nettle continued her practice while walking. Ever since the fight with the raiju, she felt more in control of her magic. She didn't struggle as much to control multiple orbs, nor did she struggle to gather enough magic to do so. At times, she forgot she placed a limiter on herself.

When she checked within herself, the limiter was still there. It still constrained the majority of her abilities.

Nettle wondered to herself how different it would be without. She was content to know the emergency option was still available.

When they got to the checkpoint, there wasn't much in terms of lodging. It was another night of camping. On the bright side, they weren't on the hook for guarding.

Elisabeth still took it upon herself to scout around the perimeter for a watch.

"Can never be too careful, on or off the road," Elisabeth said to Nettle.

So Nettle relaxed as best she could. Her control was up to seven balls, an incredible amount to get to in a span of three days. Quantity achieved, now it was time to go for quality.

She caught Elmond also practicing, though he was still on the one orb.

"Elmond," Nettle greeted. "Still at it."

"Still at it. I don't know how you end Elisabeth managed to get so good at this," he said. "There has to be a trick I'm not getting."

"I don't know if trick, but I've been doing this for most of my life," Nettle said. "And from Elisabeth tells me, she's always had a knack for it."

Elmond grumbled but continued to practice.

Nettle thought his issue was focus at first, but despite Elmond's grumbling, his face calmed and his breathing evened out. The orb formed.

After a couple seconds, it wobbled, then warped out of Elmond's hands. His calm broke and the grumbling continued.

"Your start is good," Nettle observed. "But something in the middle is where it goes wrong."

"It would be helpful if I knew that something is," Elmond said.

"What of your family gift? What's the difference between the tug you feel when you use it versus the feeling of magic?"

"It's different," Elmond scratched his head in thought. "I know I used that tugging feeling to explain, but it's more like a muscle. I flex the muscle while thinking of what I want, then the sword appears. But for raw magic, it's less like a muscle and more like..."

"Like?"

"More like the feeling of being unsure," Elmond said. Then he nodded to himself. "Yeah, that's what it's like. It's like taking a breath and that breath going through my body. It pools in my chest and then just sits there."

"I think I understand," Nettle nodded. "It kind of wants to burst, but it has nowhere to go, even if it's right in your hands."

"That's it!" Elmond widened his eyes, surprised that Nettle got it. "What does that mean?"

"It means that you're not regulating your magic properly. Or, to be more specific, you're keeping it in your body."

"I'm not supposed to keep magic in my body?"

"Let me illustrate it like this," Nettle brought out her dagger to draw in the dirt.

"Here, use this," Elmond summoned a sword so that she didn't have to crouch.

"Thank you," Nettle drew a person, lines representing magic going into the

person, then the lines going out.

"Magework of all kinds can be represented as manipulating magic. Magic goes in, spell comes out. So when you're using your family gifts to summon this sword, it's the same idea. The only difference is how your mind abstracts it."

"So what does that mean for these magic balls?"

"When dealing with raw magic, there is no abstraction. Just magical control. You're controlling the magic within you and the magic outside of you. You're only supposed to be controlling the magic outside of you."

"Wait, wait, wait," Elmond held his hand out. "Explain that again. The magic comes into me, then the magic comes out. I'm controlling the magic in and out?"

"In simpler terms," Nettle took magic within herself and formed a ball in her hands. She pointed at her chest. "I'm welling magic here and sending it to my hand." Nettle traced the path the magic took from her chest to her hand. "Once the magic is outside of my body, then we control it. What you're doing is this-" Nettle pointed at Elmond's chest with both hands. Then, with one hand she traced the path from his chest to his hand so that one hand was pointing to his chest and another was pointing to his hand. "You're causing the magic to spin in both places when you're only meant to spin in one."

"I... see..." Elmond thought to himself.

"It's like rubbing a circle on your stomach and patting your head," Nettle concluded. "Doing two things at once is

hard."

"Oh," Elmond raised his head. "That makes sense."

He placed one hand on his stomach and held the other out. He focused again. The ball appeared. Once it started wobbled and became unstable, Elmond rubbed a circle on his stomach. The ball evened out and stabilized.

"There we go," Nettle congratulated him. "That's good."

"Cool," Elmond grinned. Then his grin falter. "How do I do this without rubbing my stomach?"

"Practice," Nettle said, then wished him a good night.

In the morning, Elmond saw the Mallach researchers to their new escorts and watched them head Northeast. Afterwards, when he rejoined with Nettle and Elisabeth, they took the rest Northwest.

There was only a handful of researchers traveling to Digen.

"If you don't mind me asking, what are you researching up here?" Nettle asked one of them.

"No bother at all," An older researcher answered her. The researcher's skin was wrinkled and stretched, their hair long and gray. They wore thick-rimmed glasses tinted so dark they might have been black. "The newest fad in Ashen is about these rocks known as *star stones*."

"Star stones?" Nettle furrowed her brow. Her mother taught her of some special gems. Surely they don't mean-

"Yes, Star stones," the researcher confirmed. "They're stones rich with magic and can store an incredible amount. They're known as such because it looks like a gem that holds a star within."

It is. Nettle's mother taught her of star stones exactly.

"Are you looking for anything specific about them?" Nettle probed.

"Really, anything we can get. We've tried replicating them in Ashen, but most gems of the sort would explode from the sheer amount of magic we'd throw in there. We'd often find them deep underground, which is why we've sent groups to Mallach and Digen. Personally, I think they're remains of falling stars. Meteors that survive to become meteorites. But," they shrugged.

"I hope you find what you're looking for," Nettle said. She relaxed. They didn't know then.

"I expect we will!" the researcher

exclaimed, hopeful. "The Scar has been a veritable goldmine of it recently!"

Nettle smiled and nodded. It makes sense that the Scar would have a large quantity of them. That piece of information lines up with what she was taught.

With that tidbit tucked away, Nettle checked in on Elmond. He was getting better at the fundamentals. After an entire day of practicing, he didn't have to rub his stomach to control the ball. Sure, a stiff breeze would disrupt the formation of it, but that was still progress.

Elisabeth was a little more restless. She checked over the sword at her hip, at the swords she summoned.

"Everything alright?" Nettle asked her.

"Something's wrong," she said.

"I can go scout it out," Nettle offered. "I think my flying has gotten better."

"No, save your strength," Elisabeth shook her head. "Just... keep your wits about you."

Nettle nodded, but she kept an open eye out. As a precaution, Nettle decided to try out a spell.

Breathing deep to center herself, she collected her magic. Then, she scattered it outside of her like an invisible gas.

Search. She sent her magic across a wide area, feeling for something. She didn't find anything, nor did she understand the information her magic sent back.

It was enough for her to know that she could cast it. With time, she'll refine the spell to actually be useful.

They made it to the edge of the Scar. Much like the Fissure in Ashen, it was a jagged gorge that tore through the land. Except, unlike the Fissure, it was absolutely giant. The other edge was far, far across, almost touching the horizon.

To Nettle's left and right, the Scar did disappeared over the horizon. When she looked over the edge, the bottom disappeared in darkness.

Elmond let out a low whistle. "Woah, this thing it massive. Digen is down there?"

"Yes!" the older researcher came by and looked over edge. "It's a bit of a trek down, but luckily there's an elevator!"

"An elevator?" Nettle looked around. "I don't see any?"

"That's because-" the researcher also looked around. "Oh dear, where has it gone?" They clapped their hands together. "Ok, guess we're going to do this the hard way! Gather around everyone!"

"The hard way?" Elmond asked. "What's the hard way?"

The researcher pulled out a cloth and waved it in the air. Suddenly, the cloth straightened out and created a hovering platform. They stood on it, then jumped up and down a couple times to test it's strength.

"Everyone who can't fly, get on," the researcher beckoned their companions over. "We'll ride this down. It's a little unstable, so I'm counting on you all to

help me out."

The researchers agreed and focused on the platform. Of their party, it looks like two needs to stay off it.

"Elmond, you get on," Elisabeth said.

"What? Shouldn't we draw straws or something?"

"Nettle can fly and you're a better close-quarters combatant," Elisabeth said.

"What about you?" Nettle asked her.

"Unless, you can fly as well?"

"Not exactly 'fly,'" Elisabeth confessed. "But I can try something."

"Elisabeth, you don't mean--"

"That's exactly what I mean," Elisabeth urged them to get to move on.

"But if you fail," Elmond was hesitant, but did what she asked.

"If I fail, Nettle will catch me," Elisabeth turned to Nettle. "Isn't that right?"

"I mean sure, but..." Nettle furrowed her brow. "What are we doing?"

"I'll explain in a bit. The rest of you, get going. We'll follow."

"Understood! Ok everyone, hold on tight and don't fall! I won't be able to control this if you do!" The researcher closed their eyes. The platform moved over the edge of the Scar and they descended.

"Alright Nettle," Elisabeth summoned a sword once they were out of earshot. "Are you ready?"

"Depends on what ready is," Nettle took a moment to focus and willed herself of the ground. "But yes."

"Excellent," Elisabeth let go of the

sword and it hung in the air. "My family has an ability with swords that Elmond and I never mastered. We just assumed we didn't have it, but this talk about fundamentals has got me thinking. Why not try again?"

Elisabeth waved her hand around, the sword responding to her movements.

"Ok, so far so good," Elisabeth unsummoned that sword and summoned a polearm. Tentatively, she sat on it, much like sitting on a broomstick. "Here goes." She closed her eyes to focus and sat. The polearm supported her weight, held up by nothing but her magic.

"That's good," Nettle smiled.

"Uh-oh," Elisabeth frowned.

"Uh-oh?" Nettle tilted her head and flew a little closer to Elisabeth.

"I can't move." This time, Elisabeth's brow furrowed. She wobbled in the the air. "I think I might need that help after all."

"Here, take my hand," Nettle offered her hand to Elisabeth, who grabbed it.

"Let's do this slow," Elisabeth breathed out and opened her eyes.

"Do you know how to swim?" Nettle asked as she slowly pulled Elisabeth over the edge of the Scar, Elisabeth sweating to keep the control of the polearm. "I always imagine flying as some kind of swimming."

"Like swimming through water?"

Elisabeth half-laughed. "Never learned. You'll have to teach me that later too."

"Sure," Nettle supported Elisabeth over open air, the cliff-face within arm's reach. "Just breath slow and don't panic."

We're naturally buoyant in water."

"We're not in water," Elisabeth pointed out, trying very hard not to look down.

"No, but we're in magic and magic is buoyant if we want it to be," Nettle then had a thought. Another lesson from her mother. "Hey Elisabeth, what's so tough about keeping yourself up?"

"The weight," Elisabeth said through grit teeth. "It's like I'm holding up five of me."

"How are you holding it up?" Nettle asked. "With your hands?"

"With my magic, Nettle. What are you getting at?"

"Magic is often a battle of the mind vs reality," Nettle pulled Elisabeth further from the cliff-face. "If your magic is in your mind and not your body, what's really stopping you from holding yourself up?"

"Nettle, is this really the time?" Elisabeth got very nervous.

"A good as time as any," Nettle suddenly wore an impish smile. *Is this how mother felt teaching me how to fly?* "Take a deep breath, Elisabeth. This was your plan after all. I'm ready to catch you."

Elisabeth took a deep breath. The polearm wobbled in the air, Elisabeth wobbling with it. "What are you getting at, Nettle? No teaching riddles, explain it clearly."

"It's simple and complex all at once. The world wants us to stay grounded. We want to fly. You've just got to want it more."

"Nettle, that doesn't make a lick of sense," Elisabeth wobbled more.

"Yeah in hindsight, my mother's spiel didn't work for me either," Nettle returned to Elisabeth's side and supported her and the polearm. "When you or Elmond swing a sword, how do you put more power into it?"

"With our bodies, with leverage," Elisabeth responded. Nettle saw a light go off in her head. "There's a different leverage point for magic."

"There we go," Nettle nodded. "While the fundamentals are the same for everyone, that leverage will be different. It'll be based on you and how you think, so your brother will have a different leverage. So that begs the question - what is your leverage? What do you lean on?"

"My leverage..." Elisabeth looked down; though the two had slowly descended, it was at a snail's pace. The other group were long gone and into the darkness of the Scar. Elisabeth moved a little faster on the polearm. She wobbled still, but it looked to Nettle she had more control. Elisabeth looked at Nettle and grinned. "Get ready to catch me."

Nettle let Elisabeth go.

Elisabeth dropped a little bit, but she didn't fall outright. Then, with a newfound determination, she moved up to Nettle, then around, then flew to the center of the Scar.

"There we go," Nettle flew to Elisabeth. "And now you can fly."

"Yeah, I can fly," Elisabeth smiled. "You're a much better teacher than my

family. Let's catch up with the others."

Nettle nodded.

The two of them flew around the Scar. All around the Scar, there were large patches of ice that Nettle gravitated towards.

"What's this?" Elisabeth asked her. She touched it, but pulled her hand away like it burned her. "That's very cold."

"Ice Eternal," Nettle explained.

"Magical ice from a caster so skilled it cannot be melted under normal means."

"You'd probably need an equivalent force of flame," Elisabeth said.

"Yeah," Nettle traced the ice, her fingers turning blue from the cold. "An equivalent force."

The two of them reached the bottom of the Scar, where Elmond and the researchers were already settling in.

"Oh good!" the researcher waved them over. "You didn't fall to your death! We were getting a little worried when you did not come down!"

"No, we're ok," Nettle gestured to Elisabeth, who was still floating on her polearm. "Just teaching her how to fly."

"Check it out Elmond," Elisabeth flew circles around him. "Another step closer to legend."

Elmond looked at her sister in silence.

"I can teach you too," Nettle offered.

"No, it's ok," Elmond looked at his own hands. "I've got another thing on my mind. Another ability."

"We can figure that out on our way to Emain," Elisabeth said.

Elmond nodded, but Nettle could tell it stuck on his mind.

"Thank you very much, young'uns," the old researcher gave Elmond a gem. "This'll serve as proof for your guild. You can stay the night if you'd wish. This site isn't as active as Mallach, so there'll no doubt be extra cots."

"We'll keep that in mind," Nettle said. "It's up to you, Elmond."

"It would be best for the night," Elmond said. "We could use the roof over our heads." And then he wandered off.

"I'll keep track of him," Elisabeth got back onto the ground and chased after Elmond.

Nettle also wandered around. It was cold enough down here for her to see her breath, chunks of eternal ice in all sorts of places. The buildings themselves were sparse and from what Nettle could see, she could count the amount of people who weren't researchers on one hand. Since it was noon, the natural light of the sun made it down here.

She heard the sound of running water. Nettle found a river; to someone coming across the Scar, the river would have been what cut through this canyon.

The corner of her mouth twitched into a knowing grin. "But that isn't quite what happened, right mother?"

Nettle found a pillar of ice next to the river. She sat next to it, listening to the water and breathing deep of the cold.

"Ice eternal," Nettle sighed.

Eternal no longer. A familiar voice

spoke in her head.

Nettle whipped her head around. "Who said that?!" She jumped to her feet and willed her magic.

Search. A pulse of magic washed over her surroundings.

Each pillar of ice was an immediate cold front, but that was expected. The researchers were in some of the buildings. Elmond and Elisabeth were next to each other at the cliff side. Her magic found tunnels that went further within. The mining operations.

Just as Nettle relaxed, her magic found something scorching hot upstream. It was approaching, very fast.

Nettle took to the air and found Elisabeth and Elmond in a flash.

"Nettle?" Elmond saw Nettle's panic. "What's wrong."

"Round up everyone and get to a safe place, right now!" Nettle commanded. "Incoming witch!"

Nettle didn't check to see if they'd follow, she returned to the air and flew towards the heat to meet it. Nettle saw red in the distance. Already, the temperature around her raised high enough to melt the eternal ice.

"*Shield!*" Nettle yelled with her voice, with her soul, and with her hands, throwing up a barrier with her magic. She managed just in time - at that same moment, fire and flame collided with her.

She was almost thrown from the air by the sheer force, but it's been a fruitful couple of days since she's last been

tested. This time, Nettle will not find herself wanting.

The flames stormed and whirled in front of her, pushing for any weakness. Nettle could scarcely make out the shape of someone within the core, a person emanating heat like they were the sun.

Ice turned to steam and all around Nettle, water poured to the river below. The person within reached the shield, hair trailing her like a comet. An unearthly roar ripped through it.

"Alright Fragment," Nettle grit her teeth. Magic welled within her. "Dance with me!"

She converted the shield into force and pulsed magic through it. It generated enough force to push the fire back a moment and allowed Nettle the time to cast another spell.

"BANG," She shouted and pulled out a magic sphere, slamming it into the fire. It roared again, though it was overtaken by an explosion that knocked Nettle towards the water. She slipped underneath the river for a moment, then willed herself towards the surface.

Nettle coughed out some water and dragged herself onto the river bank.

"Nettle!" Elmond rushed towards her from somewhere and helped Nettle to her feet. "Elisabeth is evacuating everyone else, we need to buy some time."

"I hit her with the same thing I hit the raiju," Nettle pointed towards where she flew from. "How's she looking?"

Water got to their ankles, joining the river and turning it into a rapid. Heat

continued to rise and where Nettle could see her breath, all she could feel was sweat from her brow.

The flames reconstituted itself in the air above them both. Fire and water mixed and mingled, steam starting to rise. With the amount of ice melting, a flood was only minutes away from occurring.

"Can you give me some footholds?" Elmond asked. "I haven't figured out flying yet, but I've got some tricks for this situation."

"I can manage that," Nettle nodded. "What have you got?"

Elmond held his hand to his chest and muttered something that Nettle couldn't hear. Light leaked from his palm and when he reached out, a gleaming sword appeared. He gripped it and there was a fire in his eyes that wasn't there before. He pointed it at the reconstituted flame.

"I am an Essaim," Elmond said. "By the powers vested in my family's sword I will strike you down!"

Nettle flew, Elmond jumping after her.

Elmond was not kidding when he said all he needed was some footholds. Nettle used miniature shields to support him, but Elmond jumped much higher than she expected, only needing two to cross the gap between them and oncoming fire.

Nettle was worried that Elmond just got himself burned to a crisp, but her worries were dispelled as the flames were. With a swing of his sword, Elmond cut through the flames like he was cutting through wheat. He curled like a spring - Nettle offered another foothold, which he sprung off of and cut into the fragment.

Nettle flew around the core to catch Elmond. While he reoriented himself, Nettle casted orb after orb, trying to keep the Fragment from regenerating. Her strength was good, but Elmond's sword was stronger. He jumped back into the fray, cutting through fire and flame to find his mark.

Even with their firepower, it was all they could do to hold the Witch Fragment in place. The Fragment still melted the ice around them, turning the river below them to a full flood.

After one clash, Elmond suddenly stopped on a foothold. He dropped to one knee, the sword disappearing.

"Are you alright?" Nettle asked him.

"I've been better," Elmond summoned an greataxe and used that to prop himself up. "The family sword takes a lot out of me. Can only use it for a short while. Any other tricks up your sleeve?"

Nettle looked within herself, at the internal barrier that blocked her from her

most potent abilities.

"If it's that or dying," Nettle shattered a portion of the barrier. Her eyes glowed a deep, verdant green. "And I don't think either of us fancy dying here."

"You've been holding back on us," Elmond grinned, but that grin turned to amazement as Nettle put a hand on his shoulder, his own body being suffused with light as well. He stood a little straighter, vitality returning to him. "Who are you?"

"Nettle," Nettle said. "Same as you've known."

"Well, that's good enough for me!" Elmond jumped back into the fray just as the Fragment finished regenerating.

Magic welled within Nettle, a portion of the dam that held it back, broken. She shared that magic with Elmond, empowering him with strikes that weren't as strong as the sword, but much more numerous. This was much more sustainable.

But as sustainable as this pattern was and as strong as the two have become, the Fragment was naught to be denied.

She roared and for every strike landed, the fragment gave as good as was gotten. Nettle controlled several magical orbs, constantly sending them into the mix and exploding after Elmond had to retreat to a foothold, but the flames engulfed them and shot after Nettle.

Nettle dodged as best she could and though she dodged the blasts, she was starting to be burned. She tried to further break the seal within her, but it

burned when she tried to attempt it. No, the first break was already enough stress.

Elmond wasn't doing much better. He's suffered most of the burns and despite the magic he was getting from Nettle, he was starting to flag.

The two of them thought the same thing. They needed an extra piece. They needed the Sword to break this stalemate.

Nettle knew that if Elmond hasn't summoned the Sword again by now, it would come at great cost to him. No doubt, if push came to shove, but Nettle didn't want it to come to that.

No, it's enough to continue as it.

Without communicating, Elmond must've came to the same conclusion as Nettle did, redoubling his efforts despite burns appearing on his body. Nettle collected burns of her own. If only they had a little more...

"Elmond!" Elisabeth's voice cut through the fire, though Nettle couldn't find her. "By power vested in my family's sword!"

Elmond paused at a foothold and closed his eyes, breathing out. Fire followed him.

Nettle didn't see any other options. He needed time to do whatever his and Elisabeth's plan was. Nettle put herself between Elmond and the Fragment. Her shield held for now, yet even as she held it, the flames surrounded them both. It started to crack.

"I will strike you down!" Elmond finished the chant and then disappeared completely.

Nettle focused the shield to just her

and then pushed through the fire. Her shield cracked as she escaped the flames, Nettle's skin cracking underneath the burn. Flying above the flame, Nettle found Elisabeth at the top, swords orbiting her and pushing other flames away. She pointed down, swords being launched and melted in the fire, some reaching their mark.

Nettle found Elmond, who was already on the fragment, the sword buried deep within.

"Now!" Elisabeth shouted at Nettle.

Nettle dug deep, pulling magic within and without. Instead of sending the orb towards the fragment, Nettle tried something. Whether it was because of the heat of battle or shattered a seal, Nettle collected all of the orbs that she could control at once and held them in front of her. She released energy from one end, sending out a torrent of raw magic ahead of her.

Nettle trusted Elmond to get out of the way. There wasn't enough time to check.

The torrent ripped straight through, carving a whole in the ground below. Nettle put all that she had into it, not letting up until darkness tinged her vision. The core of the fragment pierced through her magic, appearing in front of Nettle, hands outstretched to grab her.

"*SISTER!!*," The fragment hissed, before being thrown back into the torrent.

The magic faded. The flames were extinguished, the only thing left of the fragment being a charred body. Magic escaped from cracks within in, but it was far diminished. It dropped into the flood

below and disappeared. Nettle also dropped from the air, but Elisabeth was there to catch her.

"Nice shot," Elisabeth said. "I think you got it."

"Did Elmond get out of the way in time?" Nettle mumbled, fighting to stay awake.

Elisabeth pointed at the cliff-side, where Elmond hung from a sword. His head was also nodding off.

"Good, good..." Nettle trailed off, sleep overtaking her.

"Woah, stay with me now," Elisabeth shook Nettle awake. "I can't get both of you out of here. You'll have to help me get Elmond out of here."

"I just," Nettle took a breath. "I just need to catch my breath. That took a lot out of me."

"I can see that," Elisabeth closed her eyes.

Nettle felt a little warmth return to her limbs. A little bit of magic returned to her.

The two wobbled in the air, but with newfound strength, Nettle got her flight back and stabilized them both.

"Phew," Elisabeth opened her eyes. "Will that do it?"

"You didn't have to do that," Nettle said.

"Nettle, we are hanging in open air, right above a flood that is about to get worse," Elisabeth held a wry smile. "We don't have that luxury."

Nettle nodded and shook off her

exhaustion. "Sorry, yeah. Right. Let's go." She flew over to Elmond and grabbed him by one, burned arm. Elisabeth flew to the other side and grabbed the other arm. Together, the two flew back out of the Scar and onto solid ground, where the rest of the researchers were waiting. Nettle and Elmond collapsed on the spot, but they were both breathing.

"Oh thank goodness you all are alright!" The old researcher rushed over to the three of them. "We couldn't see what was exactly going on, but even from this distance we could feel the magic being thrown around down there. Every so often fire would shoot out of the Scar itself!"

"We managed it, somehow," Elisabeth said. "Any of you know healing?"

"Yes, of course!" The old researcher beckoned for one of his comrades to come by. "While we're not medically trained like a proper cleric or surgeon, we know enough first aid to get by! As long as you've got all your bits, we should be enough."

The old researcher got to work on Nettle, bandaging her burns and humming soft spells to cure her wounds. The other started on Elmond, but after a moment, asked for the old researcher to join them.

His wounds were far worse - no wonder, since he was at the forefront of it.

"Oh dear," the old researcher said. "Elmond's hanging on by the slimmest of margins. Once we do what we can, he'll need a lot of time to recover."

"I can take care of that," Nettle said

in between catching her breath. She looked around, finding no trees or plants around. "We'll have to move back to the checkpoint, but once there, I can heal him."

"Can you use that cloth platform over long distances?" Elisabeth asked the old researcher.

"It doesn't matter if I can or not," the old researcher smiled. "All that matters is that we have to. Don't worry, we'll manage."

"Let's get going. With any luck, we'll be there before nightfall," Elisabeth helped Nettle to her feet, the other researchers carrying Elmond onto the cloth platform.

On the way back, a concussive *BOOM* reverberated through the Scar. Further downstream to the east, a red gout of fire shot into the sky.

Nettle saw that and started to rush in that direction before her exhaustion took her.

"Hang on, Nettle," Elisabeth caught her. "We turned that thing into ashes. Hopefully, that's just a dying gasp."

"And if it's not?" Nettle asked, her voice quiet.

"Then we're in no state to chase after it," Elisabeth pulled Nettle back in the direction of the checkpoint. "Besides, I'm not going anywhere until my brother is back on his feet."

Nettle looked over to Elmond, who was breathing, burned, and bandaged. Nettle took a deep breath.

"You're right," Nettle leaned on

Elisabeth. "I'm just not thinking clearly."

"Obviously not," Elisabeth propped Nettle up and said nothing more.

The checkpoint was abuzz with activity by the time they returned to it. While the amount of guards stayed the same, a scant handful, they were running around performing various tasks with a new fervor that was new to Nettle.

"You there," one pointed at Nettle's group. "State your business."

"Recovering from a Witch attack," Elisabeth explained. "We have two injured."

"From Digen?" the guard asked.

"Yes, from Digen," the researcher took over the conversation and started explaining the situation to the guard in full.

In the meantime, Nettle found a place to sit down, Elmond being set down beside her. Elisabeth kept standing, but leaned beside a building.

Nettle caught her breath and closed her eyes. She felt for the plants around her - some grass, an odd tree or two. Not a whole lot up here, but it'll be enough. She pulled the energy and made it her own.

Revitalized somewhat, Nettle reached out to Elmond and knitted his wounds as best she could.

The majority of his burns smoothed out to healthy skin, some life returning to his cheeks. Elmond breathed easier his eyes fluttering open.

"Did we... Did we do it?" He groaned.

"Yeah, barely," Elisabeth sighed and sat down next to them. "What did you call that, Nettle? A witch fragment?"

Nettle nodded.

"Ancestors forbend," Elmond made a symbol with his hands that Nettle didn't recognize. "If that's a fragment, the whole article must be the real deal." He groaned as he sat up, trying to prop himself upright.

"Nettle," Elisabeth's voice was quiet. "That fragment spoke. It said 'sister.'"

Nettle kept quiet, waiting for Elisabeth to continue.

"That wouldn't have been referring to you, would it?"

Elmond's eyes widened. "Elisabeth, surely you don't mean-"

"Yeah," Nettle sighed. "She was referring to me. The fragment, anyway."

"You said your home was one of the first attacked by the Witch," Elisabeth said. "How much of that is true?"

"All of it," Nettle said. "My eldest sister turned into some *thing* and attacked our home. Burned it to the ground. Our mother lost first. Then my other sister."

"And you?"

"Barely made it out alive," Nettle hugged her knees. "I haven't lied to you. Not once. Just left certain things out."

"Nettle, we're risking our lives for this, we need any edge we can get. If you're holding out on us, that's dangerous," Elisabeth pushed. "We need to know."

"Ok," Nettle nodded and looked around.

"But not here. I only want you two to know. Not anyone else."

"But--"

"Ok," Elmond laid back down. "When we next make camp on the way to Emain, you can tell us."

"Elmond," Elisabeth looked like she wanted to protest. "Don't you think we need to know now? You almost died!"

In that moment, the sound of a teleport pulled everyone's attention to the center of the checkpoint. An imposing man in black metal armor appeared with a cloud of dust swirling around him. He dropped to one knee, bracing himself with a greatsword as tall as he was. His armor was charred and melted off.

"Blasted fragment," he coughed.

"Sir, do you need assistance?" one of the guards ran up to him.

The man waved him off. "No, I'll live. See to it that others are checked first. The Fragment was already weakened when it got to Mallach. I don't want to think about how it got to that state." He scanned the checkpoint and spotted Nettle and the rest.

He walked over. "I don't recognize you three, state your purpose."

"Adventurers," Elmond said. "We were escorting researchers to Mallach and Digen."

"To Digen?" the man rubbed his chin. "That's where the Fragment came from."

"We noticed." Elmond sounded far too tired to be in a cordial mood.

"So we have you three to thank for

weakening it," the man said. "I'm glad you're not hurt."

"It took a lot out of us," Elisabeth cut into the conversation. "Would you mind giving us space to rest?"

"Of course, apologies," He turned to step away. "Oh right, allow me to introduce myself first. My name is Nail, Commander of the Ashen Research Division. Thank you for escorting our researchers both to the Scar and away from. We can take this from here. I'll see to it that you three aren't disturbed and I'll leave an extra reward to the Guild."

"Cheers," Elmond gave a thumbs up.

With that sense of security, all three of them fell asleep on the spot.

When they were fully rested, Nettle and the Essaim twins bid the researchers farewell as they began their trek to Emain. The port city was on the eastern part of the continent; follow the Scar until they reach where the land meets the water, then travel south until they reach the city proper. It'll take four days to travel the length of the scar, another three to reach the city proper.

The first day of traveling was mostly in silence. Nettle knew she had to share her story with the Elmond and Elisabeth. She was mulling over how. How much do they need to know? What do they need to know? Will they still help if they knew?

Nettle steeled herself within. Elisabeth was right; if they're risking their lives to help her, they deserve to know who she is. When they setup camp for the night, Nettle sat in front of the

campfire, waiting for Elizabeth and Elmond to sit on opposite to her.

Elmond finished setting up the blade perimeter, Elisabeth finishing her spell.

"Search," Nettle's magic pulsed around to check them all. She didn't find anything of note. "We're alone out here. Shall I begin?"

Elmond nodded.

"Where should I start..." Nettle said aloud. "You already know that I was adopted. The same is for my eldest sister, Ivy, and for my older sister Thistle. My mother, a witch of the village, raised us and taught us magic."

"How much of that is true?" Elisabeth asked.

"All of it," Nettle said. "When I told you I lost Ivy first, that was the half-lie. *Something* happened to her, I don't know what. She was having an argument with our mother when the flames begun."

I was outside with my older sister, Thistle. This was a long time ago. My fundamentals were truly awful then, can barely control one orb, let alone two. Thistle was teaching me, trying to explain to me how magic worked. It was tough for both of us. Thistle and Ivy both took to magic like ducks to water. Me? I had no talent. Took me three or four times as long as them to learn anything.

While Thistle taught me, our mother taught Ivy. Ivy was the most talented out of the three of us. A prodigy. It didn't surprise us when Ivy stormed out of the house in the middle of an argument with mother.

Our mother always told her to be careful, something that Ivy took heed of half of the time.

I don't know what they were arguing about, only that Thistle looked worried. She told me to back inside. I refused, of course. I wanted to see what they were fighting about this time.

See, the thing is, is that Ivy was very good at fire magic. It was no surprise to us to see her ignite. Her auburn hair became fire, smoke coming out of her mouth with every word.

Typically, Mother teleports her away in an instant, sending Ivy somewhere else to cool off. This time was different.

There was something uncanny about the fire that Ivy was engulfed in. Something that I couldn't see, but Thistle and Mother did. The next thing I knew, Thistle and I were in the air, flying away from our home.

I looked back just in time to see fire and ice collide. Where my sister excelled in fire, mother was a master of ice. I thought she'd win. Then the fire got hotter, the ice smaller. And then, the ice disappeared, leaving only flames in it's wake.

Thistle took us away. I don't know where, as I begged her to go back to help Mother. No amount of crying would sway her, no amount of begging. By the time I calmed down, we were somewhere on the eastern border.

Then, when Thistle made sure I couldn't follow, she flew back. I didn't know what else to do, so I ran after her on foot. Can you imagine? A young girl crying through the wilderness after losing everything she cared about.

My older sister must've realized that too, returning and finding me curled up next to a tree. Thistle held me tight. I cried. I think she did too. We lost our family. We lost our home.

We laid low for awhile, then returned to where it happened. Our home was reduced to ashes and cinders. Whatever stood crumbled upon itself when touched.

There was a crater at ground zero. Where Ivy first engulfed herself in flame. We couldn't find our mother, but Thistle found a blast shadow near the center of the crater.

I think that was when her war started. We wandered around for a long time after that. I didn't notice at first. Sometimes when I woke up in our newest camp, Thistle wouldn't be there. Then she'd be gone for

longer. Sometimes, I'd spend entire time at a camp without Thistle coming home. I worried. Even when she said I shouldn't. I noticed the burn marks on her - she wasn't good at natural healing like I am now.

Then, one day, somewhere in the Southwest, Thistle told me she was going.

"Be good," she told me. "Stay safe. I'll be back soon."

At the time, I felt like she was trusting me with something, so I was glad she was sharing her burden with me. So I waited. I waited a day. Then two days. Then three.

Then, on the fourth day, a pillar of flame erupted not far from where we stayed.

I don't know what I was thinking when I saw it. But I ran towards it as fast as I could. I think somewhere along the way, I learned a little bit of flight. When I got there, there she was. Not my older sister, Thistle.

Ivy had just finished burning something away, fire flickering on her skin. She turned to me, eyes red with heat, flame, and magic.

"Ivy?" I called out to her. "Where's Thistle? What did you do to mom!?" Questions burst out of me faster than I could think. "Ivy! What happened to you?"

She didn't answer me. Not in a way that I understood at the time.

Then all I saw was darkness. Not darkness in terms of black. But light so bright I couldn't see. When I came to, I was alone in a crater. Ivy was nowhere to be found and I lost another sister.

That's when my war started. My war against my eldest sister, the Witch of Summer.

The Witch of Summer... I don't think I ever explained that, did I? It was a nickname our mother gave to her. For her fiery personality. Thistle was the Witch of Fall.

I didn't get a nickname like that. Too young at the time. Not strong enough to really show what I excelled at.

For many years, I chased after fire. Not really strong enough to to anything about it. My war continued. The rest, I've already said.

Nettle was quiet after sharing her story with Elmond and Elisabeth. She held her knees and looked into the fire from remembering her past. Nettle hadn't talked about Thistle in a long time. For a long while, the only sound was the crackling of the fire.

"Our family is kind of cursed," Elmond said.

"Elmond!" Elisabeth exclaimed and slapped his arm.

"What? Nettle told us her deal, only fair that we tell her ours."

"That is not what that means!" Elisabeth grumbled. "We needed to know where she stands. I wasn't about to walk into lead into a family ordained trap!"

Elmond shrugged.

"You don't mind?" Nettle asked Elmond.

"Not really, no," Elmond said. "And though Elisabeth is making a fuss about it, she doesn't really."

"You do not speak for me," Elisabeth frowned.

"Ignore her, anyway," Elmond summoned a sword. "Family troubles. We're no strangers to them. The powers that we wield can also corrupt us. Somehow. I don't know how. But it does."

"Cursed how?" Nettle asked. "No, never mind, you just said you didn't know."

"You don't get that Elisabeth?" Elmond asked his sister. "Strange voices whispering to you about more power?"

Elisabeth didn't respond. Instead she crossed her arms and looked into the fire.

"You do, don't you?" Elmond said. Then

he turned to Nettle "For me, it was when we were fighting your sister's fragment."

"What did it offer you?" Nettle asked him.

Elmond threw the sword behind him. Then, he shattered into light and reappeared where the sword was.

"What did it give me?' is a better question to ask," Elmond said. "I can teleport to my swords now. Or any weapon in our family armory. Like how we can carry ourselves on our weapons, we're one step closer to the legend."

"I don't see how this is relevant," Elisabeth finally spoke up.

"It's because I want to keep helping," Elmond said. "And we need to get stronger."

"You'll help still?" Nettle asked, looking up from the fire. "We almost died from just fighting the fragment."

Elmond shrugged. "Were you going to give up if we turned away from your quest?"

Nettle didn't answer. She wasn't going to, of course.

"The best of our family was more than an adventurer. He was a hero," Elmond said. "Maybe he was fighting the curse the same we are now. If we want to prove that the Essaim family is still a heroic family, than it'll take more than almost dying to stop me."

"Honestly," Elisabeth shook her head. "Elmond, we don't have to bear the weight of our family's reputation on our back."

"No, we don't," Elmond said. "But it's still the right thing to do."

"Elmond, I don't know what to say," Nettle said. "Thank you."

"What you can say is explain how you powered up back in the Scar," Elmond grinned. "What was that all about?"

"Oh, before I entered Ashen, I placed a limiter on my magic," Nettle explained. "I didn't want to draw any attention in case there were people who found out about my heritage."

"Especially since if you're related to the Witch burning the countryside," Elmond surmised.

"Exactly."

"Do you still have that same limiter?" Elmond asked.

Nettle looked within herself. She did, a portion that restricted the other half of her magic. She nodded.

"Do you think you can remove it?"

She poked at it mentally. Her body broke out into a sweat; this was not something that was going to be easy, even if the first two breaks were.

"A part of me says I shouldn't," Nettle said. "It would be dangerous to."

"So it can be a life or death thing," Elmond said. He scratched his head and walked back to his seat, starting at the sky above.

"Elmond," Elisabeth spoke, her voice soft. "Are you sure about this? Nettle, it's not that I don't want to help you but..."

"I'm sure, Isabeth," Elmond said. "While you're content to get by doing quests for the guild for the rest of our

lives, I'm not."

Elisabeth sighed. "Very well." She looked at Nettle. "Our lives are in your hands. Let's get stronger together so we're not so heavy." She winked at her.

"Yeah," Nettle smiled. "Let's."

"Alright everyone, time to train on the way," Elmond said as everyone packed camp in the morning.

"That's easy for you to say, but the better question is how," Elisabeth kicked dirt over the fire. "Surely you don't mean to just spin swords in the air."

"Spin swords in the air while we walk, then swing them while we've stopped," Elmond said. "That was my plan."

"It's not a bad idea," Nettle shouldered her pack while the other two stored theirs within their magic. "The basics are always important."

"Fundamentals, yeah," Elisabeth rolled her eyes. "But there has to be something more we can do. If that's what we're up against, steady improvement might not be enough. Your sister is growing stronger by the day, is she not?"

"That's true," Elmond thought to himself. "Come to think of it, what do you think Nettle? What do we do when we're done with the fundamentals?"

"My mother told me that we're never really done with fundamentals," Nettle said. "They take a day to learn but a lifetime to perfect."

"Unfortunately, we don't have a lifetime," Elisabeth pointed out.

"No, we don't," Nettle agreed. "So to know best, we have to find out limits."

"Not break them?" Elmond summoned a bunch of swords at once, then unsummoned them as a point.

"You have to find something to break it," Nettle explained. "And the fundamentals are there to support your

baseline. The higher your baseline, the higher your limit."

"Meaning?"

"Meaning you have to do both," Nettle pulled together several magic orbs. She was in the double digits now. "Just a week ago, I could only handle a handle of these. Now, look how much I can do. Besides, how did you control so many swords at once Elisabeth?"

"What do you mean?" Elisabeth asked.

"When you joined us fighting the fragment, you summoned so many swords and threw them all at once, like a veritable storm," Nettle held a small, confident smile. "A couple nights ago, you said three was your maximum."

"That was because-" Elisabeth stopped.

"It doesn't matter what it was because of," Nettle said. "You have it now. So here's how we're going to do this."

Taking small break on the side of the road, Nettle explained the strategy. The first day would be about testing limits. Whatever their maximum strength is, they find. For Nettle, she would have to find how many orbs she can control at once, how dense she can make them, and how finely she can do so.

Elisabeth, though begrudgingly, also bought in to Nettle's approach. Her exploration would be flight and weapons control, similar to Nettle except instead of orbs, it would be weapons.

Elmond was a little harder to pin down. Unlike Nettle and Elisabeth, his maximum wasn't about quantity. For him, he'd have to figure out how to swing his weapon

harder. Nettle decided to teach him basic enhancement magic as well as finding out the limit of his new teleport.

"Remember," Nettle said as she finished explaining. "Find your limits safely. You don't need to push yourself as if this was life or death. Once we find our limits, then we'll push them."

"Surely we need more than that," Elisabeth said.

"We will," Nettle agreed. "But, for now, just focus on the first step."

They didn't travel much on the first day on account of focusing on their training. Nettle and Elisabeth trained together due to their similar tasks. Nettle pushed her control to as far as it can go, creating numerous orbs and orbiting them around her. Once created them, she filled them with magic as dense as she could make it.

Above her, Elisabeth spun her own weapons. She only pulled out five or six before visibly straining. Nettle watched her push for seven before having to catch her from the strain.

"Thanks," Elisabeth said. "I think I can do it."

"Don't push yourself too hard," Nettle said. "We still have an entire journey to go through."

Then Elisabeth continued above, though Nettle hadn't quite needed to catch her since.

Elmond's training was different. He needed to figure out the exact parameters of his teleport. He stuck a bunch of weapons into the dirt and stood away from

them. He'd teleport to one, record the distance, then stood further and further until he couldn't teleport to it anymore. How many times can he teleport in quick succession, whether not his momentum carried over, things like that. Does he have to teleport to his own weapons or can weapons that Elisabeth summons can be teleported to.

At the campfire, Nettle called the other two to go over next steps.

"Now that we know our limits, we push them," Nettle explained. "Things that we can kinda do have to turn into things we can effortlessly. Learn one process, then add another, and another."

"That's fine, Nettle, basic stuff," Elisabeth furrowed her brow. "But that's just more of the same."

"It is but isn't," Nettle said. "Like I said earlier, we are raising our baseline. For something outside of that, you'll have to get creative."

Nettle brought an orb to her; now she perpetually just had a few orbiting around her at all times.

"I've been using these as explosive balls of force," Nettle explained. "But instead of detonating them all at once, what happens if I control the flow?"

Demonstrating, she shot a beam of magic towards the sky.

"It's basic, but it's just a matter of options," Nettle let the orb go and it collected magic on it's own again.

"Elmond and Elisabeth, if fundamentals aren't cutting it for you, you'll have to think on your own how to create something

that packs a punch," Nettle said.

"Maybe not on our own," Elmond looked at Elisabeth. "Even if they never taught us, our family told us the stories."

"Stories of controlling a thousand swords and ripping through armies like wildfire," Elisabeth said. "I've got the thousand swords."

"And I'll be the wildfire," Elmond finished. He got up and summoned a sword. Then, he just started swinging, practicing his form.

"There he goes," Nettle laughed to herself. "I was going to teach enhancement magic, but I guess that's fine to."

"Nettle, can you help me with something?" Elisabeth called Nettle a little bit away from the camp.

"Sure, what do you need," Nettle followed her.

The two of them walked out Elmond's earshot and then a little more.

"I'm sorry," Elisabeth said, out of the blue.

"What?" Nettle tilted her head. "What for?"

"For doubting you," Elisabeth sighed. "I know you told us you were fighting this on your own, but when it called you sister I reacted poorly."

"It's fine, Elisabeth," Nettle assured her. "I'm just glad you still want to help me knowing what you know now."

"Elmond has a one track mind like that," Elisabeth wore a wry smile. "He's determined to live up to his ancestors somehow. That actually brings me to the

second thing I wanted to talk about."

"Speak your mind."

"It's obvious I'm worried about Elmond," Elisabeth said. "He's right about the curse, of course. But he thinks I heard the same voices he did when I joined the fray."

"You didn't?"

"No, I did not. Similar to you, I was a little creative when I summoned the amount of swords that I did," Elisabeth looked down. "I know what he's talking about though. It's what afflicted our founder."

"How do you know this?" Nettle lowered her voice to a hush and looked back to Elmond. He was still practicing his swings.

"Our home had a library," Elisabeth looked back at Elmond too. "It even has a forbidden section. That was fun. Anyway, I'm getting sidetracked. Nettle, this curse targets the strongest of our family. Always, it feeds them power and lulls sweet words into their minds. Then, at the peak of their strength, their body is taken."

"Taken by what?"

"Taken over," Elisabeth clarified. "They take their bodies and then wreak havoc with incredible efficiency. I don't know who they are, I don't know what they want with our family, but they always do and they always win."

"Ok, the curse is bad," Nettle said. "What's the plan?"

"The only thing we can do," Elisabeth summoned a bunch of swords in the air. "Get strong enough that he doesn't need to

lean on the voice to survive."

"The reasons have changed, but the mission stays the same," Nettle surmised. "I know what I'm going to do beyond fundamentals. Do you have any idea for yourself?"

"Kind of," Elisabeth slammed the swords into the ground. Then, she focused and pushed them deeper. The swords went as deep as they could, about halfway into the dirt. "When you were teaching me how to fly yesterday, I put a lot of thought into what you said about magic. About what's really stopping me from holding myself up."

Nettle tilted her head as the beginnings of a grin played at the corner of her mouth.

Elisabeth closed her eyes. Then, as sudden as a twitch, all of the swords forced their way into the dirt like they were stabbing air.

"Magic is unreasonable like that," Nettle grinned fully. "We can work off that."

The path to the coast was more light-hearted after that night. The path alongside the Scar was wild and unruly to walking travelers but as part of their training, they flew over most of it.

Nettle and Elisabeth pushed their abilities together. Elmond continued to train his strength and his teleport.

He talked with Elisabeth as Nettle watched the two of them develop a combination attack. The teleport was for any of the Essaim weapons, meaning that Elisabeth can throw weapons ahead of him

and he can teleport, swing, then teleport as many times as he could manage.

When making camp, Nettle also taught Elmond basic reinforcement.

"Most mages instinctively use magic to defend themselves. As a small crutch, you can visualize the magic covering yourself," Nettle explained. "Like blood traveling through your veins, magic is traveling through your bones, your muscles, and everything else. Even without actively controlling the magic, it'll increase your strength, speed, reactions, and durability."

The magic filled Elmond's body and Nettle conjured a shield for Elmond to test his abilities on. With a punch, Elmond shattered it.

"That was enough to hold off the Raiju," Nettle said. "Add this to your fundamentals and you'll be able to hold off fire."

"Handy," Elmond grinned.

They tapered away from the Scar and came across the eastern coast. Cliffs overlooked the water, the trio able to hear the faintest sound of surf crashing on shore.

Nettle took a deep breath of the sea-salt, having been a long time since she's been this east. Water stretched out in front of them as far as the eye can see, disappearing over the horizon. While she watched the water, a waterspout formed.

A behemoth of a whale breached the ocean's surface, spinning in the air before slamming back into the water. It scattered the spout and despite being

closer to the horizon than to them, the force caused water to drizzle over all of them.

"A good omen," Elisabeth said.

Nettle couldn't help but agree. The weather was fair and their spirits light.

Stronger than they were at the Scar, the three of them arrived at the city of Emain.

Emain was a coastal city that wasn't as wealthy as it was beautiful. Though it had access to a port, there were no other cities on this ocean that can trade with them, leaving their only other major partner as Ashen. Despite such, their patron was one of immense power and mystery, owning a library that matches the secrets locked within Ashen vaults.

To an outsider such as Nettle, their quality of life doesn't make sense.

As Nettle and the Essaim twins entered Emain, she saw that the insiders were quite content with their lot. They entered from the North of the city and swiftly made their way to the city center, where there were an endless amount of markets and tinkers.

In the distance to the southeast, there was a lighthouse that Nettle wanted to climb the top of.

"Let's get some supplies here," Elmond said. "We've also got some simple quests we need to take care of."

"You can find us if you need to, right?" Elisabeth asked.

Search, Nettle casted a miniature search to recognize Elmond and Elisabeth's signature. "Yeah, when I need to."

"Good. I've heard the guild has a branch here, but it's been neglected. If not, we'll find an inn," Elisabeth waved her off.

Nettle took that chance to head off towards the lighthouse. She passed by the central fountain, where an peculiar woman in a shining dress and a poofy hat sat on the edge and drew circles in the water.

The woman watched Nettle rush by, something about her putting Nettle on edge. The feeling passed as swiftly as she left the central markets.

The path to the lighthouse was a little more treacherous than the rest of the city. While rest of the city was on one patch of land, the lighthouse was raised on another coastline, the two joined by a rickety wooden bridge.

Nettle looked around in case anyone was watching. When she didn't see anyone around, Nettle flew right above the bridge to cross the gap. At the bottom of the lighthouse, she dusted herself off and went inside.

The lighthouse itself was old and dilapidated. The paint was peeling off in multiple places, the wooden stairs rotting away. Nettle tested some of the steps at the start, but then she ran up the steps, using her flight to skip over the stairs that looked suspect.

At the top of the lighthouse, Nettle found the reflector broken, the lamp extinguished. She stepped onto the walkway on the outside, feeling the ocean wind and breathing deep of the salty air. Breathing out, Nettle sat down with her legs swinging over the edge.

The top right of her chest ached, the ache traveling from her shoulder and down to her elbow.

"That smarts," she rubbed it. Nettle looked where the skin ache, finding burn scars. Nettle couldn't tell if these were new or not. Her healing magic accelerated the body's natural healing. Get to a hurt

early enough and it won't scar. But, let it sit too long and it won't heal scarring. "Odd that you're only hurting now, though."

Nettle sighed, sitting with her thoughts. Everything will be fine, she told herself. They'll be ready when they next fight a fragment. Nettle and Elisabeth made a couple breakthroughs too - Elmond won't have to give in to the curse.

She heard the creaking of wood behind her as her scars ached again. Nettle got to her feet, still facing the ocean. A young man had also climbed the lighthouse, yet from the focus in his eyes, he was not focused on the lighthouse itself. Instead, he was focused on her.

Nettle left a hand on the rail and turned to him. There was something about him that was familiar. Something about the burns on his body that made her own ache in resonance.

"You've been burned," he said finally.

"So have you," Nettle returned. Someone from one of the many villages, no doubt.

"You were there," he said.

"I often was," Nettle turned away and back to the horizon.

"Why?"

"If you can do anything to make the burns stop, what would you do?" Nettle sighed. "This was all I can do."

Then, she slipped past the railing and into open air. Without really thinking about it, she flew just above the water and went back to the markets. She was hoping for the moment to herself to last

longer than it did, but it's fine. If someone recognized her, that was fine.

They deserved better than what they got. They deserved better than Nettle arriving too late to stop her family. They deserved a better answer than what she said.

Nettle stumbled as she landed in an alley, away from prying eyes.

"After so many years, I thought my heart had hardened," Nettle shook her head. "I thought I was strong enough."

"Oh ho."

Nettle looked up and at the entrance, the woman with the poofy hat was waiting for her.

"What do you want from me," Nettle leaned against the wall as she got up.

"Me? I don't want anything from you," she said. Her voice was like air, the tone like birdsong. "But my patron wishes for your presence."

"Let me get my friends and--"

"My patron asks for you and you alone."

Nettle closed her eyes as she leaned against the wall.

"Very well," Nettle nodded. "Lead me to them."

"That won't be necessary," the pointed at Nettle. A magic circle appeared underneath her.

Nettle recognized it as teleportation magic. The spell paused. Nettle looked at the caster, realizing the caster was asking for permission. Nettle nodded.

The woman winked at her and completed the spell. She blinked and she was no

longer in the alleyway. Instead, Nettle was in a dark, dark room.

Her eyes adjusted. No, the room wasn't completely dark. There were thousands of tiny lights, lights that reminded her of stars in the night sky. Nettle looked around. It wasn't just that they reminded her of stars, each light was a star.

"Nettle, Witch, daughter of Lily," a voice reverberated throughout the room. There was an echo of power to it, one that was unmistakable. She only heard that echo once before, when her mother couldn't hold her temper once. "How glad that we are finally able to meet."

"Who are you?" Nettle stepped back, trying to find the location of the voice. In response, the stars around her moved like fabric. "How do you know my mother? What do you want with me?"

"So many questions," the voice coalesced as the stars did. They wrapped themselves around a presence that Nettle couldn't exactly see. Only that she knew that they wore the night sky as a cape. **"As a gesture of good will, I will answer them. You may call me Mysteries."**

"Ok, Mysteries," Nettle nodded and kept an hand up. Magic was plentiful in this room. "Now the other two questions."

"Really? My name doesn't ring a bell?"

Nettle couldn't see the presence in front of her exactly, but somehow, she felt them drop their head a little dejected.

"I was hoping she'd talk about me a little bit, but I guess not," Mysteries

said. **"No matter. The short version is that we have a history as contemporaries. I was hoping she would consider us friends, but her pride might not have allowed that. When she is up to it, I will have to ask her."**

"Too late for that," Nettle scowled.
"She's dead."

A smile unseen. **"Are you so sure?"**

"Don't start with me," Scowling turned to anger, multiple orbs appearing around her. "I know what I saw."

"Apologies," Mysteries said. **"I had forgotten how young you are. Allow me to illuminate your darkness. But first, let's put those away, shall we?"**

In an instant, the orbs were snuffed like candles blown out. Nettle tried to summon more, but the magic wouldn't answer her.

"Who are you? Really?" Nettle placed a hand on her dagger.

"For you, an uninteresting mystery. Let us instead talk about the reason I requested your presence. About your sisters. About Fall and Summer."

"Thistle is dead," Nettle growled.
"Like my mother. They're both gone."

"Mages are silly like that," Mysteries said. **"Always keeping their secrets. Mayhap if your training had completed, you would know theirs."**

"Enough riddles!"

"Ah. Apologies. I keep getting distracted by these threads. Let me be brief and direct, as difficult as it may be for my nature. You must know three

things. The first, you are outmatched."

"We'll get stronger," Nettle said. "We have gotten stronger."

"It is not enough. Neither you nor the Essaim twins are able to defeat the Witch of Summer as you are. No matter how strong you become, the Essaim twin will have to tap into their curse. You will only trade one threat for another."

"You don't know that."

"Second, I will provide you with an boon. Towards the east, on an island covered by Magics, there is a Witch's ruin that is coveted by Ashen. Beat Ashen to the punch and you will find the boon you seek and the strength to stand against the Witch of Summer."

"Very well," Nettle held her tongue now that she has real information to work with. "And the third?"

"As for the third..." The voice belonging to Mysteries softened considerably. **"When all is said and done and you have traversed the Southern Castle to face the Witch of Summer..."** Mysteries trailed off. **"That is, once you've done what is needed to be done..."** They trailed off again. **"Oh, I don't know if I should really be telling you this."**

"Why not?"

"Rules and all that," Mysteries found some resolve. **"Stars above, bugger the rules. When you are finished with business to the South. Travel North. Past the Scar and into the Frozen Wastes, travel far to the North. Travel there. Travel there and then, tell your mother I said hello."**

"What?" Nettle's eyes widened and she rushed forward. She took another step forward but she found herself back in the alley, crashing into the woman who teleported her.

"Oh hello there," she said. "Was your conversation enlightening?"

"Send me back," Nettle demanded. "I have words with your patron."

"I am afraid I cannot," the woman calmly stepped back and dusted herself off. "My patron has given you all they can and has not requested your presence. I will not be able to change that."

Nettle anger rise within her but she took a deep breath.

"Very well. Apologies," She took a step back and composed herself. "I have received some answers, but even more questions."

"Such is the way of our patron and our city," the woman said. "I shall take my leave."

"Of course, thank you," Nettle said.

The woman bowed to her and left, eventually disappearing in the crowd.

Nettle looked across the city and sighed. As the sun began to set, Nettle wandered the markets. She spotted two of the researchers she escorted to the Scar. Those two were part of the Mallach group.

At least the Mallach team ended up ok, Nettle thought to herself. *Search.* She pulsed magic once to look for her companions. The magic returned to her with their location within the city and Nettle followed.

Nettle found them inside a shabby building. When she went inside, the interior matched the exterior. Barely maintained, hardly anyone inside, and about two months from collapsing in on itself.

Elisabeth and Elmond had a table in the center, one or two other patrons in the booths on the side. They had the map open in front of them and were discussing something when they noticed Nettle walk inside.

"Ah, Nettle," Elmond greeted. "Right on time, we finished a portion of our errands. We'll need another day to finish up completely, but we were right. There is a guild branch here."

"And is this it?" Nettle sat down with them.

"You make it sound like a bad thing," Elmond smiled as laughed to himself. "It's seen some brighter days, but it'll do for now."

"We'll be shutting down this branch at the end of the year," The bartender called out from behind his counter. "But until then, all guild services are available to guild members and their associates. Especially when said guild members have brought us out of a couple sticky situations."

"There you have it," Elmond gave him a thumbs up.

"Busy, aren't you?" Nettle asked.

"A couple of hunt quests for this guild, other errands for the main branch. We'll be getting quite the payday once we return to Ashen," Elisabeth said. "What of

you, Nettle? Did you explore the city?"

"Of sorts," Nettle took a deep breath and shared what she learned from Mysteries. She left out the part of Elmond having to succumb to his family curse in order defeat her sister. Only that they would lose.

"A possible boon and that your mother is alive?" Elisabeth sounded as surprised as Nettle felt.

Elmond let out a low whistle. "Is that something we can chase? Can we even trust that information?"

"If you did indeed get that information from the Patron, then you may trust it with your life," the bartender said. "If it's important enough that they have to get involved, you can bet it's fate altering."

"Altering good or bad?" Elmond asked him.

The bartender shrugged. "Couldn't tell you first hand. I was never important enough for an audience. We've had a couple adventurers that were in the past. From second-hand information, they either died or won big. It's about fifty-fifty in that respect."

"That so?" Elmond scratched his head in thought. "Fifty-fifty is ok odds."

"It's somewhat risky," Nettle said.

"I say we go for it," Elisabeth said.

"Elisabeth?" Nettle raised her brow. "I thought you'd be against risk."

Elisabeth shrugged. "Based on what we know now, it's either a hundred percent chance we die with the boon or a fifty-fifty that the boon is actually good and

not a trap. Not to mention the chance that your mother is alive."

"We can worry about that later," Nettle said. "If anything, I can tackle that on my own once the quest is complete."

"Absolutely not," Elmond said. "We tackle this together."

"Elmond, I—"

"His mind is set on it, Nettle," Elisabeth smiled. "You would do well to remember we're with you until the end of the line on this."

Nettle smiled at the both of them.

"Do we know where these ruins are exactly?" Elmond pointed to the map at the center of the table. "Mysteries says there's an island to the east, but our map doesn't have anything within the Fathomless."

"Islands are far and few in the Fathomless Ocean," the bartender said. "Someone ought to know more due to their rarity."

"Then let's do this like this," Elmond pulled out some guild quests. "Elisabeth and I still have a couple of these to go through tomorrow. While the two of us take care of this business, Nettle can hone in on where the island is. We don't need an exact location, though that would be best. Even a direction is fine, northeast, east, southeast."

"I'd hone in a little more than that," the bartender refuted. "They don't call it Fathomless for nothing. I'm not about to get a prolific member of the guild killed at sea because they underestimated how fathomless it really is."

"I'll find it," Nettle said with more confidence than she felt.

"If she says she'll find it, she'll find it," Elisabeth said. Then she stretched and yawned. "Alright, time to tuck in for the night."

"Agreed," Nettle nodded.

"I'll stay out a little longer," Elmond said. "Hey boss, didn't you say you had a training dummy out back?"

Nettle let Elmond off to his own devices while Elisabeth and her found their rooms.

"Nettle," Elisabeth stopped her before going to bed. "You were told more than we'd lose, weren't you?"

"Yeah," Nettle confirmed Elisabeth's suspicions. "The exact words were 'the Essaim twin will have to tap into their curse. You will only trade one threat for another.'"

"And that's no matter how strong we get?"

"That's what they said," Nettle nodded.

"Then I hope this boon is exceptional," Elisabeth said. "I really hope so."

"I do too," Nettle agreed with her and went to bed. Another suspicion played into her thoughts, but she dared not vocalize it. She dared not think on it. She dared not get her hopes up.

Nettle spent the next day looking for information on possible islands. In spite of her best efforts, no one had any concrete information on the waters as far as the eye can see.

"If you want some strange information

and rumors, your best bet is the library," someone told her. "Look, it's right over there." They pointed east, to the largest building in the city. At the very top, an observatory. "So long as your intentions aren't to burn the place to the ground, they'll let you in."

"Thank you," Nettle bowed to them, following her newest lead.

Once Nettle went inside, the receptionist scanned her for a moment, then let her inside.

"Please be careful," the receptionist said. "No open flames. Oh and trust your gut."

"Understood," Nettle said. She wandered around seemingly endless amount of bookshelves and bookcases. She pondered the advice the receptionist gave her. "Trust my gut? What does that have to do with this place?"

A book caught her eye. A brown, leather-bound tome that wasn't fully in the shelf. Nettle picked it up and read the title.

Witches and Their Castles, written by a Hugh W. Loch.

She flipped through the pages.

Witches, like the warlocks, wizards, and other magic users starting with the letter W are a type of mage. The source of their magic comes from within and without, much like wizards. However, unlike wizards, the things that make them a witch is much to do with their lineage. Witches don't come out of thin-air, like sorcerers and wizards might. No, the true mark of a witch is whether they are taught

by a witch. The original meaning of the word Witch might have stood for something else in the past, but currently in the present, that is how academics distinguish them from their peers.

Nettle scoffed a little bit from the introduction. No, a witch is... Her scoff turned into a thoughtful tilt of her head. She kept reading.

A witch who has achieved mastery as decided by their mentor often strike out into the world and create their own haven. We most often see this as a coven, perhaps in a swamp or a forest that's filled with magical potential. The strongest witches are anomalies in that respect. Instead of finding a home among wood and woad, they instead find their homes in the harshest environments. They build castles of magic and myth, challenging all who dare approach. Even should someone find the castle, they will be repelled unless they are protected by fierce magics, either by force or by blood.

"The harshest environments," Nettle repeated that line and thought to herself. "That's the clue."

Nettle set the book back in place and looked for maps of the Fathomless Ocean. Weather patterns, areas that are plagued by strange happenings and weather so bad it can only be caused by excess magic.

"One, two, three," Nettle marked three spots on the map that had perpetual whirlpools. "Right there." She tapped the center of that triangle. "*The Maledict Sea.*"

"The Maledict Sea?" back at the guild, Elmond looked over the triangle Nettle marked. "That sounds bad."

"Stars above, did you say *the Maledict Sea*?" The bartender jumped over the bar and rushed over. "You can't seriously be thinking your destination is there?"

"I think it is," Nettle said. "We're looking for a Witch's ruin. Can't think of any other than a castle. Witches create castles in harsh places. If that's your reaction, I can't think of anywhere harsher."

"I can see the thought process," the bartender crossed their arms. "That doesn't make it any less dangerous! When I said to hone in a little more than that, I didn't mean hone into the most dangerous spot on the bleeding ocean!"

"What's so dangerous about this sea specifically?" Elisabeth asked. "Why this spot?"

"Let's ignore the whirlpools causing erratic currents that require a master sailor to navigate. Let's ignore the night-endless storms that anyone sane would avoid. Even ignoring those two very dangerous things, the *Maledict Sea* is rich in Wild Magic," the bartender explained. "Not just Wild Magic, but ancient, Wild Magic. The normal rules do not apply. Modern spellcasting is torn to ribbons there. Not to mention, due to the aforementioned ancient magic, numerous beasts make that their home. I don't know how they all fit in there, but they seem to spawn out of magic itself. If the patron themselves asked us to put a quest

to brave that sea, I'd deny them."

"And the bad news?" Elmond said.

The bartender scoffed. "Last I checked, you three don't even have a boat."

"That's probably the hardest part," Elisabeth sighed.

"Can you secure us a boat?" Nettle asked the bartender.

The bartender sighed. "The guild has a small boat that's wasting away in port. I wouldn't take it into deep waters, let alone to certain death."

"A boat's a boat," Elmond said.

"Elisabeth, I grabbed a tome for seafaring from the library. I'll need your help to strengthen the boat with the spells inside," Nettle said.

"Understood," Elisabeth nodded.

"Better check on the boat then," the bartender sighed and went back to the bar. They pulled out a key from beneath the counter. "Boy, come and help me."

"Boy?" Elmond raised his brow, but made no other complaint and followed the bartender.

"You two won't burn the guild down while we're gone, I trust?"

"Not much to burn down," Elisabeth said.

The bartender shrugged and left with Elmond in tow.

Nettle opened the tome and began studying the contents inside.

"What have we got in here?" Elisabeth sat next to Nettle and looked with her.

"There's a fair amount in here," Nettle looked over them all. "Navigation, charm

of smooth waters, fair winds, protection. As many enchantments as we can."

"Will we be able to learn them all with any proficiency?"

"Well enough," Nettle said. "I can learn it and then teach it to you. What concerns me somewhat is the supposed ancient and wild magic. Once we get there, it might dispel all of the enchantments we've put."

"I'm assuming you have a plan for that," Elisabeth said.

"I do," Nettle nodded. "Modern spellcasting acts as a shortcut for stronger spells. Meaning, raw magic control is still viable. My plan is encasing us in that magic as a shield from whatever the wild magic throws at us."

"That's a lot of pressure on you."

"A lot, but unless we can teleport straight there, I can't think of any other option, especially since we're racing Ashen for this."

"If that's the only way," Elisabeth placed a hand on Nettle's shoulder and looked her in the eyes. "I trust you, Nettle. Elmond does too."

Nettle nodded. "I won't let you down."

Elisabeth quirked a smile as the two continued to look over the tome and learn as much as they could. The next day was swift. Nettle and Elisabeth met Elmond at the northern port, where a small boat was moored. It wasn't as small as a fishing vessel, but at the same time, it wasn't large enough to be called a ship.

"If anything, we're lucky it's just this size," Elmond said. "Any larger would

be difficult to control among the three of us. Any smaller and it'll capsize at the slightest breeze."

"Still not the greatest, but if you three are determined, I won't stop you," the bartender said. "I need to head back to the guild. Make sure you three come back alive."

Elmond shook the bartender's hand and watched them go.

"Our turn," Nettle said. Elisabeth and her stepped forward and began enchanting the boat.

The two of them worked swiftly and efficiently, Nettle taking the brunt of the work and Elisabeth supporting her as necessary. By the time they were done, the boat was far sturdier in the wind.

"Only one way to check if we're ready," Elisabeth said.

Elmond nodded and unmoored the boat from the dock. Nettle took a deep breath and blew out, pushing the boat along. Elisabeth and Elmond jumped onto the boat, Nettle close behind.

"All hands!" Elmond took the helm with a wicked grin. "Full ahead!"

They unfurled the sails and caught the natural wind, the enchantments aiding their journey.

"Elmond always wanted to sail on the seas," Elisabeth whispered to Nettle. Nettle smiled with her, the two of them watching Elmond steer the ship forward.

"First mate Nettle!" Elmond called to her. "What's our heading?"

"First mate Nettle?" Elisabeth's smile quirked into a frown. "And not your actual

sister?"

"South by southeast," Nettle said in between laughs.

"South by southeast!" Elmond repeated.

Elisabeth rolled her eyes, leaning on the rail and rocking with the waves. For now, they enjoyed fair weather and endless blue on the horizon.

"So far, the enchantments are holding," Elisabeth observed.

"So far," Nettle checked on the boat as needed.

As they sailed across the Fathomless Ocean, Nettle watched the waves in between checking the enchantments. Dolphins followed them for a spell, schools of fish underneath the waves. Soon, the sun started to set, setting the horizon ablaze.

"Elmond, let's take a break here," Nettle said. "It would be best if we didn't travel at night."

Elmond nodded. "Raise the sails and weigh anchor!"

Nettle took watch this night, making sure they didn't veer off course due to the waves. She took this time to breath deep and feel for the magic around her.

"Say hello to my mother at the Frozen North?" Nettle thought about what Mysteries told her. "This better not be a trick."

At first light, Nettle raised the anchor and unfurled the sails a bit, just enough to get them moving. What Nettle didn't understand about sailing, she made up for with magic.

When the horizon darkened for storms and the waves began to worsen, Nettle woke Elmond and Elisabeth.

"We're close," Nettle said. "Elmond, Elisabeth, watch for the whirlpools. I'll start protecting us with raw magic."

Elmond and Elisabeth took their spots, Elmond at the helm and Elisabeth keeping an eye for the incoming maelstrom.

Nettle sat down at the bow, closing her eyes and collecting magic to cocoon them with.

Rain started to fall. The wind picked up. Waves crashed against the boat, rougher and rougher. While the magic Nettle was gathering had to protect them from other magic, it was up to the enchantments to protect them from the reality.

"Maelstrom off the starboard side!" Elisabeth yelled. "Hard to port!"

"Hard to port!" Elmond repeated to confirm, the boat lurching in a direction. Nettle could hear the boom of thunder in the distance, the footsteps of Elisabeth as she added strength to the enchantments as she could.

Just ahead of them, Nettle felt the difference between the magic she controlled and the ancient magic. The border felt primal, uncontrollable, as if it held contempt for her.

But, there was also something familiar. Something she couldn't place. She will have to worry about the feeling later.

"Brace for crossing!" Nettle warned as she felt them approach. She collected the magic and tensed.

"Here we go!" Elmond yelled.

They crossed, Nettle holding her breath. One second. Two seconds. Any moment now, Nettle was worried the primal magic would overpower her and rip their boat to shreds.

Then, the weather stopped. The waves stilled. The ancient magic surrounded them, then dispersed. All was calm.

When Nettle opened her eyes, the waters were serene. The sun peaked through clouds as the storm broke. The storms were still raging in the distance, but Nettle couldn't place why the magic left them alone.

"I can't tell if this is good or bad," Elmond said.

"Any ideas Nettle?" Elisabeth approached her and helped Nettle up. "Might be the dead calm before a very alive storm."

"I... don't know," Nettle looked around. "The magic exists, it's touched us, but then... then it just left."

"Then it's best to make time while we can," Elisabeth said. "Nettle, point us the right way."

Nettle nodded and oriented them towards the center of the sea. She couldn't shake the feeling of familiarity with this magic. Though their conditions were good, they weren't sailing very fast. Outside of where their boat broke the water, the surface was like glass.

Nettle saw her reflection in it, the girl looking back at her older than what she remembered. She looked tired.

"She looked tired," the old man said. He sat on the edge of the wooden pier with his fishing rod in hand, the little girl sitting next to him with fishing rod of her own. "Just as- oh, you've got one."

The girl pulled on her rod with as much strength as she can muster.

"There we go, miss, don't pull too hard. Reel it in when it's tired," the old man coached her. She stuck her tongue out in concentration, jumping to her feet when she got a moment.

"Hyah!" the girl pulled at the exact moment, the fish jumping out of the water and onto the dock. "I got another one!"

"Great job miss," the old man tossed it into a bucket behind them. They both had a bucket of fish, though the girl's bucket had more fish. The old man's rod also had a bite and he pulled out another fish.

While the girl wasn't looking, he tossed it into her bucket before recasting his line.

"Daddy," the girl tugged on his sleeve.

"Hm?"

"What happened to Nettle while she was on the boat?"

"Oh right," the old man chuckled. "She looked tired. In this eerie calm, Nettle felt herself relax."

Nettle felt herself relax. Despite herself, there was something here that disarmed her.

"This is freaky," Elisabeth said. "Do you think the bartender was just being overly cautious or that we got lucky?"

"I don't think so," Elmond shook his head. "This isn't something guild members would joke about. I can see some hazing for first time members a little bit in the wilderness, but not out here in open ocean."

"I agree," Elisabeth said. "Guess we can only keep going. Nettle, how's it looking?"

Nettle didn't respond, mulling over some thoughts in her head.

"Nettle?"

"Hm?" She broke from her stupor.

"Are you doing ok?" Elisabeth asked. "Ever since we entered the Fathomless Sea, you've been a little off."

"Yeah, I'm ok," Nettle said. "I was just thinking about something."

"Thinking about what?" Elmond kept his head on a swivel, looking around.

"One thing about these Witch Ruins is that they're built in harsh environments, yes?" Nettle collected her thoughts. "But one thing that stuck out to me is that invaders will be repelled."

"Presumably by the magic," Elisabeth followed her reasoning.

"But we're not," Nettle said. "From my research, there are two ways to brave these locations."

"By force or by teleport," Elmond said.

"No, not by teleport," Nettle refuted. "Two ways outside of straight teleportation."

"Then what's the second?"

"By blood," Nettle said.

The Essaim twins were quiet, the implication sitting in.

Elisabeth spoke first. "Are you sure?"

"The Castle in the south, belonging to the Witch of Summer," Nettle remembered. "There is a barrier of flame surrounding it, but now that I think of it, the weather was similarly bad."

"You think it's your sisters?" Elmond asked.

"Either that or my mother," Nettle said. "I don't know if this protection lingers after death."

"Then let's make sure we find out," Elmond nodded to himself, determination in his eyes. "Nettle, does your magic still work?"

Nettle felt within herself, feeling that connection exist. She nodded.

"Our sails are still down, give us a breeze, will you?" Elmond pointed ahead. "First Mate Nettle, onward!"

Elmond's determination spread to Nettle and she pointed as Elmond did, conjuring a tailwind to push them along.

It didn't take long gulls to appear on the horizon. A few landed on their mast, giving everyone confirmation that they were on the right pace. One landed in front of Nettle, right on the bow. Unlike the others, which were bleached white, this gull had feathers of red, yellow,

orange, and golden browns. It looked at Nettle.

"Don't do that," she pleaded with it. "Not now. Not with her so far away."

The gull tilted it's head. Then it hopped closer to Nettle and looked into the horizon with her.

The island climbed over the horizon.

"Land ho!" Elmond called it out.

"Search," Nettle casted her spell and focused towards the island. Her magic touched the ancient magic that avoided them. Then, like being pulled by a rapid current, the ancient magic pulled and amplified her search. The magic reached the island, a full horizon away.

She found a galleon, a contingent of troops. Someone was there first. She reach an intense, unfamiliar magic signature. It noticed her.

Nettle cut the spell, the intensity shaking her to the core. "We were beaten to the punch."

"Ashen?" Elisabeth asked.

"Most likely," Nettle nodded. "Two of them felt strong. We have to hurry. Everyone brace."

"Batten down the hatches!" Elmond yelled to no one in particular.

Nettle pulled for magic. While she did, she called out to the ancient, wild magic.

It approached at her command, the water becoming choppy. The wind picked up. The gulls that were on their ship flew off, save for the multi-colored one with the colors of falling leaves.

"Please," Nettle whispered to herself,

to the magic. "Help us get there."

The seas roared to life, wind howling behind them. The boat lurched forward, almost launched into the air as Nettle commanded the magic forward.

"Woah!" Elmond almost fell from the helm in surprise. "Now we're picking up speed!"

"If they're looking for what we're looking for, they can't know where coming," Elisabeth shouted over the wind. "At best, they'll ask questions. At worst, they'll fight us."

Nettle nodded. Weather manipulation was never her strong suit. It was a couple steps above fundamentals that she couldn't master. But with the wild magic aiding her, it was less about controlling the magic and more asking it. She asked for cover, for a fog, and it answered her.

Fog rolled in with them, covering the sea.

"Though Ashen will know something is up, they won't know what exactly," Nettle said. "I'll try to bring us around the opposite side of the island."

"Very well!" Elmond said, still gripping the helm. "I'm not sure I can steer us anyhow."

"Get serious Elmond," Elisabeth scolded him. "We're charging into unknown territory. Both figuratively and literally."

"Aye, Captain," Elmond straightened out and focused.

Soon, the magic let up. They approached the back of the island, where steep cliffs made for perilous disembarking.

The castle was at the top.

"Thank you," Nettle whispered, the magic leaving her.

"Not the best of spots, but it'll do considering the circumstances," Elisabeth said. She summoned two polearms and lifted herself up with one. "Get on, Elmond. I'll carry you to the top."

"I'll scout for us," Nettle flew up the cliffs. She got to the top, at the back of the castle. Something about it felt familiar.

Regardless, no one was on their side. Nettle looked over the edge and motioned for the twins that it was safe.

At the top, Elmond summoned a short-sword. He looked around.

"We're at the back," Nettle said. "If we circle around to either side, we should be able to find an entrance."

"Can't we fly up?" Elmond asked.

Elisabeth shook her head. "Maybe at dark. But with the sun still up, we'll be silhouetted across the brickwork. If they're watching, they'll see."

"This way," Nettle took point, taking care to stay silent. She restricted her magic use as well. "No magic until we're discovered," Nettle said to the other two. "If someone can notice my search from the entire horizon, I don't want to find out what they'll notice if we casted overt magic this close."

From what Nettle understood, they were behind the main body of the castle. Two wings were on either side, Nettle was leading them down the left wing. She was hoping to find- ah, there it is.

On the left wing, there was a spire with an open window. Nettle pointed to it. Elmond took position underneath it. He helped Nettle up, then Elisabeth. Elmond jumped after them, Nettle and Elisabeth pulling him in.

"Nice," Elmond tossed a thumbs up. "Now what's the plan? Search the entire castle until we find what we're looking for?"

"We run the risk of running into the Ashen search party," Elisabeth said.

"We run that risk anyway," Elmond refuted.

As the two of them discussed, Nettle looked around the room they were in. It smelled of earth and pine. The room itself looked to be a crafting room of sorts. It was in disrepair and weathered by being so close to the sea, but there was something in here that pulled Nettle around.

She wandered into the room, where a shelf still held books and trinkets. Still?

"Nettle, did you find something?" Elmond approached her.

"No, not exactly," Nettle touched the shelves. She wiped away the dust, trying to read the spines on the books. "No good, too weathered. Come on."

"Come on where?" Elmond followed, but Nettle didn't answer.

Nettle still had the presence of mind to lay low and sneak through the halls. She moved with an eerie sense of familiarity.

"Keep close, step where I step. Step wrong and you'll fall through," Nettle said. She didn't wait to check if the two

followed them.

"How do you know that?" Elmond whispered after her.

Their current hallway should lead to spiral staircases higher into the castle. Another set of hallways through different storage rooms. Storage rooms that Nettle should have no busy finding or navigating through, but she knew the paths instinctively.

"Careful," Nettle warned them. "That shelf is unsteady. It's holding up all the rest of them."

At the end of one storage room, Nettle heard voices. She motioned for the two of them to stop.

She pointed at her steps to remind them to only step where she did. For each step she made, the floorboards didn't make a sound. She continued until she hit the next entrance then motioned for everyone to be quiet.

"We've searched this castle top to bottom and we haven't even seen an artifact," a gruff voice said. "How do we even know if something is here?"

"The powers that be have detected an intense aetheric signature from this island," a lighter voice replied. "Matches that of the more robust star stones we've seen."

"There's gotta be something more specific than that," the gruff voice growled. "Even getting here was a ballache. If not for that changeling, we would've capsized multiple times over."

"Aye, Lieutenant Chance is nice like that."

They stopped walking just outside of Nettle's storage room.

"This is squad five, reporting in, over," the lighter voice said.

Nettle couldn't hear the other side of the conversation.

"Roger that, over."

"What did they say?" the gruff voice couldn't hear them either. Must be long distance contact of some sort.

"The Commander has ordered all troops to hold position," the lighter voice said. "A new party has breached the shores and we need to be on the lookout while the Lieutenant does their major work up top."

"Fair enough. I don't know who's stupid enough to sail through that storm. Other than us, I mean."

"Could be whoever orchestrated that fog."

"Could be. You think we could have a sit down? My feet are killing me."

Nettle motioned for Elmond and Elisabeth to go back the other way, careful to not make a sound lest they alert the two just outside of their storage room.

Once they were out of the room and a couple more hallways down, Elmond stopped.

"Think they're referring to us?" he asked.

"A good assumption to make," Elisabeth said.

Nettle paced around the current room. She flexed her hands, looking around the dusty shelves and tomes. This was a type of library. Books of all sorts, mostly

around magical theory and potion making. Idly, without any real thought, she ran a finger across a shelf, caking her finger in dust.

"Nettle!" Elisabeth grabbed her shoulder. "Were you listening to a word we said?"

"Yea," Nettle snapped her head towards them. "No. Errr. What?"

Elisabeth sighed. "It looks like we need to head to the top. In a pinch, we could fly straight there, but we run the risk of being spotted. Not only that, they're aware of something happening."

"Yeah..." Nettle's mind drifted off.

"Hey," Elisabeth lightly slapped her cheek. "What's going on? You haven't been focused ever since we got in here."

Nettle paused to gather her thoughts.

"There's something about this place," Nettle said.

"Something bad?" Elmond asked.

"Something magical? It's weird how it's only affecting you and not us."

"No, something strange. And normal," Nettle began to walk around again. "And strange again." She touched the shelves, a pattern forming in her mind. She stopped at one book. "Something nostalgic." She pulled at it.

In a corner of the room, without any sound, the ceiling gave way and descended to another spiral staircase going up.

"Woah," Elmond went to the staircase and whistled low. He looked at Elmond, wide-eyed.

Nettle breathed out slowly. She

remembered that being there. But she also didn't.

"Do you ever get deja vu?" Nettle asked the two of them. "I don't remember this place. Not really. More like I remember what I did here. I remember sneaking through these halls. I remember little trinkets and secret passages. But I don't know anything surrounding those memories."

"That's scary," Elmond said. Then he kicked the staircase a couple times to make sure it wouldn't go anywhere. "Wanna go up the staircase and find more memories?"

Elisabeth shot him a glare.

Nettle was quiet for a moment, thinking about what he said.

"Yeah sure," Nettle rushed to the staircase with him. Behind her, she could feel Elisabeth roll her eyes, but she followed too.

Nettle took point, a hand on the wall. She felt each brick, counting them underneath her breath. 20... 23... 24... 66... 67... 68... 123... 124... 125... 202. She stopped.

"Another memory?" Elmond asked her.

Nettle pushed the brick in. The rest of the wall followed it, revealing a bedroom.

They were in her colors. Green drapes, yellow shelves. Most of the fabric was moth eaten and worn. They were in tatters from the elements. Nettle felt dizzy. She shook her head, trying to grab her bearings.

"If I didn't know better," Elmond said. "I would've wagered you lived here."

"Looks the part," Nettle managed to say. She found the door. Creaking it open

to see if anyone was outside. No one. Well, almost no one. She spotted a young girl, maybe half her size running through the halls. Nettle stumbled after her.

"Nettle? Nettle!"

Her vision blurred and her body felt heavy. Nettle followed in the girl's footsteps, trying not to lose her around a corner, finding her up some stairs.

As she rounded another corner, she came face to face to an imposing man in black armor.

"What the-?" He jumped back, recognition in his eyes. Elmond and Elisabeth stopped behind her. "Oh, the erstwhile adventurers."

"Commander Nail," Elmond recognized him first. "Fancy running into you here."

"Same to you three, it has been some time since the Fragment affair at the Scar," he greeted them warmly. "What are you doing on this island? I felt a witch try to approach us. I didn't realize there was a third party. A good party."

"Really?" Elisabeth stepped closer to Nettle. "We can help you look for them if you'd like."

"No, it would be best if I escorted you back to the entrance," Nail started to leave, expecting them to follow. He looked at Nettle. "Are you alright miss? You don't look very..." He narrowed his eyes.

Then, the next moment, Nettle was pushed to the floor. A greatsword sliced through the air where she was, Elisabeth pushing her out of the way. Elmond responded with weapons of his own.

"Go!" Elisabeth shouted at Nettle.

"Chance!" Nail shouted for his companion.

Nettle ran, throwing stealth out the window and enhancing herself with magic. She jumped and took to the air.

"Oh no you don't!" Nail shouted behind her.

A shock ran through her, Nettle crashing back onto the floor. She looked back, Nail holding a sapphire gem in his hands.

Behind him, a cloaked figure was holding off Elisabeth and Elmond with magic.

Nettle called for magic. The castle responded to her, shaking on it's very foundations. Just as Nail charged, a wall of stone appeared and cut him off. He slammed into the stone, brickwork shaking.

Nettle didn't stick around and kept going. She retraced her steps, trying to find her way. But to where?

The girl appeared again. Nettle followed her. The memories slipped into her mind of kinder days. More concrete locations.

She was heading to the grand hall, where the most powerful of ritual magics were casted.

Behind her, she could hear brick and rock be overturned. She looked back for a second, Nail in full black armor chasing her like a man possessed. Every time she tried to fly for more speed, he'd pull out his star stone and neutralize her magic.

Nettle made it to the antechamber of the great hall. She ran to the double doors, but before she could make it, the

black greatsword embedded itself onto it.

"Nowhere to run, witch," Nail cornered her. "I don't know what your story is or your plan, but your tyranny must end. You and your sisters both."

Nettle knew he wasn't about to be swayed. She prepared orbs behind her,

A small ethereal dagger appeared on Nail's back shoulder.

"Well, you know. Let's agree on half," Nettle thrust the orbs forward, detonating them while diving to the side.

At the same moment, a man materialized behind Nail in a flash of purple energy, slamming into him and knocking him off balance.

Nettle locked eyes with the person who bought her time. He had burns.

"Go," he said without words.

Nettle didn't wait to ask who he was or what he was doing here. As Nail got up, she slipped past them both. The door opened for her and when she slipped inside, it closed for everyone else.

The door turned into walls at Nettle's command, blocking anyone else who might approach. Fighting resumed outside, but soon it dimmed as they continued their bout elsewhere.

Nettle sighed, then turned to the grand hall. The walls had stained glass at regular intervals, depicting significant moments of the Witch who created the castle.

Being picked up by her mother, learning magic with her eldest sister. The first magic casted.

Meeting her youngest sister, freshly adopted. Teaching her.

Building the castle. Becoming a full fledged Witch.

The back of the hall was smashed open, revealing a great gash to the elements.

In the center of the hall, in blue crystal, was a woman. The woman inside had short brown hair and olive skin. She looked older than Nettle, but her right arm and most of her body was burned.

Nettle rushed to it. The crystal was huge, the size of the guild building. When Nettle put her hands on the crystal, there was still several meters of crystal in between her and the woman inside.

"Thistle," Nettle whispered her sister's name. So many questions ran through her head. But the most important - was she even alive in there?

Nettle closed her eyes and focused on the magic. She discarded that idea quickly. The cool gem she felt in her hands wasn't a gem of any sense. It was pure magic, similar in color to the star stones Ashen was looking for.

The castle shook. Nettle looked around and hoped Elisabeth and Elmond were doing ok.

"If this is magic, let's try something," Nettle breathed deep. She breathed out and placed her palms on the crystal. "To me."

She controlled the magic within her and connected to the magic of the crystal. She pulled it into herself. The amount was too much.

Nettle let go and dropped to her knees,

magic welling into the pit of her stomach. She retched liquid magic on to the ground. Nettle wiped the magic from her mouth. The crystal might've shrunk a little bit, but she couldn't be too sure.

"Alright, if I'm taking too much," Nettle tapped into herself. Her eyes glowed a deep, verdant green. Magic swirled around her. She took a deep breath and placed her hands on the crystal again. Once again, she took the magic within herself. In addition to intaking magic, she expelled all around her. She didn't know what shape that expelled magic took, only that it needed to happen. "Hah!"

The magic rushed through Nettle like a torrent. It filled her entire body to the very brim. She felt like she was being filled with fire, and close to bursting. Her skin cracked from the strain, glowing blue as the magic tried to escape in other ways.

She heard the walls crumble behind her, glass shattering around her. If her focus wavered for a second, she'll break. So despite the sounds of fighting approaching her, Nettle continued channeling the magic.

Nettle pushed, taking a step forward. The crystal obliged her, Nettle pushing into the gem. The more magic she channeled, the more ground she gained, the easier it was to move forward.

Then, like a hose with no more water, the magic stopped. Nettle had no more crystal to push through. In front of her, propped up by the last remnants of crystal, was a sister she had long thought

dead. The last parts of the crystal dissolved into dust in the air, Nettle catching her sister as she fell.

Nettle held her for a moment, held her breath. She was cold. Cold enough for Nettle to wonder if Thistle was actually alive or not.

Then an inhale. Followed by an exhale. The rising and falling of her chest. Thistle was breathing. She was alive.

"Thistle," Nettle whispered.

The woman stirred, her orange eyes fluttering open. Through half-lidded eyelids, she saw Nettle.

"Nettle?" she whispered back. "What are you-" Thistle's eyes focused, gaining lucidity as Nettle could only hold her sister and share magical warmth. The color returned to Thistle's cheeks as Thistle found the strength to hold Nettle's face. "You've grown, little witch," Thistle said with the faintest of smiles.

Nettle could back no more. She hugged Thistle as tight as she could, burying her face in her chest. Elated, shaking sobs escaped Nettle. In this moment, she was no longer a witch who waged a decade long war with fire by her lonesome. No, in this moment, Nettle returned to being a young girl, holding the hand of her older sister while running from flame.

"You did well," Thistle wiped the tears from Nettle's face, though when Nettle looked, there were tears on Thistle's face as well. "Who do we have here? Are these your friends?"

That forced Nettle to recompose herself, the girl wiping the extra tears from her eyes as she looked around. The fighting stopped, Elmond and Elisabeth running towards Nettle.

Nail and the cloaked figure he called Chance were wrapped in thick tree trunks, being watched by the man with burn scars, two researchers that were part of the Scar Escort party, and the magic woman with the poofy hat. The woman winked at Nettle, then turned back to her party.

What really caught Nettle's attention, however, was thick wooden trunks that broke the foundations of the castle. Gnarled roots broke the stonework, branches the size of her body wrapping around the castle windows.

"Elmond, Elisabeth," Nettle got to her feet, helping Thistle up. "Are you ok? What's with the trees?"

"What's with the trees?" she asks, "Elisabeth scoffed. "You're what's with the trees."

"We're ok," Elmond said. He nodded to the party that were keeping an eye on Nail and Chance. "We had some help."

"I did the trees?" Nettle looked around, then at her feet. Sure enough, roots and vines started from her then joined the tangled mess that wrapped around the room. "How did I?"

"It's because you expelled a great deal of magic," Thistle explained. She stretched and tested her body here and there.

"You must be the older sister, Thistle," Elisabeth greeted. "I'm Elisabeth Essaim."

"I'm Elmond Essaim. As you say, we're friends of Nettle. Also," Elmond averted his gaze. "Do you need extra clothes?"

Nettle looked at her sister and for the first time realized she was naked. "Oh!"

Thistle experimented with a little more stretches and chuckled to herself. "No, no. I think I can manage clothes." She waved her hand and a dress with the colors of autumn materialized on her form. "There we go."

Then, Thistle wobbled.

Nettle caught her as Thistle dropped, a rueful smile on Thistle's face.

"I'm ok, I'm ok," Thistle sighed. "Just a little woozy. I guess even simple magic will take some time to return to me."

"It's been a couple years," Nettle smiled with her.

"Do you think this is the boon?" Elisabeth asked.

"It's a pretty big boon," Elmond smiled with the rest of them. "Even if magic isn't on the table, this is massive."

"I suppose," Elisabeth said.

"Don't suppose," Thistle settled next to Nettle. "Magic is on the table. I just need some time. Beside, with her display today, my esteemed sister is one step closer to being a full-fledged Witch herself."

Nettle kept her smile as Thistle made small talk with Elisabeth and Elmond. Despite being the one who helped Thistle stay up, she was feeling a little dizzy herself.

Then she felt hot.

Elisabeth must've felt it first, since by the time Nettle noticed something was up, there was already a barrier in place.

A blast of fire engulfed them all. The flames caused Nettle to sober up. Her dizziness gone, she found the magic to strengthen Elisabeth's barrier.

Nettle faltered, still feeling the after effects of her initial feat. The heat increased, flames turning blue.

"It's ok," Thistle closed her eyes and

leaned against Nettle. "You're doing well." Thistle had no magic to give, but the encouragement was enough. The barrier strengthened and held. When the flames receded, a fragment of the Witch of Summer was flying over the cracked end of the great hall.

Nettle spared a moment to look behind - the other party had their own barrier, though they didn't couldn't fully negate the burns. The man had hatred in his eyes, the fire reflected within them.

Nail and Chance struggled against their wooden bonds, all the wood in the room on fire.

Nettle locked eyes with Nail, fire rapidly approaching them.

She didn't know if she could, nor did she think it was the right decision. But upon seeing the flames approach, Nettle willed the wood to free them. The trees obliged her, splintering at that moment and freeing them both.

"Hello sister," Thistle greeted the fragment. Nettle turned back to the problem at hand.

"It's just a fragment," Nettle grit her teeth. "Ivy's gone."

"A fragment?" Thistle squinted as the flames approached. "That's strange."

"A lot has happened," Nettle said.

"Look alive!" Elisabeth shouted.

The heat increased again as flames welled from within.

"By the powers vested in my family's sword," Elmond's sword appeared in his hand and he teleported ahead. "Cover me!"

The man with burns teleported with Elmond, both of them engaging the fragment in melee.

"It's stronger than the one at the scar," Elisabeth dashed forward and summoned swords to support.

"So she needs time to charge up," Thistle observed. "She needs to focus like a person."

The other party joined the fray, one researcher wearing heavy armor running forward. The other researched stepped beside Nettle and Thistle, shooting magic from an arcane gun.

The woman in the poofy hat had stars orbiting her. She supported her party with magic of her own, healing their wounds from a distance.

"Did you find the boon you were looking for?" She asked Nettle with the softest smile.

Despite her tiredness, Nettle responded with a smile of her own.

The fragment split into two, one tackling Elmond and the other tackling the burned man. The latter threw him off the castle and chased. The other members of his party also chased after.

"When you're finished her, come to the entrance of the castle. We will wait for you there," the woman said, then followed.

The other fragment battled with Elmond and Elisabeth, the two keeping it contained for now.

"Any day now, Nettle!" Elisabeth shouted for backup.

Nettle focused and pulled magic from the air. Even though she was still feeling

the aftermath, as long as her sister was by her side, Nettle felt as if she could do any amount of magic.

Multiple magical orbs circled them, shooting at the fragment with precision and strength. Each blast disrupted the flame.

"You can control so many now," Thistle marveled. "You truly have grown."

"I can do more than control magic," Nettle's began to glow. She shared magic and strength with Elisabeth and Elmond, empowering them both.

"Amazing," Thistle said. "But, it is not enough. There are many ways to snuff a flame."

"What do you suggest?" Nettle asked.

"In this case, smother her," Thistle gestured to the wood around them. The flames have died out, charring the wood.

"Won't it burn?"

"Try," Thistle encouraged.

"Elisabeth, Elmond!" Nettle called out to the both of them. "On my signal, disengage. I'm going to try something!"

"Understood," Elmond yelled back. He was faring well with the sword, but he was slowing.

Nettle closed her eyes. She willed the wood around her, felt it with magic. In the same way she empowered her allies, she empowered the wood. She willed it forward.

"Now!" Nettle opened her eyes and clapped her hands together. Elmond teleported back, Elisabeth also disengaging. Wood shot out of the charred remains and surrounded the fragment.

With nothing holding the fragment back, the fragment was able to charge enough power to constantly emit flames. It incinerated the wood, but Nettle didn't let up.

"Keep going," Thistle encouraged.

Nettle sped up. She controlled more magic, more wood. Now it was a race between her and the fragment.

"Should we be helping?" Elmond hopped on the balls of his feet, trying to gauge an opening.

"You'll get in the way," Thistle told them. "What you've been using to fight fire is swords and magic."

"Is that not how we're supposed to fight them?" Elisabeth said. "It's kind of all we've got."

"Not anymore," Thistle clasped her hands over Nettle as Nettle focused on overpowering the fragment. Nettle didn't know where she was getting this strength from, but she understood what Thistle was getting at. "The real trick is to use mass."

Nettle was winning. She wrapped the fragment in endless amount of wood, smothering the fire faster than the wood was charred. She managed to wrap the fragment in a wood ball, adding wood as it burned from the inside out.

"Now," Thistle squeezed Nettle's hands together. "Just squeeze."

Nettle followed her instructions. The wooden ball condensed, just like the magic balls.

The strain stopped and Nettle knew their fragment was no more. Nettle panted,

her hands shaking. When she looked to her sister, Thistle's eyes gleamed with pride.

"Now we just have to hope the others are able to manage on their own," Elisabeth said.

"They'll manage," Elmond said. "They looked confident and competent. What of Nail and the other one from Ashen?" Elmond looked back to where they were trapped, only finding splintered wood.

"I let them go," Nettle said.

"They tried to kill you," Elisabeth said. "I wouldn't have."

"Burned alive isn't the best way to go," Nettle refuted.

"No, guess not," Elisabeth nodded in understanding. "They could've helped us though."

"Truthfully, I'm just glad they didn't attack us," Nettle admitted.

"That *is* good," Thistle said. "Let's make our way to the entrance of my castle. The mage said they would be waiting for us there should we prevail."

Nettle nodded. She took a step forward and then the world faded to black. She was dimly aware that she was being carried, catching snippets of conversation as she fought to stay awake.

"No wonder, she must be tired."

"This is a long trek."

"Apologies, I have not the strength to move the castle for us. A proper night's rest will do."

"Did you have to make this part so confusing?"

"I usually flew past it."

"Look, there they are."

"Told you they could handle their fragment."

"Is she ok?"

"After a good rest, she will be."

"Then we shall receive it in Emain."

"A good teleport circle. Did Mysteries teach you?"

"Indeed. Shall we?"

"Let's. It will be good to speak to a friend of mother's."

A rush of air. More heat.

"Oh. This is bad."

Nettle didn't know how long she was out for. In truth, if not for the incoming heat, she would've stayed unconscious. But her body recognized this heat and roused her despite her exhaustion.

"Keep moving!"

An explosion.

"Don't stop!"

Another explosion. Nettle heard screams. She opened her eyes, though the edges of her vision was still tinged with darkness. Someone was carrying her on their back. Nettle recognized the platinum hair as Elmond's.

Fire rained from above, the buildings and markets all ablaze.

"Get out of the city! Evacuate!"

Search, Nettle pinged with her magic, trying to locate the new fragment. Her ping reached the sky.

Nettle looked up and in complete fear, she realized that it wasn't a fragment that was attacking Emain.

"Ivy," Nettle said, her voice weak.

"Ivy?" Elmond glanced at Nettle behind him as he continued running. "Nettle, is that the actual Witch?"

"That's the real deal," Thistle ran beside them.

"Thistle... no..." Nettle reached out to Thistle.

"Don't fret," Thistle comforted her. "Even if I wanted to sacrifice myself to stop her, I can't even manage that right now."

"Small comforts, but she still needs to be stopped!" Elisabeth intercepted a

fireball with a sword, the fire detonating above their heads.

"Out of the city first!" Elmond said.

"We need to get these two to safety!"

"The others..." Nettle couldn't see the other party with them.

"They went to help the civilians evacuate," Elmond explained. "They had the numbers to do it."

"Sorry..." Nettle apologized, unable to muster the strength to move.

"You've done more than enough," Thistle said. "We're almost out of the city."

The burning of Emain continued, Nettle weaving in and out of consciousness. Once they were ways away from the city, Emain set Nettle down. They found a cliff side to lean against. Now that Nettle was sitting properly, she stayed awake and watched fire rain in the distance.

"I'm going back in," Elmond said.

"Elmond, no!" Elisabeth grabbed his arm. "You could get killed out there!"

"This needs to stop," Elmond shook his sister off of him. "There's still people in there."

"No," Nettle protested as well.

"By the powers vested in my family's sword, I am not watching a city burn down," Elmond summoned the sword. Without waiting for a response, he teleported towards the city.

"Elmond!" Elisabeth hopped onto a weapon and flew after him.

Thistle took a deep breath and sat next to Nettle while the Essaim twins headed back.

Nettle struggled to move, trying to get up, but her body wouldn't answer her.

"Have faith," Thistle said. "We can do nothing else."

"I can still do something." With great effort, she forced her hand to her chest. She felt for her last limiter. It burned her up inside to even touch it, but she can still break it to unleash one last torrent of magic.

Thistle placed a hand on hers. "You've made a ritual to limit your magic."

Nettle nodded.

"It would explain your explosive growth from when I've last seen you," Thistle softly took the hand away from her chest. "But you've also limited it over your vitals. This will kill you instantly if you break it now."

"But—"

"No buts," Thistle said. "We can fix that. But not now. Let's live until tomorrow."

"Elisabeth and Elmond," Nettle struggled to get up despite Thistle's efforts.

In that moment, a pulse of magic came from the city.

"There they are," Thistle sighed in relief. "I was wondering when they'd make their move."

"When who would make their move?" Nettle asked.

"Mysteries," Thistle said.

"I've talked to them," Nettle remembered their conversation. "They said to say hi to mom. But mom's dead."

"I thought so too," Thistle smiled.
"But you thought I was dead. And we both know mom is a stronger witch than either of us."

"Ivy beat her though," Nettle said.
"Can Mysteries beat mom?"

"Depends on who you ask. If you ask mom, no doubt she'll say no. Mysteries would say they're evenly matched."

"Then—"

"Have faith," Thistle said again.
"Magic is for turning the impossible possible."

"Faith," Nettle repeated. She watched the sky above Emain with bated breath.

The Witch of Summer was a burning ball in the sky, visible even from this distance. Fire rained from the ball and onto the city below, but another pulse of magic rang out. The fireballs paused in mid air, then flew towards the observatory.

In contrast to the Witch's light, darkness spilled out of the observatory. Like a black hole, it ate the fire and extinguished it in endless dark. The darkness took to the air opposite of the fire.

Nettle couldn't tell exactly what was happening. The magic could be felt from this distance. A wobbly pressure that pulled and push like the waves on the tide. It was energizing and tiring, like adrenaline from a turbulent storm.

The skies darkened and warped, shimmering as the darkness and the fire clashed. She couldn't tell if the actual night sky appeared or if it was an

illusion, yet she saw the stars regardless.

The sky cracked, something ripping out that Nettle wasn't sure if she was supposed to see.

"Brace yourself," Thistle grabbed onto Nettle.

Like the very sun, the Witch of Summer exploded in heat. The shockwave reached Thistle and Nettle, the two of them holding onto each other as the very ground shook from the battle.

"Elmond and Elisabeth are in there," Nettle squinted through the shockwaves.

A different light appeared. Nettle couldn't see the actual source, but the light was radiant and focused like a blade. It sliced straight through the fire, cleaving the night sky in twain and revealing the blue of day.

"That must be them," Thistle said. "We never should count an Essaim out."

A chill came over Nettle. She didn't know Elmond or Elisabeth were strong enough to do that. They'd have to severely pass their limits or do something even worse.

"The curse," Nettle whispered.

"You know of the Essaim curse?" Thistle sounded surprise. "What does that have to do with this?" Thistle asked, but she trailed off as she realized. "Oh no."

The radiant light continued to strike at the fire and the darkness both. The fire had enough, fading to cinders and shooting off towards the west. The light continued to battle darkness.

A third pulse of magic emanated from

the city, snuffing the radiant light in an instant.

Everything calmed.

"We have to get back there," Nettle said. But even as she said that, with the immediate danger gone, her eyelids became heavy. The adrenaline left her and sleep took over her once more.

* * *

"Nettle."

"Nettle."

"Nettle."

Nettle woke up groggy. She was on a bed she didn't recognize, a room she didn't know, with no idea how she got there. She blinked the sleepiness from her eyes and sat up.

Her entire body was sore and she felt her joints creak. She studied her arm and moved it around. With some movement, the creaking went away. However her skin was marred with blue cracks where the magic threatened to burst. She touched the cracks - at the very least, it didn't hurt.

"I guess it kind of looks cool," Nettle noted to herself.

The door to her room opened.

"Nettle," Thistle walked in, wearing a more casual dress and a brimmed hat of her own. "It's good to see you awake."

"Thistle!" Nettle swung her legs off the bed to go and hug her. When she placed her weight on them, her legs buckled and Nettle fell. "Woah!"

"Easy," Thistle caught her and helped Nettle back onto the bed. "You've been out for a couple of days. Not only did you use your body as a conduit for severe magic, you also awakened a bigger portion of your Witch's Calling. Your body is strained, stretched to the brink. A couple more days of rest and you'll be a better than normal."

"My Calling?" Nettle tilted her head.

"What do you mean?"

"You'll find out the details when you're fully recovered," Thistle winked. "For now, just know that I'm proud of you. If mother was here, she would be too."

Nettle looked down at her hands, at the blue lines that marred her skin. At the burns that marked her failures. She looked back up at her sister, who held a proud, loving gaze. Nettle cracked a smile.

"Thanks, Thistle," Nettle reached and hugged Thistle. "That means a lot."

"Come now, little witch. I dare not spoil the surprise, but I can give you a little taste of the future," Thistle stood and held her hand out. A gnarled, wooden staff appeared in her hands, twisting and spiraling and taller than them both. She offered it to Nettle.

Nettle looked at her with wide eyes. Nevertheless, in spite of her trepidation, Nettle picked up the staff from her. Using it to support herself, Nettle tried to get up once again. Her legs cooperated little and less, but with the staff to support her, she was able to stand.

"When you're ready, I'll be waiting with your friends just outside," Thistle paused at the door. "There is much to discuss." Then, she left.

Nettle leaned on the staff, experimenting with how to move. Some strength returned to her as she got used to it. After a fashion, Nettle felt up to walking. Sure, she hobbled outside of her room, but it was better than being bound to bed.

When she left her room, Nettle found

herself in the Emain adventurer's guild.

As she walked to the main tavern, Nettle found the bartender clearing away rotten wood that fell from where the ceiling collapsed at the corner of the guild. At the center of the guild, Elisabeth and Thistle were talking at half-broken table. Elmond was laying in one of the booths, an arm covering his eyes.

"Oi," the bartender greeted her. "Glad you managed to pull through."

"Glad to see you're also ok," Nettle said. "I'm surprised the guild is still standing."

"By sheer and stupid luck," the bartender said. "Can't even get rid of this place properly. You owe me a boat, by the way."

"When this madness ends, I'll get you a ship," Nettle said.

"That would be nice," the bartender continued on his work.

"Nettle, you're ok!" Elisabeth rushed to Nettle's side and helped her to the table. "We need to talk."

"I've heard from Thistle much the same," Nettle sat and kept holding onto the staff. "What's the situation? Exactly how long have I been out?"

"It's been five days since the Witch of Summer arrived in Emain," Elisabeth explained. "We lost a lot of people, but thanks to the other adventurers most were evacuated in time. Half the city is either burned down or still burning, the other half turned into refugee lodgings."

"Thanks to the quick actions of the

Patron and the Essaim here," Thistle gestured to Elmond, "They were able to Weaken Ivy and drive her back. Weaken but not defeated. She is still out there."

"What of the light?" Nettle asked. "I saw it turn against the darkness."

Elisabeth was quiet. She looked at her brother. That told Nettle all she needed.

"How bad?" Nettle asked.

"It's not great," Elisabeth admitted. "Elmond turned the sword against the Patron. I couldn't calm him down and he almost turned his sword against me. Then the darkness swallowed them both. Then Elmond dropped out of the sky. He's been lucid, but distant ever since."

"And the patron?"

Thistle shook her head. "Mysteries had lost a lot of strength since the time mother knew them. The Essaims also tend to be the bane of their type. I would not be surprised if they never recover."

Elisabeth balled her fist. "And how do you know this?" She snapped. "What do you know of my family? Of the world outside of your crystal?"

"Elisabeth," Nettle held a hand up. "You're doing it again."

Elisabeth closed her eyes and took a deep breath. She relaxed her hand.

"Sorry," Elisabeth apologized. "We still need to know."

"It's quite alright," Thistle said. "Our mother has a past with some members of the Essaim family. Nothing specific, but our home library has- sorry, had some history that I read through."

"That's a little vague," Nettle said.

"If you paid attention during mom's history lesson, you would have been able to share this instead of me," Thistle lightly scolded.

Elisabeth cracked a smile at that.

"Now, if I remember rightly," Thistle thought for a moment. "The Emain family had a history of battling divinity or divine-like beings. The Dragon War which occurred over a thousand years back was one such part."

"Elohim," Thistle whispered a name.

"That was the name of him, yes," Thistle nodded. "Now, the curse is something that our mother had a lot of writings on."

"She did?" Elisabeth leaned close.

"What can you tell me? Is there a way to break it?"

"I assume you know what it is?" Thistle said.

"A possession of the strongest member of each generation by some magical force beyond our time," Elisabeth said.

"Close, it is a possession of whoever knows a certain technique," Thistle corrected. "It's a coincidence that you need to know everything else to have a shot of intuiting the technique itself."

"But the voices," Elisabeth said. "In our records, there's a voice that urges the strongest on. Elmond admitted to hearing it too."

"There's no mention of voices in our mother's records," Thistle said. "I will not refute you. Both things can be true."

"Maybe it's trying to speed up the teaching process," Nettle suggested.

"That could be true," Thistle said.

"Does your mother know exactly what technique it is?" Elisabeth asked.

"As it would turn out, she does," Thistle nodded. "What's more, she knew of a way to break it for an individual."

"Just an individual, not the entire bloodline?"

"Well that's the thing. It would require severing the individual from the bloodline."

Elisabeth was quiet.

"What would be the effects of that?" Nettle asked the question for her.

"Physically, nothing that can't be healed," Thistle thought for a moment. "Maybe it'll give a cool scar. Magically, it'll be different. You'll lose access to all of the abilities granted by your bloodline."

"All of our magical abilities?" Elisabeth asked.

"No, just the ones granted by your blood," Thistle clarified. "Magical fundamentals are still on the table if you know those."

"That's it," Elisabeth leaned in close. "That's really it?"

"It would have to depend on the person," Thistle said. "For you, it would be a 'that's it.' For him, however," Thistle looked at Elmond, who hadn't moved.

Nettle followed her gaze. If not for the rise and fall of his chest, Nettle

would've thought he was dead. Nettle understood Thistle's implication. He wanted to restore the name of his family. He couldn't do that without their abilities.

Elisabeth drummed her fingers on the table, lost in thought.

"What's the technique?" Nettle asked. "Was it that light I saw? The one that cleaved into the sky itself?"

"No actually," Thistle said. "It's something a lot more abstract. It's memory tapping."

"Memory tapping?" Elisabeth focused again. "The hell is that?"

"It's the ability to tap into the memory of our swords," Elmond groaned as he sat up.

"Elmond!" Elisabeth rushed to her brother and helped him up. "Are you ok? What of the voice?"

Elmond tapped his head. "Insistent."

"It's talking to you right now!?"

"Yeah," Elmond nodded. "But it's me right now." He looked at Thistle. "What needs to be done?"

"We need to hold a ritual to sever you from your bloodline. A lot of the materials are mundane, but there are some that are very rare," Thistle explained. "The rarest is dragon blood."

"Why dragon blood?" Elmond asked.

"Because your family are dragon slayers," Thistle said.

"Are we?" Elmond raised his brow. Then he looked up, as if hearing a voice. "So we are."

"What does your fellow say about the ritual?" Nettle asked.

Elmond gave a wry smile. "Nothing that I should repeat."

"So now we need to figure out what where we can find dragon blood," Nettle said. "We don't have a very large list, short of knowing where a dragon is."

"I know where dragon blood is," Thistle said. "Ivy's castle should have it. Assuming it hasn't burned down. She talked much about having a large supply of it."

"It still stands," Nettle remembered the last time she was there. "It's surrounded by intense fire and I can't say if the inside is the same as the outside, but it still stands."

"Truly?" Thistle widened her eyes. "That's fortuitous. Both of our objectives are in the same place."

Elisabeth nodded. "Sit tight, Elmond. We'll get that dragon blood and free you from this."

"Sit tight?" Elmond shook his head. "No, I don't think I will sit tight."

"Elmond, you're in no condition to move anywhere. If you're possessed—"

"If I'm possessed, it would be best if I'm surrounded by allies who can stop me," Elmond said. "If it happens while I'm still here, I don't think I can be stopped. I can't imagine any place where I go where there will be enough to stop me if I get taken over."

"Ashen, probably," Nettle suggested.

"Ashen is in play?" Thistle made a warding sigil. "Stars forfend, they can handle you for certain."

"I'm not sending my brother to Ashen to possible die," Elisabeth said, her voice firm.

"Then I travel," Elmond said.

"Do you remember if Mysteries did anything to you?" Nettle asked.

"Not exactly," Elmond shook his head. "The best way to describe it would be putting my head in a box. Almost a labyrinth. I needed to gather the pieces of myself and avoid whoever else is in here."

"Elisabeth, can you handle travel preparations? The castle is roughly a week from Ashen," Nettle asked her.

"Two weeks from here then," Elisabeth nodded. "Yes, I can handle it."

"We should pay a visit to Mysteries if we can," Nettle turned to Thistle. "It would help us if we knew the spell, just in case."

"A wise decision," Thistle agreed. "But be aware, if we go to the castle and Ivy is there, it will be a tough battle."

"If it comes to it I can help," Elmond said.

"Absolutely not," Elisabeth repeated. "I'm not trading their family member for mine."

"It won't come to that," Nettle said. "Between my sister and I, I'll make sure it won't."

"How can you be so sure?" Elisabeth asked. "Not only were we barely hanging on for the fragments, we don't have anything big to actually beat the big one."

"Ye of little faith," Thistle laughed

to herself. "Before, you had a fledgling witch who knew nothing of secrets and legacy."

"Elisabeth," Nettle shot her a thumbs up. "We've got this."

"Yeah," Elmond also did a thumbs up. "They've got this."

Elisabeth rolled her eyes. "Very well, if you got this."

Nettle and Thistle left the guild to talk to Mysteries, the Patron of Emain. Nettle hobbled on her new staff, thought she was regaining strength as the day went on.

She took that time to look at the damage caused to the city. The market was no more, stalls reduced to ashes. All around them, buildings have collapsed in on themselves, their foundations reduced to cinders. Nettle watched anyone who was walking try to rush to where they were needed. People who weren't walking were either bandaged or not. Everyone was burned.

"You don't seem surprised," Thistle said.

"Surprised about what?" Nettle asked.

Thistle gestured to the ruins of the city.

"I'm a little surprised," Nettle confessed. "More surprised that it happened here. The where. But the results are familiar to me."

"Familiar how?"

Nettle pointed at the cinders, at the people. "The results are always the same."

"You must've been at a lot of places where this happened," Thistle said. "How long?"

"How long what?"

"How long have you been doing this on your own?"

"Oh you know," Nettle paused and leaned on the staff. She sighed. "Since you..."

"Since I died," Thistle finished. "Time has been strange for me, in that crystal."

I can't tell if it's been ten years or fifty."

Nettle couldn't help but wear a rueful smile. "It's only been ten."

"Ten years," it was Thistle's turn to sigh. "I'm sorry, you know."

Nettle started walking again.

"I thought I could win," Thistle walked with her.

"You could've told me," Nettle said, after a while. "Told me what you were up to, told me what you had a backup plan. Anything at all."

"I know," Thistle held Nettle's hand while they walked. "This time, you will know everything. You deserve that much and more. This time, I will walk with you when we confront our sister. We will say hello to Mom again together."

After a moment of quiet walking, Nettle broke the silence. "Alive, right?"

"Pardon?"

"We'll say hello to Mom again together since we're all alive," Nettle said. She looked at Thistle, the two of them right outside of the observatory.

"Of course, alive. All of us. I promise. As your sister, I promise."

"You better," Nettled said. She went into the observatory.

The woman with the poofy hat greeted them.

"Oh wonderful," she smiled. "You're ok."

"Is your party ok too?" Nettle asked.

"Yes, yes," She nodded. "Everything is fine. Mostly everything. Our patron wishes

to speak with you both."

"Then we shall meet them," Thistle took the lead.

"This way," the woman lead them through the library.

"Not going to teleport us like last time?" Nettle asked.

"No strength," the woman said, still chipper. They moved through the deepest part of the library. Nettle tried to keep up and make a mental map, but after a few too many right turns in a row, Nettle gave up. Eventually, the bookshelves went away.

The three of them traveled in darkness, the only source of light being the faint starlight off of the woman's dress.

"Here we are," she said. "I'll take my leave now."

"What if we get loss on the way out?" Nettle asked.

"You'll find your way," she said with her unchanging smile and then left.

When she left and they were wrapped in darkness, Nettle waited for a couple minutes.

"Thistle? Are you still there?" Nettle asked.

"I'm here, little witch," Thistle said. Nettle felt Thistle grab her hand and she squeezed it in reassurance. "I would imagine Mysteries would require some time to recollect themselves."

"How astute of you." Lights blinked into existence all around them. Stars dotted into existence, the night sky forming as Nettle recognized the form ahead. With the added starlight, Nettle

could see Thistle beside her. **"Welcome, Witch of Fall. I hope you are well."**

"Well and alive," Thistle did a small bow. "Do I have you to thank for sending my sister to me?"

"Indeed," Mysteries made a sound Nettle couldn't recognize. **"And you, Witch of Spring. Did you enjoy the boon?"**

"Thank you," Nettle also bowed. "I would not have been able to reunite with my sister without your guidance. Also-Witch of Spring? Are you referring to me?"

"Did she not tell you?" The presence ahead of them approached Thistle. **"Did you not tell her?"**

"It was meant to be a surprise and bestowed with the right ritual," Thistle sighed and shrugged.

"And yet you have provided the mentor's staff ahead of the ritual," the sound again. It occurred to Nettle the sound was Mysteries laughing.

"You just said you'd tell me everything," Nettle teased Thistle.

"Well, surprises can be nice," Thistle teased back. "But, this is not why we are here."

"No, it is decidedly not. My time is short. You are here for the spell."

"The spell you used to subdue Elmond," Nettle said.

"It was a series of spells, but yes. However, before I share with you the spell, I must tell you of the mysteries to come."

Nettle's thumb drew circles on her staff.

"You are hesitant," Mysteries approached Nettle. **"After sharing with you knowledge of a great boon, have I not earned your trust?"**

"I thank you again for that knowledge," Nettle said. "But something doesn't make sense to me. You said we needed Thistle to face Ivy or Elmond would be forced to go tap into his curse." Nettle tapped the butt of her staff on the ground. "Yet Ivy came anyway. He tapped into his curse anyway. And you do not seem surprised."

"An astute observation, Witch of Spring," Mysteries said. **"You have the same iron in you as your mother."**

"That as well," Nettle frowned. "You know much, that is plain. My question, is why share that with me."

"A good question," Mysteries said. **"Let me return with a question of my own. Do you know what I am?"**

"Powerful magic user," Nettle said. "Strong as my mother. Knows secrets."

"Nettle doesn't really know how strong our mother is," Thistle said.

"Thistle?" Nettle turned to her. "What do you mean?"

"Watch the Witch of Fall is implying is that the Witch of Winter has strength comparable to the divine," Mysteries said.

"The divine? Then that makes you—"

"Divinity. A god," The form of Mysteries stepped away. Nettle could swear the stars took the shape of a smile. **"And as divinity, there are rules we must follow. Rules that prevent our enemies from doing the same."**

"And now what? You want us to fight your enemies for you?" Nettle gripped the staff tighter.

"No. I want you to fight my enemies for you," Mysteries said.

"But—"

"Let me explain. One of the rules is one reaction for every action. The enemy has made an action. It is only now that I have an opportunity to react."

"What does that have to do with—" Nettle thought for a moment. Then she realized. "Ivy is their action."

"That is correct. I do not know why. But our battle confirmed it. They are marked by the enemy," Mysteries said. **"Sharing this knowledge will be my reaction."**

"That's it?" Nettle asked. "That's all your great knowledge is for?"

"You sound disappointed."

"That's because I am disappointed," Nettle frowned. "Can't we even know what this enemy is?"

"If would be overstepping my bounds if I did. They would be granted an equal and opposite reaction."

"That is plenty," Thistle interjected. "Thank you for that knowledge."

"It is?" Nettle looked at her.

Later, Thistle waved her off.

"Now, the spell for the Essaim! Surely that is not part of your enemies and rules," Thistle said.

A smile unseen. **"There is an enemy, but not one bound to the same rules. I will teach you this spell."**

The spell itself was made of several components and required knowledge of their target. As a divinity, Mysteries was well aware of the presence in Elmond's mind. As Nettle and Thistle were not, they needed additional spells to mark their target. Elmond and the curse inside his head would have to be separately targeted.

The next step is carving a labyrinth for each of them. As they are connected, it is impossible to completely separate them without harming Elmond's brain function. The next best thing is keeping them separate for long enough for Elmond to regain control. To the target, it would seem like they were traversing a labyrinth of their own mind, populated by memories and dreams of times gone past. The strength of the labyrinth would depend on the strength of the spell. Though Nettle and Thistle are not on the level of their mother or Mysteries, the fact that there are two of them casting it would strengthen the spell regardless.

Outside of the mind, the body would be on autopilot. They would stay that way until Elmond resolves the spell.

"For a possession such as this, it's meant to buy time for the possessed to regain control. However, there is a chance for the possessor to regain control before the possessed does. If your Essaim had the strength to it once, I do not doubt that they have the strength to do it again. But be wary."

"Understood, thank you for teaching us," Nettle bowed to the divine.

"Thank you, Mysteries," Thistle

repeated, then added, "Should you recover, I will ask mother to make amends."

"That would be lovely," Mysteries said. Then, one by one, the starlight dimmed and went out. Nettle and Thistle were left in darkness once again.

"Shall we go?" Thistle asked.

"Yeah," Nettle looked around in darkness. If not for Thistle holding her hand, Nettle wouldn't know if she was there. "But where?"

"We'll find our way," Thistle started walking, pulling Nettle along. It was just their footsteps in the darkness for awhile. In the distance, Nettle saw a light. They walked towards it. They made out shapes in the darkness, of bookshelves. Soon, they were in the library proper.

Nettle didn't know where to go, but the library let them out regardless. Soon, they arrived back at the entrance. The woman with the poofy hat was nowhere to be seen.

"So," Nettle looked at her sister and raised a brow. "How does that knowledge help us?"

"Let's head back to the guild, I'll tell you on the way," Thistle said.

While they retraced their steps, Thistle explained to Nettle of their mother.

"Once you're strong enough to play the games that a divinity can play, you know their secrets," Thistle explained. "You were too young to know at the time, but mother was a big player. She knew their enemies."

"Did she ever tell you about them?" Nettle asked.

"Not directly," Thistle admitted. "We did ask, but we were repeatedly told we weren't ready."

Nettle's eyes widened. "Ivy wouldn't have wanted to hear that."

"My thoughts exactly," Thistle nodded. "Ivy would've tried to find out on her own."

"Do you think the enemy corrupted her?" Nettle's mind ran through all the possibilities. If it was a corruption, would there be a way to purify?

"That would be an easy out, wouldn't it," Thistle held a wry smile. "It is clear to us that Ivy has been touched by the enemy in some way. Whether it is corruption or empowerment, who is to say? The only way to find out for sure is by confronting her."

"That's true," Nettle frowned. They made it back to the guild. Elmond was chatting with the bartender, Elisabeth still out gathering supplies. "We're back."

"Welcome back," Elmond greeted. "Do you have the silver bullet for me?"

Nettle nodded.

"Good, good," Elmond smiled, but then his face turned downcast. "Hey, since Elisabeth isn't here, I'll need you two to do me a favor."

"What is it?" Nettle furrowed her brow. "If you don't want Elisabeth here, then that means she'll not approve."

"Not approve is the least of our worries," Elmond laughed to himself. "No,

she wouldn't. If worse comes to worst then I need you to stop me."

"Oh that's it?" Thistle sat down at the table. "From the way you were talking young Essaim, I thought you were going to ask us to kill you."

"No, if you kill me it'll just go to her," Elmond said. "I need you to do more than that."

Nettle paused, unsure of what to say.

"You're right," Thistle said. "You wouldn't approve."

"What do you mean, more than that?" Nettle asked.

"I need to be stopped in a way that the curse is stuck with me," Elisabeth said. "In stasis, banished, or whatever. But it needs to stop with me."

"Doable," Thistle said. "There are ways for this to happen."

"You're talking about Elisabeth being against this," Nettle shook her head. "I'm also against this. I'm not about to kill my friend."

"Come on Nettle, be smart about this," Elmond said. "If the worst case scenario occurs, I'll already be gone. You can think of it less as killing me and more like avenging me."

"You make it sound like that's supposed to be easier," Nettle frowned.

"I know what I'm asking. I also know that if it came down to it, Elisabeth would hesitate. That's why I'm asking you both," Elisabeth took Nettle's hands and looked her in the eyes. "Please."

Nettle pulled away and paced the room.

After a moment, she stopped and looked at Thistle.

"Is there a way where he won't suffer?" Nettle asked.

"There are ways for eternal torment if we are too late and ways that are painless if we are too early," Thistle said. "We would have to learn them both, of course, but there are ways."

"Very well," Nettle said. "I will do as you ask."

"Thank you," Elmond smiled genuinely for the first time. "If the world is good, it won't come to this."

"If the world was good, we wouldn't have to do anything," Nettle sighed. "Once Elisabeth comes back, we'll come up with a proper plan. It won't include what we've just discussed."

Elmond nodded.

"Come here, young witch," Thistle waved Nettle over. "It's time to talk to you about your title."

"My title," Nettle sat next to Thistle. "The Witch of Spring?"

"Yes. I was hoping to have a ceremony for you like Ivy and me, but time is short. We will have to skip the formalities and you will have to learn the advanced secrets quickly."

Nettle nodded. While waiting for Elisabeth, Thistle taught Nettle of magic. More than fundamentals, Thistle taught Nettle arcana that Nettle would not have been able to understand three weeks ago.

When Elisabeth did arrive, it was night. Her expression dour, the weight of the past days clear on her face. As Elmond

walked with her to try to lighten her spirits, Nettle couldn't help but notice the bags underneath her eyes.

"We have to make sure the worst doesn't happen," Nettle said to Thistle. Her voice was firm, firmer than she meant to make it.

Thistle held a soft smile. Was it pity? Was it rue? Nettle didn't know for sure, only that it felt like Thistle knew something Nettle didn't.

"We will try, young witch. Else what is the point of magic?"

"Daddy," the girl set her bucket full of fish down on the road for a second. "What is the point of magic?"

"Do you mean in the story or just in general?" The old man paused and waited for the girl. The sun was touching the horizon in the distance, painting the sky in the colors of fire.

The girl thought about her question.

"You know, why magic?"

"What a question," the old man scratched his chin. He looked at the fiery horizon, trying to figure out how he should answer. "Do you dislike magic?"

"No!" the girl said instantly.

"What do you like about it?"

"I like how it makes things easier!"

"Is that it?"

"I like how it can make pretty things too!" the girl smiled and clapped her hands together. With what little magic the girl knew, she shot sparks into the sky.

"I think the point of magic is to make young girls like you smile," the old man picked up both buckets and started walking back home.

"Not boys?" she asked and followed him.

"Magic can make boys smile too," the old man chuckled. "Magic can be used for a lot of things. Cool things. Dangerous things. Forbidden things. But I believe that the point of it is to bring smiles to the world."

"Can I use magic to make people smile?" the girl asked. "Can you teach me how?"

The old man smiled. "You already know how."

The girl beamed. The two walked in silence back to their home. Then, when they got there the girl asked, "Daddy, what happened next? Did they use magic to fix things?"

"It takes a couple of tries," the old man confessed. "First they had to get there. The journey to the Witch of Summer's castle began."

When Nettle and the rest left Emain, it was with heavy hearts and an even heavier task ahead of them. No matter what they did to right the wrongs ahead of them, the burns that stayed on the citizens of Emain was a reminder of what the Witch of Summer means.

It was reminder to Nettle that the Witch of Summer was more than eldest sister, Ivy. It was a reminder that for many years, fire and flame caught her world and the world of many others.

"Elisabeth, Elmond, a word before we go," Nettle pulled the two of them aside into a separate huddle. Elisabeth continued to have bags underneath her eyes, not looking like she had much sleep. On the other hand, Elmond looked well-rested but there was distance in his gaze that told Nettle he was thinking much. Nettle pulled them close and looked both of them in the eyes. "One way or another, this ends soon."

"One way or another," Elmond nodded.

Elisabeth didn't say anything, but she looked at Nettle. There was a pleading in her expression.

"When it's all said and done, I'll make sure you get your reward at the guild too," Nettle joked. That managed to get Elisabeth to crack a smile.

"You better," Elisabeth said. Then they set off.

Much like the journey to Emain, Nettle continued honing her fundamentals, as did Elisabeth and Elmond. That kind of magic was easy for her now, to the point that setting up multiple orbs were no longer a

challenge. She could create and control as many as she wanted, with no regard for limit.

At the very least, if there was a limit, Nettle hadn't found it yet.

In addition to working on the fundamentals, the inclusion of Thistle had Nettle learning the more difficult aspects of magic. Not just raw magic control, but of spells and the languages that govern them.

"It's all about translation," Thistle explained. "You tell the world what you want and the world obliges you. Most of the time, the world doesn't agree. That's where spells come in. You convince the world that your way of viewing things is correct. The more complex thing you want to happen, the more complex the spell."

Nettle didn't understand the full philosophy behind casting spells. Though she didn't understand, she trusted in her sister. That trust worked to her benefit - after casting a couple of spells, it became easier as she understood the process.

"Does all this come with being the Witch of Spring?" Nettle asked after the first night.

"No," Thistle shook her head. "All of this is just the next step after knowing the fundamentals. As for what being a Witch entails, I suppose now is a good time as any to explain."

"Let's use Ivy as an example," Thistle summoned a flame. "We've always known what she's like."

"Hot-headed and assertive," Nettle

recalled.

"That's right. Fiery. The Summer suits her, don't you think?"

Nettle nodded.

"Once we become strong enough, we develop a magic that we can do without thinking. One that is natural to us. Our title is influenced by what is natural. Once defined, our title is then used to help us guide our magic," Thistle explained. "Mine is Fall. Mother is Winter."

"And I'm Spring," Nettle said. "Do we only use seasons?"

"I'm sure there are other Witches who don't," Thistle said. "Mother made a habit of using seasons, so we're only following in her footsteps."

"Ok," Nettle did a little bit of magic that felt right. In the ground at their feet, a sprout pushed through the dirt. "So being Spring means I can grow plants?"

"An application of it," Thistle nodded. "Even before you found me, did you have a moment of where magic came naturally to you? When your choices were do magic or die, what kind of magic did you do?"

"We were in the Scar, fighting on of Ivy's fragments," Nettle recalled. "The flames were so hot, they melted mom's ice."

"Not an easy feat," Thistle said. "What did you do?"

"It was just Elmond and me at first," Nettle said. "Elisabeth evacuated the group we were escorting. When I called for magic, I felt strength. Strength I could share. Healing was easier too. It became a

battle of attrition."

"Empowerment and rejuvenation," Thistle summed up. "Like the spring after winter, your abilities are meant to help yourself and others grow."

"Growth," Nettle looked at her hands and the small plant at her feet.

"It suits you," Thistle smiled. "Now we just have to unlock more of it."

Nettle nodded. With Thistle's guidance, the two grew and developed Nettle's abilities.

Every so often, Nettle would look over at Elmond and Elisabeth's progress. Elmond changed his focus from his abilities to swordsmanship. He practiced his swings and his form, setting up his own dummies to practice against.

"Shall I give you a sparring partner?" Thistle asked him early in the training.

"Can you magic something up?" Elmond asked.

Nettle watched as Thistle summoned a staff of her own. She tapped it on the ground; taking shape from the earth, a humanoid figure formed. It was thick and unwieldy, but it moved with an alright speed.

"Woah," Elmond let out a low whistle. "That's handy."

"As you practice, I can make the golem as fast and as strong as you want. Skill is somewhat out of the question, but I can always make more," Thistle said.

"Thanks Thistle," Elmond got his sword ready. "Let's do it." Then he was off, putting his skills to the test.

Elisabeth's progress was harder to pin down. Much like Nettle's magic orbs, it seemed like controlling any number of weapons came easy to her. Nettle had no doubts that if Elisabeth wanted, she could fill the sky with swords and demolish a non-magical army.

"Think of any cool moves?" Nettle asked her once.

Elisabeth sighed and shook her head.

"None that aren't dangerous," Elisabeth replied. "It wouldn't make any sense to learn more about my family abilities if they'll end up with me taken over."

"You could learn magic like me," Nettle said. "You always said you were the better spellcaster between Elmond and you."

Elisabeth thought to herself for a moment.

"For everything that comes with your natural ability, a spell can copy," Thistle said. "And if it so pleases you, as long as you don't learn memory tapping, it should be ok to learn the other abilities of your blood."

"You never explained that in full," Nettle said. "What is memory tapping?" Elmond said it taps into the memory of swords, but what does that mean exactly?"

"Elmond!" Thistle called the Essaim over. "Can you explain memory tapping to Nettle and your sister here?"

"Kind of?" Elmond said as he jogged to them. "Some of the more powerful weapons have a memory associated with them. That memory has special abilities."

"How does a sword remember things?" Elisabeth asked. "How do they have memory?"

Use it long enough and it gets a life of their own?"

"Less the sword and more of the user," Elmond clarified. "You know Eleden?"

"An ancient ancestor," Elisabeth said.

"His memory is in Eden," Elmond said. "That was the radiant blade I used."

"Not every sword will have a memory," Thistle said. "Only the important ones. If it has a name, there is a good chance there is a memory. And that memory is what allows the possession. It opens the door in your mind for the memory to flow. But more than memory can flow in."

"Makes sense," Elmond nodded. "At the start, before I was possessed by the curse, someone else guided me. It might've been Eleden himself, a part of them still in the sword."

"Elmond, is the ability in the memory or the sword?" Nettle asked.

"What do you mean?"

"Well, you said the memory guided you, yes?" Nettle continued. "If you didn't know how, it would make sense that you needed guidance. But if you did know how, you wouldn't need a guide."

"You're saying that he can use the radiant blade without the memory tapping now," Elisabeth said.

"Only if he knew how still," Nettle said. "Do you?"

Elmond held a shy smile and scratched his head. "Would you be angry with me if I said I didn't?"

Elisabeth sighed and held her face in her hands. "Why am I not surprised?"

"It's too risky for Elmond to experiment with it," Nettle said. "But you might be able to, Elisabeth."

"It's worth a try," Thistle supported. "Mother had a good list of notable Essaim figures. We can try to recall their abilities without using a memory."

"And if worse comes to worst?" Elisabeth asked.

"Then whatever the plan is with me, we'll apply to you," Elmond said. "We can't both be possessed at the same time. I think."

"It *is* only one entity," Thistle said.

"Then I'll give it a try," Elisabeth said. "Talk to me Elmond, I need to recognize the signs if I start hearing voices in my head."

"On it," Elmond and Elisabeth went off to the side to talk.

"That was a good shout," Thistle said to Nettle.

Nettle couldn't help but smile. "I was hoping to give her a little bit of hope. She looked down ever since the attack at Emain."

"Sometimes, a little bit is enough," Thistle said. "How much further?"

"Tomorrow we'll hit the Deserts of Yawn," Nettle said.

"That used to be a Savanna, no?" Thistle said. "Mother had lessons on that."

"Well, it's desert by the time I crossed it," Nettle said. "After a couple of days, we'll make reach the Spineshattered Ranges. On my own, I can

traverse it to the castle in a day or two. In a group, it'll take twice as long."

Thistle nodded. "You've visited the castle before, yes?"

"I have," Nettle said. "I thought I could end it at the source, but it's surrounded by fire. I wasn't strong enough then."

Thistle laughed a small, rueful laugh. "You know, Ivy never told me where her castle was. I didn't tell her where mine was either, but it was always a small bit of sibling rivalry we had. I hope the secrets we find in there aren't too bad."

Nettle could only hope with her.

The Deserts of Yawn was marked by shifting sands, endless dunes, and an unforgiving.

"Careful," Nettle warned. "Keep an eye out for white sand. If that gets on you, you'll fall asleep instantly."

"Noted," Elmond said.

"We will be fine," Thistle said. While they walked, Thistle swirled her staff in the sand like a rudder on the boat. The sands shifted around them, moved by an unseen force. The journey would be perilous normally. Thanks to the magic that Thistle and Nettle possessed, nothing of note occurred.

They left the desert and came across the Spineshattered Ranges. A perilous place of tall mountains and valleys.

"Legend tells the peaks used to be much higher," Thistle said. "Up until the greatest of dragons fell, breaking their spine and the peaks with it."

"Did you mother have a hand in that as

well?" Elisabeth asked.

"Not sure," Thistle shrugged. "She might have, but it didn't really come up in conversation."

"I know most of us can fly, but watch your step regardless," Nettle warned. "Spineshattered refers to more than the legend."

At one of the peaks, they took a break.

"This is nice actually," Elmond said. "From up here, it's like you can see the whole world."

"So long as we don't fall," Elisabeth said. She had multiple swords out, hovering by both of them.

"Look," Elmond pointed north. "If you squint, you might be able to see the tip of Ashen."

Nettle followed where he pointed. At the very edge of the horizon, Nettle could just make out the tip of a mountain. Considering that was the only mountain in that direction, it wouldn't surprise her if Nettle was right.

"Something doesn't feel right," Thistle said. "Do you feel it too, Nettle?"

"No," Nettle looked around. "Is it here?"

"It's faint," Thistle said. "Far away. In that direction." Thistle pointed in the direction of Ashen with her staff.

In the distance, Nettle saw the faintest light appear next to the mountain. Then it was gone.

At the same time, at a different place, a man with burn scars was preparing for the day in an inn's washroom. He washed his face, taking great care to not disturb his scars.

The man earned some new ones while at sea. He earned some more while fighting in Emain. Now back at Ashen, pondering the next move. He walked to his room, pouring some water for himself.

Ding.

The bells in Ashen rang out, as they always did in the morning. Stay in Ashen long enough and anyone could learn what they meant. Ring, pause. Ring, pause. They would happen at sun up or sun down.

Ding.

Three bells would tell him that the mages in uptown would try an experiment and to not panic if something shot in the sky. Two bells would mean ground activity and the ground might shake.

Ding.

He couldn't remember what one bell meant. In either case, he went to meet with the rest of his party.

Ding.

As he passed by a window, the man pondered for a moment. He hadn't realized it was midday.

Ding.

Why were bells ringing at midday?

Ding.

He looked outside, at the streets below. A crowd was beginning to form, people wondering what the deal was.

Ding.

Light shone on his face. The man looked up, covering his eyes from the sun.

Ding.

Except, it wasn't the sun that.

Ding.

The man's heart sank, being replaced with unyielding rage and hatred. Hanging in the air, like a miniature sun, was the Witch of Summer.

Ding.

Then he remembered what a single bell meant.

Ding.

Emergency imminent. Threat inbound.

Ding.

As he summoned a psychic dagger to his hand, his vision went white.

Ding.

"We have to move," Nettle said. "We're not far, we take to the air."

Thistle and Elisabeth nodded, both taking flight with own magic.

"Come on Elmond," Elisabeth summoned a spear for Elmond to fly on.

"No, that won't be necessary," Nettle looked at Thistle who nodded. "We'll be trying something out." She placed a hand on Elmond's shoulder, taking a deep breath. When she exhaled, Nettle and Elmond both took to the air.

"Woah!" Elmond floundered wiggled his limbs, trying to find some balance.

"Relax," Nettle said. "Imagine you're swimming."

"Is now a bad time to say I don't know how to swim?" Elmond confessed.

Nettle looked at Elisabeth, who rolled her eyes. Nettle amended the spell slightly.

"Then focus on going somewhere and you'll go there," Nettle said. She pointed at Elisabeth. "There, look at Elisabeth. Go to her."

"Here goes!" Elmond pointed at his sister. Slowly, like baby deer trying to learn how to walk, he wobbled in the air towards Elisabeth. As he got used to it, his flight became smoother, he got a little faster. When he reached her, Elmond turned back to Nettle and grinned. "I think I'm getting the hang of it."

Nettle nodded, then flew up to join them.

"Stay close to me," Elisabeth said. "In case the spell breaks, I want to be able to catch you."

"Do we have an idea of how long this'll last?" Elmond asked Nettle.

"Should be indefinite until either you or I break the spell," Nettle thought for a moment. "Do stay in eyesight of the both of us, just in case."

Elmond tossed a thumbs up.

"Follow my lead," Nettle said. "Keep an eye out for fire."

Nettle lead the party over the mountain peaks. They passed over ridges of stone and gravel, finding no snow this high up. It was hot. Hotter than the desert.

"I've heard stories about these ranges," Elmond said. "That they're like walking next to the sun."

"A side effect of the castle, no doubt," Thistle replied. "Similar to the storms around my castle. If there's a difference, it's in the fact that this effect is unassisted by the ancient magics."

"Meaning this heat is all Ivy," Nettle said. "And it would be far worse if the two of us weren't here."

"Exactly," Thistle confirmed.

"We're almost there," Nettle said. Then, in the distance, Nettle saw a ball of fire. "Take cover!" Nettle dove to the ground, the rest following her.

"With me," Thistle summoned her staff and drew a circle around her. The stones of the mountain obeyed her, drawing a similar circle around everyone else.

In that makeshift shelter, Nettle watched as a fragment tore through the air towards the north. It split into multiple parts and then flew towards targets

unknown.

When they were no longer to be seen, Nettle motioned for Thistle to break the shelter.

"And that's the source," Nettle said to Elisabeth and Elmond.

"And you tried to do this on your own?" Elmond asked.

"In fairness, we were both weaker at the time," Nettle pointed at herself and the castle in the distance. "Let's move."

They went back into the air and traveled across the ranges. Within moments, the castle was in view.

"There it is," Nettle pointed it out, landing on the ground a little ways away.

"That's the castle?" Elisabeth squinted. "It looks more like a an actual fireball."

Nettle couldn't refute her. On the mountain itself, a great ball of fire spun in place. Gouts would leak out of it, scorching the mountain.

"There's a castle in there," Nettle confirmed. "It's just being protected by all of that."

"So the first trick is getting inside," Elmond said.

"Have you tried to dispel it before?" Thistle asked. "I sense great magic on that flame."

"Not before," Nettle stepped forward with staff in hand. "Let's try."

Armed with more than the fundamentals, Nettle crafted a spell. A magic circle appeared at her feet. Nettle casted her mind towards the flame. As Thistle

mentioned, the fire was all magic. If Nettle could figure out the source or the mechanism the magic operated under, she could disrupt the flame that. Alternatively, she could smother the flame or... No, any option would take too long.

Nettle cut the spell and walked forward.

"Dispelling would take too long," Nettle said. "We're doing this a different way."

"Oh?" Thistle walked with her. "Which way is that?"

"Making a path," Nettle waved her staff around. All around them, thick trunks and roots burst through the rock. When Nettle felt she had enough, she called for more. Her magic empowered the wood. Then, she slammed the wood into the fireball.

With Nettle's strength empowering it, the wood didn't burst into flame instantly. Though, it was fighting her for it.

Thistle waved her staff next to Nettle, the surrounding stones moving at her command. It crept up the burnt wood, covering the ash with solid stone. Though it blackened, it didn't burn.

"Not hot enough to turn it molten," Thistle said.

"Expand it," Nettle said. The two sisters worked together to create a path for them through the fire. Thistle formed the fireproof shell with rock, while Nettle expanded the corridor with wood. Once the path was wide enough for two of them to walk in side by side, Nettle stopped her magic. "That should do it. Is

everyone ready?"

"Ready as we'll ever be," Elmond said. Elisabeth nodded with him.

"Then let's make our objective clear," Nettle said. "We have two missions here. The first is dragonblood for Elmond. We get that, we'll be able to perform the ritual to free him from his curse. The second is defeating Ivy once and for all. Are we clear?"

"We do the ritual before we fight the Witch," Elisabeth said.

"No," Elmond summoned a sword. "We fight the Witch first."

"If you fight the Witch in your current condition, we might lose you," Elisabeth said.

"And if we fight without me, we might lose everyone," Elmond refuted.

"Let's secure the dragonblood first," Nettle said. "This is Ivy's castle. No matter what we do from now on, we'll be stepping on her toes and there's a chance we'll have to fight before we're ready. Thistle, how fast can the ritual be done?"

"If we do it correctly with no harm done, it will take an hour. But, if you want to do it fast, it can be an instant. It will hurt and you will certainly come out of it with a cool scar," Thistle said.

"Then we have multiple options," Nettle said. "Will that be enough, Elisabeth?"

"It'll have to be," she grumbled.

"Then let's go. Stay safe, stay careful," Nettle lead the way through the corridor. Despite the sound of fire raging outside, the corridor held. The ambient heat was sweltering regardless, rivers of

sweat running down Nettle's back. She paid it no mind and focused - once on the inside of fire, she saw that the castle was built directly into the mountain. It was as large as Thistle's castle, maybe larger depending on if there were caverns as well. In either case, Nettle flew to the entrance, the rest of them following suit.

"Keep magic to a minimum," Nettle said. "We don't want to alert Ivy, not yet."

Thistle took a couple steps inside, looking around the blackened stone which made up the castle. Then, she slammed her staff into the ground a loud CRACK echoing through the halls.

"Thistle!?" Nettle whipped her head around. "What are you doing?"

"Stealth won't be necessary," Thistle said. "Ivy's not here."

"How can you tell?" Elisabeth asked.

"A feeling," Thistle said. "More specifically, a lack of one. I'm surprised you didn't notice," Thistle said to Nettle.

Nettle furrowed her brow and paced the hallway they were in. She thought to herself. Then her eyes widened and she looked to Thistle. Thistle nodded.

"Ashen," they both said at the same time.

"Good and bad news," Nettle said. "We can get the dragonblood with major worries."

"And the bad news is that the Witch isn't here," Elisabeth said. "Sounds more like good news."

"Good news for us," Nettle said. "But awful news for everyone who isn't us."

"That's a lot of people in Ashen, Elisabeth," Elmond said. "Even if they're better equipped to fight than Emain is..." He didn't finish the thought, Nettle understanding where he was going with it.

"Let's move quickly then," Nettle said. "If Ivy isn't here, let's split up. We can cover more ground that way. Elmond, go with my sister and travel the bottom half of the castle. Elisabeth, you're with me. We take the top half."

"Nettle," Elisabeth started. "I should--"

"No Elisabeth," Nettle shook her head. "If we're splitting into two parties, you wouldn't be able to cast the spell to stop the possession."

Elisabeth looked down. Then nodded.

"Hey," Elmond hugged his sister. "It'll be ok."

"It better," she said. "Alright Nettle. Let's go."

Nettle nodded and took to the air. "Thistle and I will keep in touch."

Understood, Thistle's voice rang in Nettle's mind. "Let's go, young Essaim." And then the two disappeared into the depths of the castle.

Nettle and Elisabeth flew to the top of the castle. There was a balcony leading to a bedroom, the master bedroom from the looks of it. It was bare. Scorch marks were everywhere. On the bed, on the walls. The ceiling. Except for one spot. A nightstand was untouched, though it was surrounded by blackened ash.

"Did you find something?" Elisabeth asked as Nettle approached it. She opened the top drawer, finding a picture frame. When she turned it over, Nettle frowned. The picture itself was burned. Hardly recognizable.

"Nothing we can use," Nettle showed her the picture. "Was hoping I can find family in it, but that's gone too."

"Nettle..." Elisabeth started to say something, but then stopped. "Never mind. We can talk about it later."

Nettle tilted her head, but let the topic drop. They explored more of the castle.

Though Nettle had no memory of this place, the Witch of Summer had a castle that was much easier to traverse than the Witch of Spring's. Straightforward and direct, no hidden passages and the ability to systematically go through each room.

Most of them were empty. Well, not empty in the normal sense. Empty as in, everything inside was burnt to a crisp. Each room was full of ashes. If not for the stone itself, Nettle knew the entire castle would be ash as well.

"Nothing," Elisabeth said. "Everything in here is ash and dust."

"Search," Nettle closed her eyes and casted the spell. Her magic pulsed through the castle, diffusing through all of the rooms. "No magic items, no nothing. Sorry, Elisabeth. Seems I won't be able to pay you with the treasures here."

"Save my brother and I'll consider us even," Elisabeth rolled her eyes. "What of them? Did they get better luck?"

"I'll find out," Nettle thought about Thistle. *Thistle, nothing at the top of the castle. Any better on your end?*

Nettle waited for a response. Just when she started to worry, she got a response.

Nothing in the castle. We found a passage deeper into the cave. This location. An image of their location appeared in Nettle's mind.

On our way, Nettle replied then turned to Elisabeth. "Same story from their end, but they did find an extra passage deeper into the mountain. We'll meet up with them before heading down."

"I don't like this," Elisabeth said. "It's too quiet, especially since this is supposed to be the source of it all."

"A fragment came from here earlier," Nettle said. "I don't fully understand how or why if Ivy isn't here."

They met up with Thistle and Elmond, who stood in front of the mouth of a cave.

"No dragon blood," Elmond said. "Everywhere we looked was ash. I assume it's the same for you two as well?"

"It doesn't make sense," Nettle said. "Not anything in here. I don't even know how fragments come out of here, let alone how we'll find dragon blood. Thistle, how were you so sure there'd be some?"

"It was something Ivy bragged about a lot," Thistle recalled. "I assumed she had an alchemical keg of some sort."

They all looked into the cave.

"Who's feeling brave?" Elmond asked everyone.

"Well, I'm not leaving empty-handed,"

Elisabeth said.

Thistle pointed at the tip of her staff, a mage light appearing.

"Time to find out that's behind door number three," Nettle took the lead, pointing at her own staff for a mage light of her own.

The group traveled down the cave. As it was slightly sloped down, Nettle knew they were going deeper into the mountain. They took slight turns, the path twisting and winding through. It started off hot and dry. Then, the path became more humid. Their sweat clung to them, drenching their clothes. A steady breeze picked up. A hot breeze smelling of sulfur. A breeze out. Then in. Out. Then in.

Nettle paused. She looked at everyone else behind her. The breeze continued, grabbing onto the wisps of everyone's clothes, of their hair.

The breeze stopped.

Nettle placed a finger to her lips, though everyone was quiet already. They continued onward. After some more time traveling, they came across a wall.

Except, it didn't look like a proper wall. Unlike the jagged walls of the cavern, the wall ahead of them was smooth. It didn't explain the breeze either. Nettle moved forward with her light, approaching the wall.

Her widened when she shone her light on it.

The wall wasn't completely smooth. Instead, a set of scales the size of her head, all neatly stacked upon each other. Red scales, that radiated intense heat.

Nettle looked back at everyone. She tapped her head and spoke in their minds.

Dragon, Nettle said.

Shit! Thistle swore, startling Elisabeth and Elmond in their place. *An actual dragon? Is this what Ivy meant when she talked about her dragon blood stores?*

What do we do? Nettle looked around everyone else.

I'm not leaving without dragon blood, Elisabeth said.

Our family are dragonslayers, Elmond said. *We should be able to pull this off.*

It's a foolish gamble, Thistle said. *A dragon outside of it's lair is dangerous. A dragon inside it's lair is twice as dangerous.*

Nettle looked at the wall in front of them.

Do you think Ivy is stronger than this dragon? Nettle asked.

Nettle, we can't. Thistle frowned.

That isn't what I asked.

Thistle shook her head, mumbling something underneath her breath. Then, she sighed.

Thistle? Is she stronger or not?

It is very likely that Ivy is stronger than this dragon, Thistle sighed.

Then we have to try. If we can't beat this enemy in front of us, then we won't have a chance against Ivy, Nettle said. *Besides, we need that blood.*

This is a mistake, Thistle said. *But very well. Their scales are impervious to most magics. Their insides are a different story. We will have to end this swiftly.*

Not only are they physically imposing, but magic runs in their veins. That means if they find themselves in enough danger they'll start casting. If we find ourselves at that point, our only option is to retreat.

Can you tell us how big the lair is?
Nettle asked.

Thistle closed her eyes, touching the tunnel wall beside them.

It is a proper lair. So long as we force ourselves through, there will be enough space to maneuver. Thistle confirmed.

Nettle nodded. *Elisabeth, Elmond, you two have the weapons. We'll start with you. I will provide support. Thistle, the moment this kicks off, create for us a path into the lair.*

I've got just the weapon for this,
Elmond summoned a lance. *The Drachenlance. Used by a Matriarch of the past during the Dragon War.* He handed it to Elisabeth, who held it close as she closed her eyes.

Ready, she said.

Nettle and Thistle took a step back, Elisabeth approaching the scales, Elmond behind her.

On your signal, Nettle said. The fringes of a spell appeared in her mind.

The lance began to glow an ethereal blue. The cave rumbled, dust coming from the ceiling.

"Now!" Elmond yelled.

Nettle pulled magic into herself and shared that with everyone. In that same moment, Elisabeth launched the lance into

the scales, piercing it in a moment. Blood was not drawn.

The wall moved and an ear shattering roar rippled through all of them.

Elmond jumped on the opportunity, grabbing the lance as it was moved away. Elisabeth followed, though Nettle lost sight of them both.

"Brace yourself," Thistle said, her voice a steely calm. She slammed the butt of her staff onto the ground. The tunnel around them exploded into fragments of stone - they didn't fall, instead being compressed into tiny shards which orbited Thistle.

With the extra space, Nettle found the space to fly and enter the lair properly. Below her, she spotted the light of the Drachenlance; Elmond held onto it with all his might as the body of the dragon thrashed about the place.

Nettle reached the ceiling. Once above, conjured several powerful lights to give everyone a better view. With those lights, size was easier to gauge.

The dragon itself was large, at least as large as the castle. The space in the cave was at least four times larger than that. Meaning that enough to maneuver was correct.

With Nettle turning on the lights, the dragon focused it's attention onto her. Golden eyes and red scales, it's maw snarled and opened, a massive breath of fire covering the entire ceiling. Nettle shielded herself with magic, but the heat was the hottest she ever felt. Hotter than Ivy's heat.

However, Nettle was stronger than before. She braved through the fire, coming outside of the breath as the dragon refocused on the Essaim twins. Just as Nettle tried to figure out her next steps, a glob of molten rock fell in front of her. When Nettle looked up, the breath was hot enough to turned the ceiling red hot, molten globs starting to fall ever so often. The dragon didn't seem to notice when the globs landed on their scales, but if the globs landed on Elmond and Elisabeth, there'd be trouble.

Thistle appeared next to Nettle. "Go," Thistle said. "I'll handle the lair. You support them properly." Nettle turned to protest, but Thistle was already controlling the stone in the ceiling, taking the molten rivulets and moving them to the walls instead of the ceiling.

Nettle flew towards the dragon. Elisabeth and Elmond going up and down it's back as best they could, avoiding it's breath and tail. They still have not recovered the lance. Nettle saw what the two were going for - the moment they fall off the back of the dragon is the very same moment the dragon can take advantage of the space and it's size to smash them underfoot.

Once Nettle was in range, she empowered them further. Without missing a beat, Elmond teleported back to the lance.

The massive tail of the dragon came to intercept him, but Elisabeth was there with her swords. She summoned plenty and held the tail at bay. From the other side, the dragon's head whipped around, fire

already spewing from it's maw.

Nettle was there. She pulled in raw magic and crafted a spell. Instead of using magic to brace through the flame, she parted the fire around them.

"Elmond! No!" Elisabeth's shouted behind Nettle.

From above, Elmond jumped in front of Nettle, the *Drachenlance* burning a crimson red. He ran up the dragon's back, dragging the tip of the lance through the dragon's scales. The cut through the scales like they weren't even there. The dragon bled boiling blood, the lance drinking and reddening with each minute.

Nettle saw another flash of red light. Then, the fire ceased. The dragon's limp body fell onto the ground. As blood boiled and pooled like a gushing torrent from the dragon's wounds, Nettle had a terrible feeling.

The dust hadn't settled, yet a black silhouette was visible within. They floated in midair, the lance in one hand, a sword in the other.

"Shit, shit, shit," Nettle swore and began the spell to the lock Elmond's mind.

Then she blinked, seeing stars as her back was against the wall and the lance was in her stomach.

Elmond's face looked at her, but his eyes were white. Floating above his head, was a white crown.

"After extensively talking about your plan, did you think I was going to let it happen?" the voice reverberated with power. Nettle was too late - the curse had taken over.

Elmond took the lance out and raised the white sword in the air.

Then, a solid chunk of stone slammed into him. Thistle appeared next to Nettle.

"Give me back my brother!" Elisabeth shouted. Swords and weapons outnumbered the stars Nettle has seen, the blade swirling around the lair.

"Heal yourself, Nettle," Thistle knelt next to her and shared magic. "We must hurry."

Nettle coughed blood and held the gaping wound. Her hand was hot, her blood spilling through her fingers.

"Nettle, focus," Thistle's hand glowed with her own magic. The wound began to heal.

"Right, yeah," Nettle shook her head, still dizzy from blood loss. Without even thinking of the spell, Nettle flowed magic into herself. Instinct took control, her body's natural growth accelerating as muscles were sown together, regrew, and skin covered it.

Thistle ripped Nettle's shirt open and began drawing on her chest in blood.

"Thistle, what?" Nettle still didn't have full senses back yet.

"Your ritual seal is in a dangerous spot. We have to lift it now," Thistle said.

"Chances that I die?"

"Because I am doing it, none," Thistle said. "This will be extraordinarily painful. It will feel like your heart is being ripped from your chest."

"How do you know that?" Nettle asked

through the delirium.

Thistle finished drawing, then flooded the circle with magic. The sudden searing pain caused Nettle to scream and writhe underneath Thistle.

As her vision tinged with darkness and stars, she was dimly aware that Thistle reached into her own chest. Each touch was agony. Thistle brushed against something. She squeezed and pulled. Nettle felt her heart ripped out of her chest.

Then, all that was left was a dull, aching pain. More magic flowed through her, magic that Nettle didn't know she had.

"I've released the seal," Thistle said.

Nettle looked up, all of the swords almost gone. Elisabeth was down to a couple, Elmond leisurely approaching her.

Power rolled off of Nettle like smoke. At her feet, little plants sprouted.

"From what I can tell Nettle, it's still an uphill battle," Thistle said.

"How long do you need to start the ritual?" Nettle asked, testing her own body with some stretches.

"A minute," Thistle said. "Once ready, you need to keep him pinned for thirty seconds."

"A lifetime," Nettle felt something in her throat. She coughed and spat out another glob of blood. On the ground ahead of them, the dragon blood continued to pool and boil. "There's plenty of blood, most of it should be dragon. Get started, I'll buy you the time you need!" Nettle took to the air. She flew faster than she expected, blowing right past Elisabeth and

Elmond.

"Knowing our plan won't help you!" Nettle shouted. She pointed at Elisabeth, magic flowing into her.

Her strength renewed, Elisabeth re-summoned all of her swords.

With the amount of magic flowing through her, Nettle forwent the fancy spells. She opted for raw magic. Relying back on her fundamentals, magic orbited her like stars. Nettle flew back and crashed right into Elmond. She collected the orbs where they touched and blasted him as she continued charging him through.

"Temporary measure," Elmond said.

Nettle noticed two swords about to skewer her - she blasted Elmond away and sent orbs to stop them.

Nettle turned. Despite sending Elmond flying, he was already behind her, sword in hand. Heavy, white armor formed where Nettle blasted him.

As Elmond began to swing, something stopped him. A moment of confusion appeared on his face, then another swarm of swords engulfed him.

Within that storm, a radiant light appeared. It cut through all of the blades, Elmond unscathed. In fact, another part of his body had the white armor. Elmond looked himself over.

"A futile effort," he said. His voice reverberated with even more power. **"Even as his mind struggles, this body will be mine ere long."**

"I won't let that happen," Elisabeth summoned a sword that mirrored the sword

Elmond held. A similar radiant light appeared in her hands. "By the powers vested in my sword, I will sever you from my brother!" Elisabeth swung, Elmond swinging to meet them.

Their swords clashed, though Elisabeth's blade was much smaller. At the same time, blades flew at Elmond. Elmond countered with blades of his own, giving no quarter.

Nettle flew around with blasts of magic, giving Elisabeth any opening she could. The armor was tough. As Nettle flew around, she saw the dragon's body, still warm. An idea wormed it's way into her head. She flew across the breadth of the dragon's body, a hand on the scales.

Though the dragon was dead, this was a creature of magic. She pulled out the fading magic. Even fading, there was an incredible wealth of magic, enough to empower Nettle even further. As Nettle grew in strength, so did Elisabeth, the sword growing to match.

"Enough!" Elmond shouted. A wave of radiant light shattered Elisabeth's sword and knocked Nettle out of the air. For as much power as Nettle gathered, Nettle could only concede that Thistle was right - it was still an uphill battle. **"You will not stop me!"**

Ready, Thistle spoke in Nettle's mind.

"We'll see about that," Nettle formed several orbs around Elmond. She blasted him with everything she had and then a little more. Even if it didn't hurt him, all she needed to do was distract him. Nettle flew close.

Another wave of radiant light shattered her magical orbs. Nettle pushed through, just close enough to grab Elmond's head in both hands.

"*Labyrinth!*" Nettle shouted with her mind, body, and soul. The magic circle appeared in single instant. It wasn't pretty or elegant in any sense of the spell. But what Nettle lacked in skill, she made up with power.

The spell took hold, the white eyes fading to Elmond's natural color.

Then they turned white again, Elmond grabbing Nettle by the neck.

"**Temporary measure,**" Elmond growled.

Another magic circle appeared, the border surrounding them.

Nettle grinned. "This measure is less temporary."

"Elmond Essaim, son of Elmara Essaim, I hereby banish you from the blood that binds you!" Thistle shouted from below. "I banish you from the family that birthed you! I banish you from the ancestors that guide you!"

The ritual took hold on Elmond, the white armor cracking off. He lost his strength on Nettle, his skin burning.

"Nettle!" Thistle flew beside Nettle, a red dagger in her hands. It dripped blood. "He needs to be cut with this!"

A concussive force hit both of them.

"I **won't** let **you!**" Elmond struggled but still had some power left, knocking both of them out of the air.

"Elisabeth!" Nettle tossed the dagger. Elisabeth was there, grabbing onto the

dagger and diving into the circle. She cut a savage gash across Elmond's back.

"Three times I have banished you!" Thistle yelled mid-fall. "Be severed from blood!"

The magic circle activated in earnest, summoning a platinum light. Elisabeth fell out of it, her body smoking but not burnt.

Nettle caught her. She blinked her eyes open, groaning all the way.

When the light faded, Elmond fell too.

"Elmond," Elisabeth jumped out of Nettle's arms and flew to her brother. She caught him, lightly slapping his face awake. His back was still bleeding.

Nettle rushed over and provided some healing. She couldn't heal the wound completely, not since it was caused as part of a ritual, but she was able to stop the bleeding.

Elmond's eyes fluttered open.

"Tell me you're ok," Elisabeth pleaded.

"I'm..." Elmond struggled to speak. He raised his hand to hold his sister's face. Then his eyes flashed pure white. **"I'm glad. This is the first with twins and as long as there are two, I will never be severed."**

"No!" Nettle yelled. Another wave of radiant light knocked Nettle away. She tried pull magic from the air, but the two of them were already being covered in the white armor as before.

Hand in hand, eyes glowing white, Nettle watched in horror as both siblings were taken over.

"Thistle!" Nettle called for her

sister. "We still have dragon blood, do the ritual again!"

No response.

"Thistle?" Nettle looked down, Thistle pinned by blades.

"A valiant effort. Ultimately wasted," The twins said in unison. The both raised a hand and summoned a weapon to hand. Elisabeth summoned the radiant sword. Elmond summoned the blood dagger. **"With this power, I will not fail!"**

Elmond broke free, regaining control of half his body. He took the dagger and cut his sister's chest, mirroring the gash on his back. "I banish you, I banish you, I banish you! Thrice banished, be exiled by blood!"

The light stopped. As instantly as it came. The swords faded. And then the twins fell.

Nettle caught them. She pulled Thistle off the floor, taking them all back to the entrance of the lair. The wounds ran deep. They were all breathing, but just.

With the last of the magic available to her, Nettle healed what she could of their wounds. She closed the worst of them. When Nettle ran out of magic, she sat down and collapsed on the spot.

"That was too close," she said to herself.

Nettle didn't know when she fell asleep. In fact, only realized it when she woke up.

Her eyes darted to where she left her sister and the twins, only to find them missing. Nettle jumped to her feet, ready to search. She looked to her left and found them all sitting against the wall. They were nursing their healed injuries, but was otherwise alive.

"Oh, you're all ok," Nettle fell back down.

"Sorry to scare you," Thistle said. "We're all ok."

"Do any of you feel different?" Nettle asked.

"I am sore, but nothing else," Thistle said. "I would imagine you two to be much worse." Thistle nodded to Elmond and Elisabeth.

Elmond opened his eyes and leveled a weak gaze to Nettle. His eyes were normal, the same platinum color as his hair and not very useful in the dark.

"My back feels like it's on fire," Elmond said. "I can scarcely move and I'm starving."

Elisabeth sighed and opened her eyes as well. "The same for me. Except my front burns and not my back."

"Let's get the packs, we should still have some supplies for the return trip," Nettle said.

"That's the thing, Nettle," Elmond closed his eyes again and laughed. "We left our travel packs in our armory."

Nettle chuckled, shaking her head all the while. "Of course we did. And that

magic is fully gone then?"

"Gone and empty," Elisabeth said. She held her hand out. All of them watched and waited. Nothing happened. "I'm not going to lie, I do feel empty."

"One side effect of the hurried ritual," Thistle said. "There will have to be an adjustment period. You will no longer have access to your family's magic. At the same time, you will no longer be in danger of possession."

"That's good," Elmond smiled. "Hey, you also mentioned that the scar would look cool." He struggled to his feet and turned his back to them. "Can you check if it actually does?"

Elisabeth rolled her eyes, but Thistle obliged him. She used her staff to raise the back of his shirt, revealing a red line that traveled from his shoulder to the opposite hip.

"It looks a little raw, but with time it'll heal," Thistle said. "I do think it'll turn out nicely."

"Thanks, Thistle," Elmond turned back and stretched. His stretches were a little reserved, his body still wincing. "Some movement is doing me some good. How about your scar, Elisabeth?"

Elisabeth shook her head. "Does it matter?"

"Of course it does!" Elmond sat down next to her. "If we're getting scars, they might as well be cool, right?"

"That's true," Thistle nodded enthusiastically in agreement.

"Nettle, help me out here," Elisabeth pleaded.

"I think you're outvoted," Nettle smiled, trying her best not to laugh. Elisabeth rolled her eyes.

"If you all insist," Elisabeth stood, leaning on Elmond for support. She raised her shirt, showing off her scar. Similar to Elmond, it went from her shoulder to her the opposite hip, just on the front instead of the back.

"A respectable scar," Thistle said. "It is fortunate that you two were able to fight back as you did."

"Yeah," Nettle nodded.

"While this is fine, we still have another problem on our hands," Elisabeth said, sitting down again. "We've lost a lot of strength. Even if Elmond and I try to regain what we've lost some other way, it'll take too long."

Nettle shook head and waved her off. "We'll manage. I don't know how we're going to confront Ivy now, but we've already done too much today. We can worry about that when we're out of here and rested."

"Agreed," Thistle nodded. "I am glad we were able to break you from your curse."

"No, I should be thanking you," Elisabeth said. She held onto her brother. "We don't have to live with this shadow anymore."

Elmond smiled. Nettle noticed that there was a part of it that was forced. She didn't press the issue.

They all rested for a little while longer. Nettle got to her feet first. She helped everyone else get to their feet, sharing magic with them.

"Not the best substitute for a full night's rest or a hearty meal," Nettle confessed. "But it'll do until we get to a safe place. Let's go."

So began their arduous journey out of the cave. It was slow goings, their pace burdened by their exhaustion. Though Nettle tried to put the questions from her mind, she thought a lot about how they were going to face Ivy. Would Nettle be able to learn all she needed when they confronted her? Would Nettle be able to protect her friends from her? How would they even find Ivy?

Questions such as that swam around her head. Then, as they approached the mouth of the cave and saw the interior of the castle in sight, another question occurred to her.

"How are we going to deal with the firewall?" Nettle asked aloud.

Thistle shrugged. "We will deal with it as we must. Carefully."

To Nettle's relief, they didn't have to deal with it at all. They exited the cave in a peculiar silence. When they returned to the castle entrance, the fire was gone. Without the fire raging throughout around the castle, there was an eerie silence.

"Looks like we don't have to deal with it at all," Elmond said.

"A good fortune," Thistle said.

Nettle agreed.

"Think we can make the journey back?" Elisabeth asked. "Walking through this seems less than ideal."

"Flying for a day will take us out of the range. Once there, it'll be easier to

get supplies," Nettle said.

"We'll need a better place than the rough outdoors," Elmond said. "Ashen is the closest major city. I know it might be dangerous, but I bet the guild will still take us."

"It's risky," Nettle said. "Doubly so for Thistle. While I got away with being registered, I don't think she'll be able to be registered without any warning."

"One step at a time," Thistle reminded. She took to the air and tapped on Elmond with her staff. He took to the air as well. Nettle did the same with Elisabeth. It was a steady flight outside of the mountain ranges. They went slower than usual, taking it easy as Nettle fought off exhaustion. Though she made it out with lighter injuries than everyone else, she was still tired.

It wasn't the physical kind of tiredness, the kind that where the body ached and screamed for relief. No, her body was quiet. She could move normally, as she wanted, with no impediments to her physical strength.

It was Nettle's mind that was tired. Her mind was wandering, her eyes looking at where she was going but not seeing.

Nettle wanted the world to stop for a moment. A single moment. Just long enough for her to catch her breath.

Yet as they crested the final cliff that served as the border of the Spineshatter Ranges and back onto the central plains, Elisabeth pointed out the camp at the bottom of the cliffs.

They had the unmistakable Ashen reds.

"We'll have to be quick," Nettle shook off her exhaustion and readied her magic. "If they notice us, I can launch us out of here."

"It's a little late for that," Elmond shook his head. "They're already coming."

Nettle looked around. Appearing out of the air in flashes of teleports were several mages. They wore combat leathers and were equipped with all sorts. A few with staves and wands, another few with conventional weapons.

All them looked capable.

Flying from the camp below was the cloaked mage from the island. They flew and met with Nettle. Once they were even with each other, the mage raised their hands for Nettle to clearly see.

"The Commander wishes to speak with you," they said.

Thistle answered before Nettle could. "Of course. Lead the way."

Thistle? Nettle shot her a look.

Have faith, Thistle said. *We are in no condition to fight.*

"Follow me," The mage descended into the camp. With escorts on either side, Nettle followed.

The mage brought them to the largest tent. Commander Nail was inside at the head of a table. But, he wasn't alone. All around the table were the other adventurers who had helped them before.

The woman with the poofy hat winked at Nettle.

"The Witch of Spring and the Witch of Fall," Commander Nail greeted them. "As

well as the Essaim twins. Thank you for accepting my invitation." He stood from his seat and bowed, revealing that his black armor had partially melted into him.

"Commander Nail," Elmond greeted him. "You look like shit."

"A side effect from the most recent attack on Ashen," Nail chuckled. "The Witch of Summer had paid us a visit. If not for these erstwhile adventurers, it would have been tough for my unit to stop her."

"So long as everyone is safe," Nettle said.

"Of course," Nail agreed. "So long as everyone is safe. This, however, leads us to the next step. After that display, my superiors have saw it fit to wipe out this problem once and for all. Now that they've seen her dangers on our soil, the problem is more tangible for them."

Nail walked around the table, pacing the tent. "We knew where the source is, of course. We've always known. Checking for identical two magic signatures is trivial with our resources."

"And that brought you here," Nettle surmised.

"Indeed," Nail leaned on the table. "To our surprise, the magic signature in this location was snuffed out. When our scouts reported your crossing the ranges, I was less surprised."

"Is that why you have stopped us?" Nettle asked. She added as much venom as she could, though her heart wasn't in it due to exhaustion. "To say thank you?"

"Yes," Nail said. "Thank you, for

solving this. My family thanks you, as well as other families impacted by this."

"Oh," Nettle was caught off guard by his candor.

"There is something else, is there not?" Thistle asked.

"There is," Nail nodded. "In addition to thanking you, we have also come to beg for a boon. I understand that our actions on your island may have soured our relations, but I trust that after share our information, you will find boon beneficial for all of us."

"Out with it," Nettle said. "We've had a long couple of days and are not in the mood for riddles."

"No riddles," Nail agreed. "It's very simple. Despite your successful foray into the castle and snuffing out the magic within, I would imagine that the Witch of Summer was not there personally. Am I correct?"

Nettle didn't answer right away.

"Whichever your answer is," Nail continued. "We fought the Witch of Summer earlier in Ashen. The actual Witch. At Ashen, we have an incredible home advantage. We've won, multiple times over. Multiple times, being the key. See, no matter how much power we pump into the Witch, she always rises again with even hotter flames. The true problem is when we tried to peak into her mind."

"What did you find?" Thistle asked.

"Nothing," Nail said. "Absolutely nothing."

"That can't be right," Nettle frowned. "She'd be a fragment in that case."

"You're right," Nail said. "Not it was not a fragment we fought. I've cut through fragments before. This was flesh and bone, wrought by magic. When we did manage to drive the Witch away, she didn't go South, as I expected. Instead, she went North."

"North," Nettle repeated.

"Here's my theory," Nail beckoned them to look at the map behind him. He pointed to the Frozen Wastes that was at the very north of the map. Then he pointed at a circle that was between the two. "The Witch is here. We tracked her past the Scar but for some reason, she stopped at the border into the Wastes. There's a missing piece here. I think you know what is. Rather, who it is."

"The Witch of Winter," Nettle said.

"The only Witch unaccounted for," Nail nodded his head. "I'm thinking there's something there. If Summer and Winter were in cahoots, Summer would be there already. There's something that's stopping her. That's our opportunity. Your group will go past the Witch of Summer and find the Witch of Winter. From my side, we will stall the Witch of Summer and buy you as much time as you need."

Nettle looked at Thistle, who looked at her.

"It is a solid plan," Thistle admitted. "My only question is what makes you so sure it will succeed? We could just as easily find the Witch of Winter and find nothing of import."

"A fair question. Let me answer this as such," Nail crossed his arms. "This is not the last resort. The last resort would be

getting an Archmage involved and obliterating the Witch of Summer from existence. Knowing what we know of the Witch and of the possible Archmage, it's liable to break the continent in half."

"That's bad," Elmond said.

"Very," Nail nodded. "So this is my leap of faith before it gets to that point. I don't know what you'll find, I don't know how you do it. I don't even know if the Witch of Winter is alive. What I do know is that we thought Fall was dead." Nail gestured to Thistle. "I know that the Witch of Summer is heading North. After that," He shrugged. "We'll just have to wait and see."

"Any thoughts, Nettle," Thistle asked.

"We'll do it," Nettle agreed to the plan. "How long do we have?"

"We expect the Witch of Summer to recuperate enough strength to break into the Frozen Wastes in three days. We have enough mages to start teleporting up there in two. We start tonight."

Nettle thought to herself. Not much time to rest.

"I can teleport ourselves directly to the Frozen North," Thistle said. "If you give us a day to recover, we can get a head start."

"Truly?" Nail scratched his chin. "Then you will have your day of rest. Speak with Chance. They'll be able to provide you with warm beds and hot food. We will start sending our resources now. I will see you off tomorrow."

"Understood," Nettle nodded and walked out of the tent, following Chance the

cloaked mage.

As Nail said, Chance showed them a tent where food was being prepared. Once Nettle ate, Chance then brought them to a separate tent. There were four cots inside, just enough for their party.

Nettle thanked the mage, who nodded and left them to their devices.

Once there, Nettle sat on her cot. She sat there and stared into nothing.

"Nettle," Thistle sat next to her.

Nettle whipped her head in Thistle's direction. She felt Thistle place a hand on her shoulder. A soft touch, gentle and warm.

"It's going to be ok," Thistle said.

Then, as if a dam within her broke, Nettle deflated. Tension that she didn't realize she was holding onto escaped her as Nettle relaxed. She collapsed onto her sister, her body letting go. With her body relaxed, Nettle fell asleep in an instant.

Nettle didn't dream often. When she did, they were of random scenes of no importance. She used to have nightmares of the flames. Burnt corpses reaching out to her, running from fire. She didn't know when they stopped, or why, but they did.

This dream was peculiar. She was laying on someone's lap, could feel someone grooming her hair. When Nettle opened her eyes, she was met by an older woman. Her eyes were unmistakably blue, the color of ice. Her hair was the color of sunshine on a winter day. Her lips were red, perked up in the warmest of smiles.

"You're almost there, my darling," she said. "I believe in you."

When Nettle awoke, her cheeks were wet with tears. With a spring in her step, she wiped the tears away and got up from bed. A new day has dawned, and with it, a chance to set things right.

"Best of luck out there," Elisabeth said. She and Elmond with the two witches just outside of the Ashen camp. They were outside of the magic circle Thistle created.

"You as well," Nettle smiled. She gestured to the "What's the score on Ashen leaving you out to the woods?"

"Well, without our family magic our talents are better on the front lines," Elmond said. "As much as we want to repay your help with ours, it would be difficult as we are."

"It's ok," Nettle said. "This is help too. Buy us as much time as you can."

"That is the intention," walking from the camp was Commander Nail, slow, limping steps as he struggled against the black armor fused with his body. He nodded at Elmond and Elisabeth, giving both of them red cloaks. "This will prevent friendly fire." He acknowledged Nettle and Thistle. "Regretfully, I don't have any gifts for the two of you except for luck and well wishes."

"It will be enough," Thistle said. She looked at Nettle. "Are we ready?"

"As we'll ever be," Nettle took a couple steps back to the center of the circle. She looked at the Essaim twins, at her friends. She smiled and held her staff out to them. "Farewell. And thank you."

Thistle activated the magic circle, the breeze picking up, runes glowing in ethereal blue light. She spoke a word.

Nettle's body froze as the cold engulfed her to the bones. The ice shattered, her consciousness taken away by

the winter breeze.

Though scattered, she was dimly aware of the sky. Bright blue and crisp, there was an element of familiarity across the winds that took her. Before she could place it, the shards of her shattered ice reformed. The ice receded and when Nettle exhaled, the rest of the cold went with it.

Nettle shivered and looked around for her sister, who reappeared shortly after her.

"That was different than the other teleports," Nettle noted.

"A habit from our mother," Thistle smiled and gestured for Nettle to look around. Nettle did.

Her heart fluttered.

Though most of it was reclaimed by time and snow, Nettle recognized where they were. In front of them was a house, most of it blown to pieces. None of the wood was rotten, but most of it was burnt. There was even a tower of stone where most of the labs were. Those stones were burnt as well the tower itself collapsed from the concussive force behind it. Nettle dropped her staff and continued through the house.

Nettle knew the way to the back, though it wasn't necessary with the state of the house. If she wanted to, she could've gone around, straight through, above. But Nettle didn't do any of those things. Instead, she walked through rooms that echoed in the back of her mind. Doors that didn't exist anymore. She walked through her childhood home, to the back where she

saw snow covering a crater.

"Home," Nettle sighed.

"Where it all began," Thistle had followed her, carrying Nettle's staff. "Mother's castle is not far from here."

Nettle took her staff back and followed Thistle through the forest. There was a path that they took that Nettle often used while exploring. Though timeworn, there was enough of it to follow. Then a thought came to her mind.

"Thistle? Where are we?" Nettle asked her.

"Home," Thistle replied. "More specifically, two weeks North of the Scar."

"I get that," Nettle looked at the sky, still blue. "But I've traveled pretty far on my own and could never get back here. And if mother's castle is so close, how come I've never ran into it when I was a kid?"

Thistle turned back, the corner of her lip quirked upward.

"For the second, you'll understand once we enter the Frozen North. As for the first," Thistle continued onward, but pointed her staff to the sky. As she moved her staff, Nettle saw magical runes appear. "There is a glamor around this area. A couple of spells meant for hiding us. Another couple of spells meant to suggest others to go away. Part of the ceremony for you to become a witch was so that you understood the ward and can pass through it easily."

"All of that, just for us?" Nettle looked around.

"Mother was only a little bit paranoid," Thistle confessed. "I actually helped her with maintaining the wards once I was able to. It is a miracle they have lasted this long."

"Do you think it's because it's been this long the Witch of Summer is making her move?"

"Perhaps, though I don't see why," Thistle said. "Once bonded, it'll stay with your blood and soul until death."

"That's an awful thought," Nettle mumbled.

"Oh? How so?"

"Because that would've meant that the reason the Witch of Summer hasn't breached the barrier yet would've been because Ivy's dead," Nettle said.

Thistle paused for a moment. "That is an awful thought."

The two didn't elaborate further.

The path through the forest got colder and colder. Nettle shivered as snow turned to ice and soon, the trees of the forest broke way.

Ahead of them was ice and snow, as far as the eye can see. Perhaps in the distance there were snow-capped mountains, but Nettle could not make out their shapes.

The expanse was wide, far enough to see the clouds ahead and the storm that was approaching them.

"Mother's castle is through there?" Nettle asked. "Makes sense for the Witch of Winter."

"Not through there exactly," Thistle

said. "It is there. Everywhere there is snow and frost is mother's domain. Step onto the ice without her permission and the elements themselves will endeavor to keep you out."

"Much like yours," Nettle remembered the castle.

"Exactly like mine, only more..." Thistle paused, looking for the word. "Malicious."

"But it will be fine for us?" Nettle tested by waving a hand through the border. There was a sharp wave of cold running through her arm, but before Nettle could pull her arm back, the cold abated.

"You really should have waited for my answer before testing that," Thistle mused, but she walked forward into the ice. "The more magic you have, the harsher the backlash. If you weren't family, it would've frozen your arm solid."

"Not one to do things by halves," Nettle followed her, the cold brushing against the rest of her body like a gentle breeze.

The storm approached. The howling wind nipped at their clothes, at their hair, yet it passed over them without discomfort. Snow and hail fell down in droves.

The snow didn't touch them.

"What happens if someone outside the family makes it this far?" Nettle yelled over the howling winds.

"Well, making it past the first couple barriers would be fiendishly difficult. Difficult, but not impossible. At this point, they'd be battered by the storm. If they don't freeze to death, the land will

warp itself to usher them out."

"If they've gotten here, I can't imagine the land stopping them," Nettle thought about what it would take. She had some concepts of how, but it was still several tiers above of what she could do currently.

"Most likely not," Thistle agreed. "That's what the next spell is for. Copy my movements and what I say."

Thistle waved her staff in the air, Nettle following suit. The wind picked up, following the movements of their staves. Thistle began a chant, Nettle echoing the aria.

The snow and ice fell around them, same as before. But as they walked and shaped the magic, a tunnel began to form. A warmth blossomed in Nettle's chest, something that warded away the cold.

When the tunnel was fully made, the wind stopped. Thistle set her staff down. Before Nettle could realize it, she passed through a portal, the magic so imperceptible she didn't realize it was there until it touched her skin.

A sudden flash of light.

Nettle bumped into Thistle, who paused. Nettle blinked the light away from her eyes, putting a hand on her sister's shoulder to steady herself.

"Behold, the castle of the Witch of Winter," Thistle said. "Look upon its glory and despair."

When Nettle could finally see, she gasped.

To call the building in front of her a castle would be the same as calling a

mountain a hill. The castle was off several spires, each higher than the rest. Nettle kept looking up and up and up until her neck strained look as high as she could. Even then, the peak of the castle broke through the cloud layer above. The storm surrounded them like a barrier, clear blue sky in between them and the castle.

If Ashen was built around a mountain, the castle itself was the mountain.

"I'm starting to think our mother was more than extravagant," Nettle said.

Thistle smiled. It was soft, a little exasperated. Then she led on. The two sisters approached the large frozen doors of the castle. Nettle looked around as they did. The wind had stopped, as did the falling snow.

It occurred to her then, that the only sound she heard were the crunching of her footsteps in the snow. The world felt still.

"Here we are," Thistle raised her staff to the doors ahead of them. The doors were massive, large enough to let the dragon they've fought through unhindered. Thistle tapped her staff against the doors.

"Mother, your children has come home," she whispered. If there was even a stiff breeze, Nettle wouldn't have heard what Thistle said.

The huge doors opened into the castle, as silent and unnerving as the weather. They didn't open all the way, however. Just enough to let the two of them in.

Thistle walked through. Nettle grabbed her sister's hand just before she

disappeared into the castle.

"Thistle, I don't like this," Nettle said. "I can't imagine mom making something like this."

"There's a lot about mother you don't know," Thistle said, but she held on to her sister's hand, which Nettle was grateful for. "Never one to do things by halves." When Thistle stepped into the castle, Nettle went with her.

The moment they stepped inside, the doors closed behind them. Silent as ever, the only thing that changed was the natural sunlight disappearing behind them.

Ahead of them was a grand hall leading to a spiral staircase leading upwards. An ethereal blue light suffused the air, several braziers lit with the same colored blue. The castle was cold. In heart, soul, and body.

"Do you know if people made this?" Nettle asked. Her voice didn't carry far, didn't echo.

"No," Thistle replied. She was louder, more confident than Nettle. But her voice didn't echo either. "Just one person. Just one mage. Just one witch. Come on. It's a long way up to the throne room."

Their footsteps were the only sound the echoed throughout the castle as they climbed the staircase. While Thistle kept her focus on the path ahead, Nettle's eyes shifted all the castle. Their home was something that was lived in. Warm, full of life, full of sounds. Smiles met with smiles. Bruises met with kisses and mistakes met with kindness.

Nettle couldn't imagine the woman who

made this castle.

Actually, there was one thing Nettle could imagine of this woman. In a castle this large, this quiet, and this hostile, she must've been alone. She must've been lonely.

That was the only thing that made sense to Nettle.

"Was mother lonely?" Nettle suddenly asked Thistle.

Thistle paused, both in step and in response. She turned Nettle, the same exasperated smile on her face.

"When you were younger, you'd often ask Ivy and me if we knew why Mother stared off into the distance," Thistle reminisced.

"You said you didn't know what I was talking about," Nettle remembered.

"We lied," Thistle turned and kept walking.

"I get that much," Nettle kept up with her, her unease turning into impatient anger.

"This is hard for us too," Thistle said. "Especially since it was a sore spot for Ivy."

"What was the sore spot?" Nettle pressed. "I'm tired of talking around our mom. Everyone is saying she's more powerful or dangerous or whatever, but no one is telling me **why**!"

Why... why... why... The last word echoed throughout the castle. The castle shuddered with her words, ice tinkling.

The sisters held their breath, only breathing when the shuddering stopped and

silence returned.

Thistle looked around at the castle. On some level, Nettle saw hurt in her eyes.

"It's like that?" She asked the empty air.

Her voice did not carry. The castle did not answer.

"Very well," Thistle sighed. She turned to look at Nettle, taking another look around the castle. "I'll give you the short version."

"No," Nettle pushed. "You'll give me the whole version."

"We would be here for a fortnight," Thistle held a wry smile. "Some day, I will tell you the whole story. This I promise by my love to you and the stones of my magic. But I will tell you what you need to know."

Nettle stewed on it for a moment before nodding.

"The important things about mother..." Thistle began walking up the staircase, slower this time as she pondered where to begin. "She is powerful, this you've been told and understood. But her power lies in her talent and her age. Let's start with her age, for her talent is less relevant. She is, by a conservative estimate, at least a millennium of years."

"An estimate," Nettle played with the word.

Thistle shrugged. "After a certain amount of years, the exact number ceases to matter. That is what she told us, and it's as good as a reason as any."

"How does her age account into this?" Nettle asked.

"It accounts by giving us a long, long time to wonder," Thistle explained. "Mother's epithet wasn't always the Witch of Winter. She has a large number of names. *Godslayer, Starchild, Speaker to Dragons, Archmagus.*" Thistle paused. "*Destroyer of Selarune.*"

"A large collection," Nettle said.

"Only a handful," Thistle replied. "All earned and collected. But that is but a symptom of this." Thistle waved to the castle. "I'm sure you've felt the air of this castle. The oppressiveness and unease."

"The loneliness," Nettle added.

Thistle's eyes widened at that. She tilted her head, listening to something unseen, then acquiesced.

"Yes, I suppose that too," Thistle nodded. "Which brings us to the why. The woman, the mage known as Lily Lochbeldra once had a family. A son, some thousand years ago."

Nettle's eyes became round, like saucers.

"I've never heard of an older brother," Nettle said. Realization continued. "Oh. I see."

"The beginnings of it, yes," Thistle nodded. "I do not know the specifics, but Ivy and I know that much. The one time we've confronted her about it, the air was filled with so much rage that I thought she was going to kill us on the spot. After a thousand years, she feels that pain so keenly." There was a touch of resentment in her voice.

Nettle pondered that.

"This brings us to the next why," Thistle continued. "Why us?"

"What do you mean, why us?" Nettle looked up and saw the end of the staircase.

"Why did the Witch of Winter bother with us?" Thistle said. "Were we meant to be nothing more than replacements?"

The image of the woman who raised them flashed in Nettle's mind. Nettle tried to imagine her as the witch that Thistle talked about.

"We're at the top," Thistle brandished her staff. "Stay sharp, we don't know what's awaiting us."

Thistle took point to the top of the castle. She was right to be careful, of course.

Something in Nettle stirred. An answer that was obvious to her, but one that Thistle might not have considered. While she stewed on her thoughts, she followed her sister to the top of the stairs, ready to confront their mother, Lily Lochbeldra, the Witch of Winter.

The top of the stairs led them to an antechamber. A set of double doors blocked their way deeper inside. Unlike the rest of the castle, power thrummed from them.

Nettle recognized these runes. Runes of warding. They were double-sided, meant to keep people out and whatever was inside the room in.

"A heavy ward," Thistle noted aloud. "It's strong. Not only that, it was thrown up fairly recently."

"How recent?" Nettle looked for the signs in the magic, but evidently she hadn't developed that sensitivity yet.

"I would put it at the length of this business," Thistle said. "That is my best guess."

"Which means Ivy hadn't killed in her in that fire," Nettle studied the wards. There was something there that didn't feel right.

"So it would seem," Thistle didn't seem all that surprised. Considering Nettle found Thistle in stasis after assuming the worst, perhaps Nettle shouldn't have been either. "In either case, it's a perfect ward." She glanced at in a direction and tilted her head. "It would take more time than we have to break it this way. We'll have to forgo the decorum and go around."

Thistle turned to go.

Nettle kept her eyes on the ward and instead of turning with Thistle, she approached it.

"Perfect?" Nettle dropped her staff with a clatter. With her hands free, she traced air above the runes, spurred by memory more than theory. "That can't be

right. There's a flaw here."

"I've seen mother create wards all my life," Thistle said. "She does not make mistakes."

"Maybe not," Nettle mumbled. "But maybe it's not a mistake."

Her hands continued tracing runes, but her eyes were no longer on them. Instead, she heard her mother's voice.

Nettle remembered sitting on her mother's lap, underneath the shadow of a tree. Solid stone runes were carved in front of them, tactile building blocks of magic since Nettle was too young to properly cast at the time.

"Can you make me a perfect ward?" her mother asked her.

"Yeah! Like this!" Nettle arranged the runes a certain way. She showed her work to her mother.

"A very solid attempt," her mother praised. "As perfect as I would have made it."

Nettle beamed.

"But, there's a trick here," her mother said. "A perfect ward also has a perfect flaw."

"What?" Nettle gasped. "Where?"

"Here, I'll show you," Her mother took Nettle's hands and traced the runes with her.

Outside of the memory, in the frozen castle, Nettle placed her fingers onto the glyphs.

"Nettle wait!" Thistle rushed over as Nettle touched the ward. A spell was crafted on her staff, but Nettle held her

other hand out.

The ward didn't trigger.

"A perfect ward has a perfect flaw," Nettle echoed her mother's words. As if her mother was guiding her, Nettle found the flaw and used it to shatter the ward.

"I don't believe it," Thistle gasped. "Mother doesn't make mistakes."

"She doesn't," Nettle agreed. "But she does like her tricks."

Nettle picked up her staff and pushed the doors open. Upon opening the doors, several things happened at once.

The first was a wave of oppressive magic, suffocating Nettle in pressure. The second was Thistle jumping forward, staff in hand with a barrier of her own to protect the two of them.

The third was a sudden wave of heat. Not from in front of them, but from behind.

On reflex, Nettle summoned her own barrier behind them. The two forces pushed the sisters together, ice on one side, fire on the other.

Before being overwhelmed, Nettle tapped deep within and released her magic. She shared her strength with Thistle and amplified their spells, holding back the assault.

A sudden chill came over her.

The fire abated, as did the magical pressure. From where the fire came from, Nettle could see a hole bored through the castle walls. The source was nowhere to be found, but Nettle knew what it meant. Elmond and Elisabeth were buying time with Ashen, but time was not on their side.

"We need to hurry," Nettle walked backward, pushing Thistle inside. They entered the room, Nettle gesturing with her staff to close the doors behind them. "Thistle, what do we do now?"

Thistle didn't answer her.

"Thistle?" Nettle turned, her breath taken away as she saw what Thistle saw.

They were in a large bedroom, the room larger than a house. Ritual implements were everywhere. But at the center of the room, a literal sun. It was the size of a person. If Nettle squinted, maybe there was a person in there.

Surrounding the sun was a thin layer of ice. At four equidistant points around them was four copies an older woman, her hair the color of winter sunshine. Her lips were red, in constant movement. Her eyes were closed, but Nettle knew they were a piercing blue.

From the laugh lines on her face to the way the crows touches her eyes, Nettle saw her mother, unchanged from the day she saw her wreathed in flames.

Nettle took a step forward. Another wave of pressure suffocated her. She dropped to her knees, gasping for air. The pressure abated as swiftly as it came.

The ice around the sun had cracked. Wisps of blue magic whirled around the cracks, slipping into them and repairing the sphere.

"She needs help," Thistle coughed, rubbing her neck. She pushed herself to her feet, grabbing her staff and her own magic swirling around her.

A chill whipped it's way through Nettle

and surrounded Thistle.

"Thistle wait!" Nettle hit Thistle's staff with the butt of her own, breaking her concentration.

The chill stopped, leaving nothing more than a breeze.

"If you don't want my help, then why ask me to come?" Thistle growled towards the circle. "If you can fix this, why leave it as is?" She started to pace the room.

Nettle watched her pace, a little stunned. Gone was the respected Witch of Fall, the woman who Nettle looked up to. Instead of her wise older sister, Nettle watched a daughter sulk in the presence of her mother.

"What now?" Nettle whispered to herself. She watched the sun, circling the main ritual. The ice continued to crack, but she was watching for it now. She shielded herself from the pressure each time it came. Despite Thistle sulking on the other side of the room, Nettle saw her put up her own shields in time with the pressure.

"What's the point?" Nettle asked. She looked at the ritual circle again. Mother and her copies stood at the four cardinal directions. North, South, East, and West. Nettle's eyes were drawn to her sister on the opposite side of the room. On the West side of the room. Nettle darted to her feet, then behind her. She was on the East side of the room.

"Then that would mean-" Nettle approached mother, the one standing at the North.

When Nettle was no more than three steps away, one of mother's eyes opened. Nettle stopped, frozen by her gaze.

One hand struggled to put a finger to Mother's lips, shushing Nettle as the other erratically continued their signs. The ice wobbled, the pressure nearly breaking Nettle's shield. Mother winked with her one eye and closed them again in concentration. With both hands available, the ice smoothed over.

Then the idea struck.

"Thistle, I've got it," Nettle called to her sister. "Can you come here please."

Thistle arched an eyebrow, but approached the ritual. As she tried to skirt the circle to reach her sister, Nettle stopped her.

"Stand there please," Nettle pointed to the eastern clone. Thistle paused, looking at the circles and where Nettle was standing.

Understanding dawned on her face and Thistle took her spot in the east.

Nettle stood beside the clone to the west.

"Mother does need help," Nettle said. "But a very specific kind of help."

"I don't recognize this ritual," Thistle said. "I can't even begin to fathom the machinations of it. Only that it requires four." Her brow furrowed. "No, not that it requires four. It requires us four. A ritual bound by blood." Her eyes darted to her mother to the North.

"One," Nettle pointed at Thistle.

"Two," She pointed at herself.

"Three," Then to her mother.

The fourth was out there, fighting Elmond and Elisabeth and Ashen even as they ponder next steps.

Thistle gasped.

Nettle followed her gaze and something inside her clicked. A person *is* in there.

"Four," Nettle pointed at the sun, at the Witch of Summer, who was encased in that sun. "We need to help."

"We don't know how," Thistle said, but there was agreement in her voice.

"We don't have to know how," Nettle pooled magic within her. "We just need to do."

"We'll be throwing ourselves into a ritual of unknown intention."

"We know the intention," Nettle said. There was a sureness in her statement that surprised her. She kept speaking, the words spilling from her mouth without thought. "Mother is trying to save Ivy."

Out of the corner of her eye, Nettle thought she saw a lip quirk up.

"Save our sister from what?" Thistle asked, but Nettle felt magic pool from her as well.

"Let's find out," Nettle felt her magic flare, her eyes glowing the color of Spring. With her magic, she linked herself to Thistle. Thistle's eyes flared with the color of Fall.

On an unseen count, the two sisters stepped into the ritual circle, replacing the copies of their mother. The copies dissolved into diamond dust, misting their skins.

The ice started to crack, destabilize. They needed to add their strength to the magic and soon.

With an exhale, Nettle linked the two of them to mother.

Nettle wasn't sure what to expect. Cold was expected, for one thing. But what accompanied it was not.

A profound depth. Like being submerged by the ocean and seeing nothing the blackness of water, several thousand fathoms within. Like staring between stars and the darkness consuming all.

Nettle tried to remember the warmth of her mother. She fought every inch of her rising fear.

It was too much. The weight of two thousand years were too much.

One more. A soft voice whispered to her.

Nettle opened her eyes, still engulfed by the depths. Her hands were already making signs in the same way the clones were, their magic adding to the ice.

Thistle was much of the same, though sweat had appeared upon her brow.

Nettle linked to the copy of mother to the south. She didn't get any feedback from it. For a moment, they were in a standstill.

"One more," Nettle repeated. She looked inside the sun. "If I get this wrong..."

You won't. Mother whispered to her again. The depths disappeared and she remembered home. Then, she sent the link into the sun.

Darkness took her. A suffocating black

that drowned. Nettle was dimly aware of Thistle's consciousness somewhere in this darkness. A small dot appeared, a single star.

Ivy, The thought of her eldest sister floated in her mind as Nettle floated in space. She willed herself towards it. Her stomach fluttered as she moved. Her only reference was the star growing larger and larger.

She moved faster towards the star. The sun turned into a star and within seconds, she was engulfed in light.

Nettle fell onto grass. She rolled onto her back and opened her eyes. She was in the middle of a familiar forest, sunlight peaking through leaves. The wind rustled through the forest, pleasant and warm.

It was comfortable to lay here. She must've laid like this before when she was younger.

Footsteps approached her.

Nettle looked up, at an upside down woman in a blue dress strutting towards her. Her blond hair was long, down to her waist. She held an umbrella as she approached, the shadows covering her eyes.

The woman stepped beside Nettle, covering them both in shadows. Her familiar blue eyes seemed to glow.

"Hello mom," Nettle blurted out. Despite not having said the words in ages, they were familiar to her. Even just saying them kindled a warmth in her chest.

The woman smiled in return, warm and inviting.

"Hello, my darling," She crouched beside Nettle's head and brushed the hair

from her face. She raised a hand out, which Nettle took. With strength that surprised Nettle, mother helped her to her feet.

The two witches walked through the forest. Well, one of them walked. Unbeknown to Nettle, she had a spring in her step that made her stride more than a walk. She led the way, not knowing where they were going, but enjoying Mother's company regardless.

"You've done well getting this far," Mother mused, still wearing the same smile. "Was it hard?"

Nettle stopped.

"Hard," Nettle repeated the word, tasting it in her mouth. She looked at mother, the soft smile unchanging. The word tasted bitter. In that moment, she understood Thistle.

"It was hard," Nettle said. The words came out soft. That's how they started. "It was ten or so years of hard. It was ten years of being on my own! It was more than hard!"

Nettle was screaming now, but mother still held that smile.

"It was impossible!" Nettle snarled. "I knew nothing! I knew less than nothing! And I had to stop Ivy on my own? Do you know what mom? I can accept that," Nettle breathed out, then walked towards mother. She stopped shouting, but her voice hardened until it was steel. "I can accept that my mother died to protect us. I can accept my older sister almost died to protect me."

She stood right in from of mother.

"But then people talked about you," Nettle said. "They talked like you were god. Why? If you were alive all this time, why didn't you let us know you were alive? Why didn't you let me know? Surely your daughter deserves that."

The smile never faded, but Nettle no longer felt warmth from her. mother started walked, the shadow cast by the umbrella covering her eyes.

Nettle watched her go, but she stopped a little ways away.

Mother turned her head a little bit to Nettle.

"Ten years?" mother asked. "Has it truly been so long?"

Nettle didn't respond, still snarling.

"I'm sorry, darling," mother apologized. "Do you care for my reasons?"

"No, I expect not," mother walked back to Nettle. She finally closed the umbrella, hanging the tool in the crook of her arm. Though the smile never changed, mother tilted her head in a way that Nettle took as a soft apology. "When you are curious, I will give them to you. But for now, I will tell you what I must. I expect they told you of my feats. Of my strength and my abilities. But they didn't tell you my failures. They didn't tell you my shortcomings or what I've lost."

"Or who you've lost," Nettle spat.

The smile wavered. The wind stopped and the sun disappeared behind clouds.

A long moment sat in the air. Nettle felt very small.

"I'm sorry," mother said again. And like a breath being released, the wind

returned and the sun reappeared. The smile didn't quite return. She turned away and started walking. "I've fought for less. You didn't deserve that."

It was then that Nettle decided to follow her.

"Who was he?" Nettle asked.

"My flesh and blood," mother replied. There was a somberness in her voice.

"We are neither of those things," Nettle said.

"I've lost him to my mistakes," mother led the two of them to a clearing where a cottage resided. Their home. Where the crater was, a small sun. But unlike the sun in the center of the ritual cricle, this one had inky darkness swirling in it. Something about it felt wrong, incorrect, sickening Nettle to her core. "And though you may not believe me, I love all of you as much as I did he. Because of that, I will not lose another child of mine."

"Ivy is in there?" Nettle asked.

"She is," mother said. "Corrupted by the enemy, but she is alive. She is alive because for the many years you fought her body, I was salvaging her mind."

"Is that difficult?" Nettle asked, her voice soft.

"Yes," mother said. The bluntness of it left no room for what Nettle suspected. For anyone else, it would have been impossible.

"Then what now? What changed?"

"You did," the smile returned, though more genuine. "My efforts were on a knife's edge. But your efforts shifted the scales."

"Twenty years against your thousand," Nettle mused.

"It was enough," mother said.

"Thistle wasn't enough?" Nettle idly asked.

"My smartest daughter was recovering until recently," mother chuckled.

"Where is she?"

Mother tilted her head, listening to something in the distance. She pointed the umbrella towards the cottage.

"She's giving me a piece of her mind," mother walked around it and reached the crater.

Nettle stood beside her. The inky darkness captivated her, colors hidden within like a kaleidoscope.

"Mother?"

"Yes, darling?"

"Who is the enemy?"

"My wayward daughter asked me that as well," mother said. "Now look at her."

The ink danced within the light. There was something hypnotic about it, in the endless shapes that it took form in. The longer Nettle stared, she swore she started to hear whispers.

She felt two hands cover her ears. Mother moved behind her, hands soft and gentle.

"The enemy is subtle, everywhere, and everything," mother explained. "The more you know about them, the easier it is for them to corrupt you. That's how they got her. She wanted to fight them with me."

"You can fight them without being corrupted?" Nettle held her mother's hands

and took them away from her ears. "How?"

"Carefully, though many proxies," mother said. "Ivy wasn't ready, but you know how she is."

"Always running ahead," Nettle remembered. "For better or for worse."

After a couple moments of silence, Thistle walked out of the house, the air shimmering around her. Her arm was around the arm of another copy of their mother. The two walked beside Nettle, the copy stepping into themselves so that there was only one. Thistle stood on the opposite side, her eyes tinged red but standing taller.

Mother hooked her arm into Nettle's arm. Her eyes were closed and she breathed deep.

"Shall we save my beloved daughter?" mother finally asked.

In response, Nettle willed her magic forth. In that same moment, the ritual shattered. Her mind was cast back into the castle and all she felt was suffocating heat.

The floor cracked underneath her, then gave way. Then, the world around Nettle slowed. She felt like she was underneath several fathoms of water, each limb heavy and her mind dim.

At the south, mother's clone dissolved into liquid. Drifting from the north at a normal speed, mother herself summoned the umbrella and it turned into a gnarled staff. The staff was like an oak tree in winter, countless branches splitting off of the trunk. Gems and charms adorned each branch, shining with magic inside.

Each movement left echoes as those echoes also started to move to parts unknown. The staff of each echo held less and less branches. Nettle didn't understand the magic being casted, let alone the effects.

Within the sun, also at normal speed, the inky darkness blossomed. It broke through the flaming sun, engulfing the light. Nettle's skin blistered in slow motion.

Then magic pulsed within her, a minty cool that soothed her hurts. The coolness brought life into her mind, the lethargy slipping away.

"The link, daughter," Mother's voice echoed in her mind.

Magic pulsed again and Nettle understood. She pooled her magic within herself. The coolness welled as well, being amplified by her own. Then, she sent the magic out.

The pressure disappeared, as did the slowness. For each pulse of magic she sent through the link, the fire responded in

kind. The darkness didn't completely take over and as long as Nettle had magic to spare it would stay that way.

The darkness shot out of the sun, aiming for the witches in the air. Nettle couldn't track where her sister went. It was all of her skill to fly around and avoid the crashing into other tendrils or even onto the top of the castle.

Nettle felt each pulse of magic in time with the pulse of her body. The rhythm engraved onto her body, she found a pattern in the haphazard attacks of the darkness.

No, it wasn't just a pattern. It was a pattern of endless patterns.

If she could decipher this, maybe she can decipher the enemy. All she needed to do was-

Stone caught her, encasing Nettle in black. In that same moment, the stone crumbled, hit by something as she was sent into a spin.

Thistle appeared and grabbed Nettle out of the spin. The two of them warped and suddenly they were far above the battlefield.

"Don't look too deep," Thistle explained. "That's one of the ways the enemy captures you."

"Where's mom?" Nettle looked around them. In the skies there was the briefest moment of calm. Below them, more magic than what Nettle has ever felt reverberated. "She needs our help."

"We'll only get in the way," Thistle said with a grimace.

Nettle whipped her head towards her

sister. No, that's not what mother thinks. But there was a resignation and a helplessness in Thistle's face.

"No," Nettle shook Thistle off her. "If she didn't need us, she would've solved this a long time ago."

Her pulse quickened.

"Mother is the greatest mage in this millennium," Thistle balled her fist. "No matter what we do, I can't visualize a way to help her without endangering all of us."

"Then I better have enough imagination for both of us," The words had bark in them as something blossomed within her.

Spring. That is what they named her. Understand dawned on her face.

"Follow my lead," Nettle didn't wait for Thistle. She dropped her staff and dove towards the fight.

It all made sense to her why mother was unable to do it alone. Why Thistle couldn't do it either. Why mother held on, but no more.

Because unlike the others, Nettle was an amplifier.

Magic in one hand, her faith in the other. Nettle approached the battlefield. Her pulse pounded in her ears as the wind tore at her clothes.

She slipped back into the fight a rush of cool magic flowing through her. The magic churned within her body, then warmed. Through the link, she sent out the warmed magic. The sun burned brighter.

Nettle fed more magic into it. Earlier, she thought there was a person inside. Now, she caught a glimpse of that person

twitch.

Of course. Mother didn't need to just beat the enemy. She needed to give power for Ivy to fight back. They needed to give Ivy a fighting chance.

With her role established, Nettle flew out to try and meet mother. She needed to help her complete the ritual from earlier.

"We need her body," mother's voice rang out behind her. Nettle looked back and mother flew in Nettle's wake, spells shooting off of her and deflecting the tendrils of ink.

"The form on a rampage," Nettle thought about Elmond and Elisabeth fighting the body with Ashen.

"The very same," mother twirled and swapped places with Nettle, blocking another strike. "Her body also needs her soul. We can burn out the corruption here. The real trick will be cleansing the body before her soul is corrupted."

Thistle dove through the battlefield.

"What's she up to?" Nettle wondered aloud.

"Something clever, no doubt," Mother replied. "Brace yourself."

With that warning, Nettle focused. Then a sudden torrent of ice-cold magic hit her body. If Nettle didn't know it was coming, the sheer suddenness of it would've knocked her out of the air.

Nettle breathed out the cold air, warming the magic within her and amplifying it further. She sent the magic towards Ivy, the sun burning brighter.

"My wards are breached," Mother said.

Suddenly, the darkness flared.

"Nettle!" A familiar voice called out to her.

"From below!" It was paired by a woman's voice.

She risked a glance - hurtling towards them on massive fireball was Elmond and Elisabeth, Commander Nail also hanging on to the fire for dear life.

On reflex, she linked to the twins. After a moment's consideration, she also linked to Nail. They look like they've been through the wringer, but already their wounds started to heal.

"And so Ashen has circumvented my wards, I will have to update them later," Mother mused. "Elohim's blood as well?"

"I have to help them," Nettle said. "They don't have their magic."

"You've performed the rite on them?" Mother asked.

Nettle nodded.

"Then I have misjudged their strength," Mother touched Nettle's shoulder. "Through you, I will grant them a portion of their former strength."

Before Nettle could ask what she meant, crystal clear magic cut through her and entered the twins.

Their eyes widened in surprise, but before they could question further, blackened tendrils flew at them.

On reflex, they summoned ethereal weapons - not as solid as their original magic, but they deflected the enemy just the same.

With added strength, Nail stood on the

fireball and produced a great sword. He stabbed it into the flame and pulled, veering the fireball off in a different direction.

The twins jumped off the fireball and defended it from incoming attacks. Nettle watched until they hit the ground, dodging her own attacks.

Thistle reappeared shortly, carrying pillars of stone.

"Mother, what do we need?" Thistle asked.

"The circle must be complete and the enemy weakened," Mother explained. "Only then can the ritual to separate her soul from the enemy be complete."

"There's more, isn't there," Nettle said.

"Of course there is," Mother said. "We will need the body to also be weakened and cleansed, but that can wait until later."

"The circle is mine," The stones around Thistle broke apart and turned into flexible, thin lines. She flew ahead,

"I'll help Ivy win," Nettle pulled magic into herself.

"Be steadfast," Mother encouraged them both. "I will bear the brunt of the enemy's offense and will support you in yours."

Battle lines renewed, Nettle flew opposite to Thistle. Magic flowed within and without, an aether trail following their flight. Threads unraveled from the trail, magic that attached themselves to stones as they came.

The thin lines of Thistle's stones ripped through the air, cutting the black

tendrils of the enemy without any ill effects. The lines connected, creating several circles around it.

The threads attached to the circles, the stone shining a brilliant blue.

Mother **spoke**. Each word thrummed in the air, suffusing the battlefield with power. The echoes returned. Unlike before, there wasn't any pressure.

No, the pressure was there. But thanks to the magic emanating from Nettle, she couldn't feel it. Not missing a step, Nettle's magic pulled and push. The light pulsed with the magic, but it wasn't any brighter.

Nettle fed more magic in, to no effect.

Mother continued **speaking**. Thistle's circle was almost complete.

The light inside the sun wasn't strong enough. Even with their support, Ivy was losing.

Nettle needed to help her. She needed more.

Nettle glanced at mother. The echoes that surrounded mother gave her an idea.

All of her focused on the link, she needed the link to do more. She split her focus into two. One hand on magic. The other on her thoughts. An echo appeared over her.

She tracked the link connected her to Ivy and after a breath, she added her thoughts to the link.

"Be steadfast," Nettle whispered.

The fire in the sun burned brighter. But only for a moment. The fire went out. The darkness took it. And before Nettle

could sever the link, the enemy rushed
through tried to take her too.

The darkness suffocated her. Then, like she was in the presence of Mysteries, tiny lights appeared like the night sky. But the presence was far more sinister.

All of the lights winked out of existence, then a singular eye opened and looked at her.

Do you want to understand. Words formed in her mind, singular and halting. Each word broke something in her, shattering a lock in in her mind that made it harder to focus.

But without speaking, Nettle refused. She thought of her sisters and of her mother. She thought of her friends, and held strength within herself.

I will make you understand. Information flooded into her. Of endless, irrevocable time. Of vast, infinite space. There was something else there. Something within eternity that begged for understanding.

Even as she tried to fight the tide, her vision fractured. Her mind split, multiple thoughts spilling out at the exact same time.

"Nettle."

She felt an embrace on her consciousness, mending her broken mind.

As her vision returned, Nettle saw the gray and muted body of Ivy hugging her.

"Sister," Ivy said, then the body crumbled into dust.

Nettle's thoughts flew back to her own body as the the link was severed.

She flew backward, trying to gather herself. Though that moment felt like an eternity, hardly any time had passed at

all. But her veins were blackened, marked by the enemy.

As her thoughts still felt like her own, Nettle thought about her sister.

Ivy said sister when she could've said anything else. There was a purpose to that, one that Nettle didn't know yet.

"We're too late," mother said.

Down below, the Witch of Summer exploded in a pillar of fire.

There.

The fragments kept calling her sister. If there was nothing left of Ivy in them, they wouldn't have recognized Nettle after so many years.

Nettle physically grabbed the broken link and dove towards the pillar.

"Nettle!" Thistle called after her, but Nettle was faster.

Just outside of the flame, the twins were supporting each other, their strength spent. Nail was on the floor, unmoving.

Nettle covered herself in magic, pulling the cold in from mother. Without any further delay, Nettle entered the pillar.

The fire burned away at her protections, burned away at the magic. If not for mother supplying an nigh endless amount of magic through the link, she would've been incinerated instantly.

Nettle pushed, the sheer force in the flames fighting against her. The pain stopped.

Nerves are gone, Mother's voice spoke in her mind. Whatever your plan is, you must do it quick.

It was kind of mother to assume that Nettle had a greater plan. There wasn't much thought beyond linking to the body. Still, her burning gut felt like it was the only path left.

She saw the Witch's silhouette. It turned to her. It was flame given form, holding enough magic to obliterate a mountain or a foolish girl. It held a hand out, even more magic forming within it's palm.

It was the smallest of openings, but Nettle will take any she could get.

With a yell, she grabbed onto the palm, linking to the body of Witch of Summer.

"Nettle, no!" Mother's voice split her thoughts, but even she was too slow.

In that single instant, memories flooded into her. Time, space, and eternity. She was back in that darkness, the presence once again bearing down on her.

Nettle looked past that. She thought of her family. She thought of the sun. And in this endless darkness with naught but an enemy longing to be understood, she found a tiny spark that was almost suffocated in this emptiness.

But she found it when none else did. And that was what she linked to.

"I call to you, Ivy. May the harvest of the fall sustain you for the coldness of winter. May your strength be replenished by the coming of spring, so that the fires of summer can burn once more. Arise, Witch of Summer!"

Nettle didn't know where the words came from, only that they came and that each

one thrummed with purpose. The words kindled the spark, igniting it into a flame. And that flame was all Nettle needed to know that her faith was repaid.

The flame burned away the darkness and Nettle was back in her body, blinking away sunspots. The ground rumbled and when Nettle could see again, she was supported by a red-headed woman who glowed with fiery power.

Ivy, the Witch of Summer, glanced down at Nettle. Within the whites of her eyes were miniature suns. She grinned, a mischievous quirk that wasn't as soft as mother's or Thistle's, but warm all the same.

They were encased within an earthen dome, Thistle holding it up. Mother teleported inside, fury in her eyes and **power** in her staff.

The moment mother saw the two of them safe and themselves the fury vanished. She dropped her staff, the **power** disappearing in an instant.

Mother embraced Nettle and Ivy in a hug, collapsing into them as there was no more room for coldness in her heart.

"Mother! It's breaking through!" Thistle called out.

"Hush, daughter," Mother chided. "Time for that in a moment." Even as the dome shuddered, mother picked up Nettle and Ivy and brought them to Thistle, including her in the hug.

The magic within Nettle's chest hummed and harmonized, filling her body with a nostalgic warmth.

Ivy didn't speak, perhaps her body

couldn't, but there was contentment in the way she returned the hug, in the way that her smile picked at the corner of her lips.

But within the link that bound Ivy's thoughts to Nettle's, there was a tinge of regret. Of sadness that glimmered when Ivy finally opened her eyes.

The dome broke. Nettle didn't panic. None of them did. The magic within her welled and was amplified to all of her family.

As the darkness descended, **power** exploded from within them all.

The three daughters took to the air without fear. The darkness of the enemy didn't touch them. Every time it came close, an echo of mother appeared to strike it down.

With Ivy freed of the enemy, mother had no more reason to hold back and it showed. She was a conductor. Magic, her symphony.

Thistle completed the ritual circle once more, all of the darkness coalescing back into a dark sun. The echoes danced around the sun, creating magic circles of their own.

Ivy set the ritual alight, each line on fire and banishing the darkness further.

In this moment, the enemy seemed so small. So afraid.

A hand touched Nettle's shoulder. Mother, not an echo looked over her and shook her head.

"Don't go down that road," Mother said. "Some day, you may travel it. But not today."

Nettle took a deep breath and shook the thoughts from her head. She **spoke**. The words weren't of her own, but of the ritual, bursting out of her as **power** continued to shake the air.

The enemy in the sun warped and pushed against it's bindings.

"I banish you from this existence. Return from whence you came and bother my reality no longer," Mother spoke, her voice soft. "I banish you from the thoughts of my family, foes, and those unknown to me. I banish you."

The magic flared. Darkness lashed and struck, but it was no match for the light of the spell.

"Thrice banished! Said and done!" Mother shouted. Space warped around the enemy and collapsed within itself. In one moment, chaos churned and echoed throughout the battlefield. In the next, silence. The spell completed with no fanfare.

The magic of the ritual faded into the air like stars in the sky. Magic left Nettle as well. She hadn't realized how much of her strength was being amplified by all the magic being thrown around. She wobbled in the sky, trying to keep herself up to no avail.

She fell, but her sisters caught her. Ivy and Thistle both. Mother floated to their side and grabbed all of them into a hug.

"My girls," She whispered. "My darling girls."

"We did it," Nettle slurred her words, halfway to dreaming from exhaustion. She

looked at her mother, who wept, at Thistle, who held a proud, but tired smile. Her gaze brushed over Ivy, who sparkled like the stars. The magic faded from her. It wasn't just magic. "Ivy?"

Nettle reached out to her, but her hand passed through Ivy's arm. She realized that while Thistle and Mother had their arms around them, they weren't holding Ivy.

"What?" Nettle tried to well magic within herself. She needed to relink to Ivy. The magic didn't respond. She had nothing left. "Mother, we need to—" Nettle looked at their mother, who shook her head, small tears running down her cheeks.

"Death is immutable, daughter," she spoke. "And though Ivy's body and soul was in flux, she lost the chance for life a long time ago."

"No!" Nettle tried to revolt, tried to grab onto her sister. "There has to be something we can do!" She tried to scream, but her strength failed her.

"There was," Mother said. "We protected her from the enemy. Where she goes, the enemy cannot follow. For my daughter to be herself at the very end, that is all I can ask for."

"There has to be something," Nettle tried once more to well magic within her. Something deep within responded to her. It hurt like hell, but in that instance, Nettle knew that she could do it.

Ivy caught her gaze and with fading hands, she clasped onto Nettle's. Ivy shook her head.

"*Your soul,*" Ivy whispered.

Nettle could scarcely hear it, the words almost lost like petals in the wind.

"*Thank you,*" Ivy smiled. "*I'm sorry.*"

Ivy was almost gone now.

"*Love you.*"

Then the winds took the rest of her away, the stars fading from the sky.

The Witch of Fall, silent and stoic, guided them back to the ground, where the Essaim twins were waiting. The Commander of Ashen laid there, unmoving.

The Witch of Winter, grieving yet proud, healed Nettle's hurts to where they hurt again, then further still to take the pain away.

The Witch of Spring, distraught and exhausted, lamented her failure, could find no solace in this victory.

The four Witches became three.

The Witch of Summer, no longer.

The old man finished his story, the girl wide-eyed and in bed.

"She died?!" she was slack-jawed and bolted straight to her feet. "That can't be how it ends!"

"Oh there's some other things that happened after that," the old man said. "Some logistics and such, but at it's core, yeah, that's how it ended. Nettle was able to stop the Witch of Summer and something even worse."

"But Nettle couldn't save her sister!" the girl jumped onto her father and pleaded. "There had to have been something else."

"Maybe," the old man gently pushed the girl back onto her bed and shooed her underneath the covers. "There could have been a lot of things. A different choice here, a different outcome there. But that was the way the story was told to me."

The girl frowned, still dissatisfied.

"What would you have changed?" The old man asked her. There was a soft, knowing smile on his lips.

She thought for a moment. She thought for a long moment. "I would've made a magic spell to fix it!"

"Magic is meant to fix things," the old man agreed.

"Yeah! A magic spell to save the Witch of Summer! And then, I would have a spell to fix the castle, another one to heal Nettle," the girl started listing her ideas one after another, endless possibilities on her mind.

The old man watched her go on and on. Death is immutable. That was a spell the

best and brightest couldn't crack. He lived in her reality for a moment. A wonderful world where magic can fix anything and everything.

He touched her head and caressed her hair.

"All good ideas," he said. "But it's getting late. How about we brainstorm a better ending for them tomorrow?"

"Ok!" The girl gave the old man one more hug before settling in for the night.

The old man turned to go.

"Daddy?" The girl called out to him. The old man paused and looked back. She smiled, "I love you!"

The old man smiled back to her, a soft, weary smile. "I love you too, little miss."

He extinguished the lights and under the darkness of night, he returned to his workshop. He sat down and picked up a half-finished carve. It was of another dragon. As he picked up his whittling knife, thoughts ran through his head. It's been a lifetime since he's heard that story for the first time. He wondered if he reacted the same way the girl did.

"I must've," he mused. Then instead of continuing his carve, he stood up and left his workshop.

The old man walked through the house on silent footsteps, picking dusty tomes and sifting through them. Soft starlight danced at the edges of his fingertips, just enough to let him read the words. After some time, he found the tome he was looking for.

He went outside, tome in hand. He went

to the cliff overlooking the ocean, the moon reflected in the crashing waves. Stars dotted the darkness, painted the unknown with colors of all kinds. There, he sat on the edge, legs swinging in air.

The old man leafed through the pages, aided by starlight above and the starlight at his fingertips. As he read the words, the words themselves glowed softly at his touch.

"Spell to preserve life, spell to speak with dead, spell to recover body with soul," he read the names of the spells aloud. This was a tome he received a long time ago, a lifetime ago, much like the story. At the halfway point, the spells were written in his handwriting.

"Reanimate corpse, reverse reanimate corpse," he leafed through the pages faster. He paused at the last page, this one not written in his handwriting. "Raise dead."

But Death is immutable.

"Inadvisable, do not attempt," the old man read the page. "To do so would be to invite weal and woe. There is no magic to bring the dead to life. There is no magic to reverse this reality. If you are reading this, I am sorry."

The old man closed the book and scratched his chin. Of all the magics to fix things, this was something that could never be fixed. It was, by all senses of reality, by design and not broken. He got up, but before he returned to his home, the old man ventured to the forest.

He didn't wander, though to an outside observer it might seem like that. He

crossed streams and ducked under fallen trees. There was a path he followed, one that only he could see. It was well-traveled, a trail that had his footsteps. Eventually, he came across a clearing. At the center, a patch of dirt, disturbed and earthy. The patch surrounded a rock.

As he approached, the glamor in the clearing shifted and changed. The rock wasn't a rock as such. It was a headstone. A headstone with a name on it.

The old man brushed his fingers on the stone, wiping it of dirt, dust, and grime. Once cleaned, he repacked the dirt around it. Once he was satisfied, he stepped back and waved his finger in the air. Grass and flowers reclaimed the dirt and turned the clearing into a meadow.

The old man stood there for a long while, accompanied by the moon, the stars, and a soft wind. He stared at the headstone.

Then, he left. He returned to his home, to the young girl that dreamed of better magic.